



'COURTESY VISIT'
Adani meets Karnataka CM, sets off speculation

STATES » PAGE 6



RHINO HABITAT
SC panel slams Assam govt. for inaction on mining

NEWS » PAGE 14



YANTRA INDIA
BOOSTING CAPABILITIES
India can be a hub for shipbuilding: Rajnath

NEWS » PAGE 12



BETTER LEARNING
Not 'delulu' — an AI tutor for every child
Government can create required infrastructure

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



SHINING BRIGHT
Padikkal hits century as India takes control

SPORT » PAGE 17

IN BRIEF



No new strain of H1N1 identified in India, says ICMR

NEW DELHI
The Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) on Sunday said no new strain of H1N1 has been identified and there is no cause for panic. "The Influenza strains currently circulating are also well matched with the vaccine strains recommended for the Northern Hemisphere," it added. » [Page 14](#)

PM urges space start-ups to make India a talent hub

NEW DELHI
PM Narendra Modi has called upon India's private space sector to build an ecosystem that attracts global talent and makes the country a hub for those seeking to build careers in the sector. » [Page 14](#)

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 2 & 7

U.S. MoU best way out of war, says Iran President

Pezeshkian acknowledges 'many problems' faced by Iranians due to the 'stalled war'; Tehran will follow policies set by its Supreme Leader, he says days after the end of the 60-day period for talks

**Associated Press
TEHRAN**

Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian on Sunday defended a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the United States as the best way out of a stalled war while also acknowledging that his country's citizens face "many problems".

The MoU signed in mid-June opened a 60-day period for talks aimed at ending the war, which began with strikes by the U.S. and Israel on Iran in February, and reaching an accord on Tehran's nuclear programme.

"That period ended last week, but no signs of compromise have emerged, especially on the crucial issue of reopening the Strait of Hormuz, the waterway



vital to global shipping. The Iranian President on Sunday stressed that the MoU was key to move beyond the situation of "neither war nor peace". "There is not a single provision in this agreement that amounts to capitulation," Mr. Pezeshkian said



in a speech published by state-run IRNA. "The Supreme Leader sets the policies, and we will follow that path," he added. Linking the deal to Iran's economic prospects, Mr. Pezeshkian said the country cannot attract investment in this stalled

phase. Nearly six months into the war, Iran's economy is suffering under U.S. sanctions and a naval blockade.

While Mr. Pezeshkian took a diplomatic stand, Mohsen Rezaei, the newly appointed leader of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, appeared more defiant, warning neighbouring countries against supporting Washington's threats to further sanction Tehran.

"If [U.S. President Donald Trump] wants to do something, we will retaliate in a seismic manner," Mr. Rezaei told the state broadcaster in an interview aired on Saturday.

**CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12
'U.S. DESPERATION'
» PAGE 16**

Search continues for 22 from vessel that sunk off Odisha

**Satvasundar Barik
M. Kalyanaraman
BHUBANESWAR/CHENNAI**

The fates of 22 crew members aboard a Panama-flagged bulk carrier that sank in the Bay of Bengal off Odisha remained unknown on Sunday even after 24 hours of intensive search and rescue operations by the Indian Navy and the Indian Coast Guard (ICG).

According to the latest reports from the Navy and the ICG, two Chinese crew members of the ill-fated *M.V. Ocean Winner*, which was carrying iron ore from Odisha, were rescued, even as Navy ships and aircraft continued to search for the remaining crew.

The ship, with 24 crew aboard — 20 from China, three from Myanmar, and one from Bangladesh — had left Paradip Port late on August 20. The ICG said that 36 hours after its departure, the Maritime Rescue Coordination Centre

Stormy voyage

The *MV Ocean Winner* with a 24-member crew had left the Paradip Port in Odisha on August 20

■ The Panama-flagged ship's crew included 20 from China, three from Myanmar, and one from Bangladesh

■ The ship, built in 1998, has changed hands many times and its current owners are located in Fujian, China

■ During the last inspection of the ship in June, Bangladesh authorities reported three deficiencies, including in its magnetic compass



Last leg: The 28-year-old bulk carrier can haul a cargo of around 73,000 tonnes and was in its end-of-life period. FILE PHOTO

received information that communication with the vessel had been lost. It also received a request for a search and rescue operation.

The Eastern Naval Command said on X that it responded to the distress alert by deploying the PSL surveillance aircraft in coordination with MRCC, Sri Vijaya Puram. "The Indian Navy aircraft located a geographically dispersed liferaft in the area and soon

coordinated with *MT Aisopos*, which was transiting nearby, with a request for the merchant vessel to render assistance. By late evening on August 22, *MT Aisopos* had rescued two of the 24 crew members from the liferafts," the Navy said. The Navy said it continues to coordinate with the ICG in the operation to find the remaining crew.

**CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12**

Onam essentials



Festive icon: Pyramid-shaped Onathappan structures on display for sale in Thirupunithura, Kerala, on Sunday. Made of clay or mud, the structures represent Vamana, a reincarnation of Lord Vishnu, and Mahabali, the asura king, and are a key part of Onam. THULASI KAKKAT

Congress highlights 'abnormal' delay in Lok Sabha prorogation

**The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI**

Flagging a 10-day delay in proroguing the Lok Sabha after it was adjourned *sine die* on August 13, in accordance with the schedule of the Monsoon Session of Parliament, Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh on Sunday asked whether the "abnormal" time gap was an indication of the Centre's efforts to cobble together the necessary numbers to clear the Bill on delimitation.

Normal practice
Under normal parliamentary practice, "the time gap between the adjournment of the Lok Sabha *sine*

Is the Union Home Minister still in search of 2/3rd majority to get the Constitutional Amendment Bill on Delimitation passed in a Special Session?

JAIRAM RAMESH
Congress general secretary (communications)

die and its prorogation is generally two to four days", Mr. Ramesh said in a social media post.

He also posted a photograph of a page from *Practice and Procedure of Parliament* by M.N. Kaul and S.L. Shukder, which un-

derscored that prorogation, not adjournment, formally closes a session and clears the way for the next one to be convened.

The gap has occasionally run longer, including 28 days during the Monsoon Session of 2015, and 20 days in 2021, however, "there were no diabolical moves afoot then," Mr. Ramesh said.

"What explains the abnormal delay now? Is the Union Home Minister still in search of his *bahukalki* (tarnished) 2/3rd majority to get the constitutional amendment Bill on delimitation passed in a special session?" he said.

**CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12**

Doval heads to China with an eye on Xi Jinping's visit

**Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING**

National Security Adviser Ajit Doval is expected to visit Beijing on Monday and Tuesday for the 25th round of talks between the Special Representatives (SRs) on the boundary question, and ahead of a possible visit to India next month by Chinese President Xi Jinping. Mr. Doval's visit and talks with Chinese Politburo member and Foreign Minister Wang Yi will also take stock of the broader bilateral relationship.

Sept. 12 BRICS Summit

That the visit is taking place a few weeks before India's hosting of the BRICS Summit on September 12 is an indication that both sides are preparing for a first visit by Mr. Xi in seven years, which would also likely include talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

A meeting between the two leaders in October 2024 on the sidelines of the BRICS summit in Kazan, Russia paved the way for what both sides see as a gradual and steady normalisation in relations. Mr. Modi and Mr. Xi last met in August last year.

During the meeting that took place at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit in Tianjin, China, both leaders "welcomed the positive momentum and steady progress in bilateral relations" and "reaffirmed that the two countries were development partners and not rivals, and that their differences should not turn into disputes."

**CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12**



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BREZZA



States

IN BRIEF



3 complaints against Assam BJP MLA over 'threat to Gogoi'

Three police complaints have been filed against Assam BJP MLA Mayur Borgohain for allegedly threatening Rajior Dal president Akhil Gogoi with physical assault, the police said on Sunday. The complaints were filed at the Sivasagar Sadar police station by people associated with Mr. Gogoi, the police said. "Two separate complaints were filed by Chandwip Gogoi and Biswa Das, both associated with the Rajior Dal. Another was filed by Krishak Mukti Sangram Samiti leader Bidyut Saikia," a senior police officer said. [PH](#)

5-year-old mauled by stray dog in Kota; CCTV captures attack

A five-year-old girl was severely injured after being attacked by a stray dog in the Bengali Colony in Kota, Rajasthan, said officials from the Kota Municipal Corporation. The attack took place at 7.15 p.m. on Saturday when the girl was playing in a lane outside her house. CCTV footage of the incident shows the child being dragged by the dog and mauled in the street before residents intervened to rescue her. According to civic authorities, they are taking measures to address the stray dog problem in the city, including the construction of the State's first-ever dog shelter specifically for strays. [PH](#)

Rahul's Pune event a comedy show: BJP; ruling party stung by his youth appeal: Congress

Political rhetoric delivered to a manufactured crowd, says Maharashtra BJP vice-president; Cong. national secretary says BJP losing sleep over 'unprecedented response' to 'Chhatron ki Goonj' event

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI/NAGPUR

A day after Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's "Chhatron ki Goonj" address in Pune, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday hit out at the Leader of the Opposition (LoP) in the Lok Sabha, terming his event a "political comedy show".

'Real concerns ignored'
In a release, BJP Maharashtra vice-president Keshav Upadhye stated that Mr. Gandhi had delivered generic political rhetoric instead of addressing genuine concerns. He also claimed that the attendees were ferried in college buses to "manufacture" a crowd. "His Pune event was yet another political comedy show," he added.

The Congress hit back, saying the BJP was "rattled" by the Opposition leader's "growing appeal among youth".

During his hour-long ad-



Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnis with cricketer Tilak Varma and others at the 'Manthan 4 Yuva - Nagpur 2026' event on Sunday. [PH](#)

dress on Saturday evening, Mr. Gandhi urged Gen Z women to "smash" the patriarchy. "Be loud, be proud and fight for your place in society," he said, holding the BJP leadership responsible for the "return of the Manusmriti".

Clear hypocrisy: CM

Following Mr. Upadhye's statement, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis also trained his guns on the Lok

Mr. Fadnis said.

"Their job is just to make speeches every day and stay relevant through television. That's all they do. They have lost touch with the ground. This party is limited to merely issuing statements," he said.

'Youth prospects hit'

Congress national secretary Sachin Sawant said the BJP had lost sleep over the "unprecedented response" to Mr. Gandhi's interaction despite the "logistical hurdles" placed by the State authorities.

"Perhaps the Chief Minister will tell them [youth] about the importance of the Manusmriti; that the patriarchal system is good; and that the RSS and the VHP decide what women should wear, say and how they should behave," Mr. Sawant said.

He alleged that the ruling Mahayuti alliance had systematically undermined prospects of the youth in Maharashtra.

U.P. Speaker leaves dais during National Anthem, draws flak

Press Trust of India
UNNAO(U.P.)

Uttar Pradesh Assembly Speaker Satish Mahana has found himself at the centre of a controversy after he was seen walking away while the National Anthem was being played at an event here, drawing flak from the Opposition.



Satish Mahana

Mahana's claim

Mr. Mahana, however, claimed that the National Anthem was not played where he was given the guard of honour.

A purported video of the incident shows the Speaker staying still for a few seconds, then turning around and stepping down from the saluting dais while the National Anthem was being played at the principals' council event held on Saturday.

Some supporters standing nearby then approached him and were seen touching his feet. The National Anthem continued to play as Mr. Mahana proceeded towards his vehicle and left the venue.

Unnao Congress Committee leader Dinesh Shukla asked if the Speaker ac-

cepting the guard of honour as per protocol, but leaving the spot while the National Anthem was being played, amounted to an insult to the anthem.

'Not paying attention'

"Now what will the BJP, which gives a certificate to everyone, say about him?" said Samajwadi Party spokesperson Anurag Bhaduria. Another party spokesperson, Manoj Yadav, said Mr. Mahana took the salute, turned around, and walked away in a "left-right (marching)" manner.

It appeared that Mr. Mahana was neither paying attention to the National Anthem nor to the situation around him, Mr. Yadav said, accusing the BJP of adopting "double standards" on nationalism.

BJP to lay siege to Assembly today seeking Karnataka Minister's exit

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU



Leader of Opposition R. Ashok

Stepping up its protest demanding the resignation of Minister B. Nagendra, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has decided to lay siege to the State Assembly, Vidhana Soudha, in Karnataka on Monday.

Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly R. Ashok said on Sunday that the BJP members will take out a protest march from Freedom Park before laying siege to the Vidhana

Soudha. The BJP has been protesting in the Assembly demanding the resignation of Mr. Nagendra, who has been chargesheeted in the case of alleged embezzlement of funds meant for ST communities. The party

will continue its protest inside the House, he said.

Janata Dal (Secular) leader and Union Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy had expressed a view that the protest should continue in the ongoing Assembly session, Mr. Ashok said.

Meanwhile, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said: "There is provision to protest within the framework of the law. Today, they are resorting to *goondaism*. Without giving any notice, they are ruining the Assembly proceedings."

Paper photographed mid-test; five arrested

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Five persons were arrested in Maharashtra's Parbhani after an exam supervisor allegedly clicked a photograph of a question paper on her mobile phone at a nursing school and sent it to her sister, the police said on Sunday.

The alleged malpractice occurred minutes into the exam of the first-year General Nursing and Midwifery course at the Indira Gandhi A.N.M. Nursing School on

Friday, an official said. It came to light during an inspection by central inspectors, the official added.

The police arrested the accused, Rakhi Chavan, her sister Rani Chavan, and three others in connection with the incident.

FIR lodged

Based on a police complaint lodged by a central inspector, a case was registered against the five persons under the Maharashtra Examination Act, the official said.

Amid Assembly row, BJP leaders sing Vande Mataram in Shimla

Press Trust of India
SHIMLA

BJP leaders and hundreds of party workers on Sunday sang *Vande Mataram* at the Ridge in Shimla, protesting against the Congress government over a row surrounding the National Song in the Himachal Pradesh Assembly.

Leader of the Opposition Jai Ram Thakur said the BJP had demanded that the complete *Vande Mataram* be sung in the Assembly with due respect. He al-



Himachal LoJ Jai Ram Thakur, along with BJP workers, singing the National Song during a protest at the Ridge, Shimla, on Sunday. [ANI](#)

leged that the song initially figured in the proposed business but was removed before the proceedings be-

gan. The House was adjourned on the first two days of the Monsoon Session over the issue.

SPOTLIGHT

Satyasundar Barik

In the second week of August, former Odisha Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik wrote to Chief Minister Mohan Charan Mahi urging him to convene a special session of the State Legislative Assembly.

The immediate trigger was the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) (MMDR) Amendment Bill, 2026, which was passed by both Houses of Parliament on August 13. It became an Act after it got the assent of President Droupadi Murmu.

According to the Ministry of Mines' 2024-25 annual report, mineral production (excluding Atomic, Fuel and Minor Minerals) was estimated in 20 States, of which about 97.70% of the total value was confined to eight States.

Odisha accounted for the largest share, at 43.49%, followed by Rajasthan (16.26%), Chhattisgarh (13.69%), Karnataka (12.42%), Maharashtra (4.76%), Jharkhand (3.26%), Madhya Pradesh (2.78%) and Andhra Pradesh (2.30%).

The MMDR Act states its objective: "extraction and management have to be guided by long-term national goals". It also cites heavy and non-uniform taxes as adversely affecting mineral production. Under the MMDR Act, "the Union

will take under its control the regulation of mineral-bearing lands". It also provides that "no tax, cess or other such levy (by whatever name called) shall be imposed by the State government on mineral rights or mineral-bearing lands".

In its press release, the Central government stated, "The amendment... will not take away any of the rights of the States on land and minerals or any tax on minerals collected by the States." It also stated the amendment will not impact minor minerals.

Several stakeholders in Odisha, however, feel that they could significantly erode the State's authority over its mineral resources and adversely affect its fiscal interests. This is not just about mining policy or government revenue, but also about the people, mostly tribals, who have been living with the environmental and social costs of mining for generations.

People impacted

In Ransol village, in Odisha's Jajpur district, Ishwar Chandra Mohanta is battling cancer. He does not know how he developed the disease. However, Mohanta claims seven other people from his village have already died of cancer. His home lies in the Sukinda valley, which contains 98% of India's chromite resources.

The first chromite mine near his village was suspended in 2000, but for people like Mohanta, the

Digging for gold

Parliament passed the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, which put the extraction and management of minerals in the hands of the Central government. Many in Odisha fear that the new law will impact the State's fiscal health



In Jajpur's Sukinda valley, residents say monsoon run-off from mines turns the area red. [BSIRWANJAN ROUT](#)

consequences of decades of mining have not disappeared with the closure of a mine. Chromite mines are a source of dangerous hexavalent chromium pollution that has carcinogenic effects. While the State's vast reserves of iron ore, coal, chromite, and other minerals have attracted industries and generated enormous revenues, communities living around mining belts have often borne the environmental and health burdens.

Their grievances have traditionally been directed at the State government, which remains accountable to them for regulation,

rehabilitation, environmental protection, and local development. The concern now is that the MMDR amendment could create a situation in which that accountability is blurred.

Patnaik says, "If the Central government takes away the State's authority over mineral-bearing lands and its right to levy cesses, only pollution, displacement, and the burden of mining will remain with Odisha."

What the tweak means

The MMDR Amendment Act, 2026 is an amendment to the 1957 Act. Section 2 now provides that

the phrase "regulation of mines" will be followed by "and mineral-bearing land".

"By insertion of 'mineral bearing land', the Union government has expanded its control over larger areas. It is tampering with the State's power. Land is a subject which is on the State List," says Umesh Jena, former Additional Director of Mines, who has over 30 years of experience in dealing with regulation pertaining to mining.

Umesh says the insertion of Section 9D has two implications: it prohibits States from earning from

new taxes, and also stops States from collecting taxes due through court orders.

The immediate repercussion for Odisha is the loss of thousands of crores in penalties. In 2021-22, the State had imposed a ₹22,000 crore penalty on different miners for excess mining in violation of environmental clearance.

"The State had collected ₹16,000 crore from defaulting lessees before my retirement. Still, a large chunk is left to be collected. This will not come to the State's exchequer because of the amendment," says Umesh.

In a statement accompanying the Act, justifying the amendment, G. Kishan Reddy, Union Minister of Coal and Mines, says, "Unbalanced imposition of steep taxes and levies will prompt the industry to completely bypass local supply lines, leading to sub-optimal development of markets, increased transportation costs and the resultant pollution load."

In 2004, the Odisha government had enacted the Odisha Rural Infrastructure and Socio Economic Development (ORISED) Act. This was challenged by miners in the Orissa High Court. The High Court subsequently struck down the law. The State government took the fight to the Supreme Court. Now, the Odisha government's two-decade-long efforts to tax miners have come to an end. The taxes raised under ORISED were meant

to benefit mining-affected areas and communities through spending on infrastructure, education and employment.

Srikant, the former Union Minister, asserts that following the Supreme Court judgment, Odisha stood to reclaim over ₹1 lakh crore in retrospective dues since 2005, which it could have collected from April 1, 2026. Besides, the State would have earned ₹50,000 crore annually through the cess on future mining operations, he says. The State has, however, not officially estimated the extent of potential loss.

A mineral powerhouse
The scale of Odisha's mineral resources explains why the amendment has triggered such strong apprehension in the State.

According to the Ministry of Mines' 2024-25 report, the State produced minerals valued at ₹67,955.89 crore, the highest among Indian States. Mining accounted for 37.59% of Odisha's total projected State revenue in 2026-27.

In the aftermath of the MMDR Act, the possibility of losing such a substantial amount of potential revenue is a matter of serious concern for Odisha's economic interests," says Suresh Panigrahi, State secretary of the CPI(M).

The economic debate also has a human dimension. Environmentalist Prafulla Samantara points out that much of Odisha's mineral-

bearing land is inhabited by tribal communities, many of whom continue to remain poor despite living amid some of the country's richest mineral deposits.

"In one stroke, the Centre has taken away the State's ability to design welfare programmes for these tribal communities," alleges Samantara, a recipient of the Goldman Environmental Prize, an international award honouring those working at the grassroots.

Political tensions rise

Opposition parties alleged that the Bharatiya Janata Party's MPs did not raise their voices against the amendment in Parliament. "It is clear that the main objective of this amendment is to centralise powers," Odisha Pradesh Congress Committee president Bhakta Charan Das alleges.

Social media platforms, meanwhile, have been flooded with reactions from political parties and civil society groups, with voices across the spectrum demanding that the Mahi government clarify its position and explain how it proposes to protect the State's fiscal and constitutional interests.

Despite repeated attempts to contact State Steel and Mines Minister Bibhuti Bhushan Jena and Steel and Mines Secretary Deorajan Kumar Singh for comment, they were unavailable.

satyasundar.b@thehindu.co.in

States

IN BRIEF



Shah meets Indian mixed disability men's cricket team

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday met the Indian mixed disability men's cricket team in New Delhi after their successful tour of England for the seven-match T20I series. "Their efforts and determination to win honours for the nation inspire the youth of India. Wished them all the best for their future endeavours," Mr. Shah said in a post on X. The Indian team had clinched the closely fought India-England Men's Mixed Disability T20I Series 2026 held from August 5 to 19 by a margin of 4-3. [ANI](#)

SFI forms 84-member panel for upcoming DUSU election

The Students' Federation of India (SFI) has formed an 84-member election committee and launched its 'Dream DU of Daffi Gang' campaign to outline the organisation's strategy for the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) election scheduled for September 18, it stated in a release on Sunday. The members elected to the panel include Sooraj Elamon (chairperson), Nadia (convener), Mehina Fathima (vice-chairperson), and Noel Benny (co-convener). [PTI](#)

Live worm found in food at Gurugram restaurant

A live worm was allegedly found crawling in food served at a restaurant in Gurugram, raising concerns over hygiene standards after a video of the incident went viral on social media. The incident occurred around 11 a.m. on Sunday when customer Sulabh Mathur visited the outlet for breakfast. He recorded a video of the food and shared it online. A senior officer of the Food and Supplies Department said the department is looking into the matter. [PTI](#)

15-year-old falls into open drain in south-east Delhi; search under way

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

A 15-year-old boy went missing after allegedly falling into an open drain while trying to retrieve a kite in south-east Delhi's Jasola village, prompting a multi-agency search operation, officials said on Sunday.

According to an official, the incident took place around 11 a.m. on Saturday when Mithun, a Class 8 student, was trying to catch a kite near the open drain.

A police officer said another boy, who witnessed the incident, alerted the family following which the matter was reported to the authorities.



Multiple rescue teams deployed in Jasola on Sunday looking for the Class 8 student who fell into an open drain on Saturday. [PTI](#)

Police and rescue teams, including personnel from the Delhi Fire Services and the National Disaster Response Force, launched a search operation. Divers searched the area for several hours on

13,433 UG seats still vacant, DU offers spot admissions

North Campus colleges such as St. Stephen's, Hindu among those with unfilled seats for BA, BSc (Hons.), BA (programme); most vacant seats are for BA (Hons.) courses in Sanskrit, Tamil, Bengali

Jaideep Deo Bhani
NEW DELHI

After multiple rounds of admissions, Delhi University on Sunday announced that 13,433 undergraduate (UG) seats for the current academic session are still vacant. It has invited students to participate in a spot admission round to fill these on the Common Seat Allocation System portal.

The university has approximately 71,600 UG seats. Aspirants are required to apply for admission on the basis of their Common University Entrance Test scores.

The first round of seat allocation began on July 16, and the academic session commenced on July 28. On Sunday, as of 1 p.m., the list of vacant seats showed that there were 2,113 available in the general category; 4,133 in the Other Backward Classes-Non-Creamy



Delhi University has nearly 71,600 undergraduate seats and admission is based on the CUET score. [FILE PHOTO](#)

Layer category; 2,038 in the Scheduled Caste category; 2,476 in the Scheduled Tribes category; 1,791 in the Economically Weaker Section; 566 in the Sikh minorities category; and 316 in the Christian minorities category.

Seats in BA and BSc (Hons.) programmes, including those in science subjects and languages, in BA (programme) remain unfilled in sought-after

North Campus institutions, including St. Stephen's College, Hindu College, Hansraj College and Kirori Mal College.

Most of the vacant seats are for BA (Hons.) courses in Sanskrit, Tamil and Bengali, said Haneeet Gandhi, the Dean of Admissions at DU. "The spot admission round has been announced on schedule, and we hope to fill all the remaining seats," she said.

The number of seats vacant at the end of the admission process comes after an overwhelming response initially, with over 1.9 lakh students registering for admission to UG programmes.

CBSE route

The university has also introduced UG admission based on Class 12 Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) scores. On August 20, it released a list of 11 colleges that had vacant seats, where admission could be secured through based on CBSE results. Four more colleges were added to the list on August 21. The list was further expanded on Sunday, and prominent institutions, including Indraprastha College for Women and Gargi College, have commenced admissions to the BA (Hons.) Sanskrit programme based on the CBSE results.

JNUSU stages protest outside IIT Delhi over MSc student's death

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Jawaharlal Nehru University Students' Union (JNUSU) on Sunday organised a protest outside the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Delhi demanding accountability from the institute a day after a 31-year-old second-year MSc student allegedly died by suicide on campus.

'Institutional apathy'

The protesting students blamed "institutional apathy", saying this was the second student death at IIT Delhi this year. They urged the institute to address what they described as "a far longer pattern of student deaths that it has failed to confront".

JNUSU president Aditi said: "We demand the implementation of the Rohith Act so that students who enter institutes as bright young minds are not suddenly told that they are not meritorious enough and have to deal with pressure

from the administration. It is not just IIT Delhi. We will raise our voices across campuses."

The All India Students' Association also issued a statement demanding a probe into the death.

After the incident, IIT Delhi issued a release stating: "The institute deeply mourns the tragic and untimely demise of an MSc student on August 22. The Delhi police are investigating the incident. Our deepest thoughts and prayers are with the bereaved family. The institute is providing all support to them."

The students alleged that the institute's response to such incidents followed a familiar script. "Reduce every death to individual mental illness, issue a condolence e-mail, and move on - while the structural conditions that produce this suffering go unexamined," a student said.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 1416 to seek help)

Paper leak confirmed, Raipur varsity cancels BSc exam

Press Trust of India
RAIPUR

Indira Gandhi Krishi Vishwavidyalaya, Raipur, has cancelled the BSc Agriculture first-year plant pathology exam held on Sunday after a police probe confirmed that the question paper had been leaked, of

ficials said on Sunday.

The cancellation follows the August 20 leak of the second-year entomology paper, which led to the arrest of a professor and five students of a private college in Durg district. The police probe later found that the Plant Pathology paper was also leaked.

The university has issued a notice to the Bharatiya Agricultural College, Durg, for allegedly failing to ensure exam confidentiality. Show cause notices have also been issued to university-appointed observers for both exams.

"Strict disciplinary action will also be taken

against students of the college detained by Raipur Police in connection with the August 20 paper leak," officials said.

Security measures

Following the August 20 leak, question papers for the August 22 BSc exam were sent to colleges

through password-protected e-mail instead of physical copies. The same system will be followed for Monday's exams. The university will install more CCTV cameras in its exam department and affiliated colleges and explore modern technology to strengthen security, officials said.

3 policemen attacked with bricks in Delhi; probe ordered

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Three Delhi Police personnel were injured after a group allegedly attacked them with chilli powder, bricks and sticks in Mukundpur's Janta Vihar, an officer said on Sunday.

Head constables Dinesh and Rajesh of the Bhalswa Dairy police station were attacked on Saturday at 3.30 p.m. They were returning to their beat after taking a motorcycle without valid documents to the police station under the Delhi Police Act. "Head Constable Tinnu, who came to assist them, was also assaulted. Dinesh suffered a head injury. All three are stable," the officer said.

The police have apprehended a 17-year-old while search for the others is on. A case has been registered under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the investigation is under way.

The main accused, Sunil, has five criminal cases registered against him, including two under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act.

Govt. eyeing inter-State transfer of high-risk prisoners, undertrial gangsters: Delhi CM

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi government has drawn up a plan to transfer undertrial gangsters, organised criminals and other high-risk prisoners lodged in its jails to prisons in other States, saying the move would help curb organised crime and strengthen prison security, the Chief Minister's Office (CMO) stated in an official release on Sunday.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta cited the presence of "hardened criminals" in prisons as a security concern.

According to the statement, the government



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the presence of hardened criminals in Delhi poses a security concern. [FILE PHOTO](#)

proposes to implement the Transfer of Prisoners (Punjab Amendment) Act, 2025 in Delhi to enable the inter-State transfer of such prisoners.

Under the proposed

system, undertrial gangsters and other high-risk prisoners could be shifted from one State to another with the mutual consent of the States concerned or the approval of the Ministry of Home Affairs.

Gap in framework

The proposal seeks to address a gap in the existing legal framework. The Transfer of Prisoners Act, 1950 provides for the inter-State transfer of convicted prisoners but not undertrials, whose custody is governed by remand warrants issued by trial courts. The Prisons Act, 1900 permits transfers only within a State.

According to the government, there are 188 members of 26 identified gangs in Delhi, of whom 107 have been arrested, as of May this year.

The statement mentioned that some hardened undertrials continue to be involved in targeted killings, extortion, threats and criminal conspiracies from custody. They allegedly sought to influence witnesses and expand their networks.

The government stated that transferring them outside the national capital could limit their access to local criminal networks and reduce interference with trial proceedings.

DDA plans over 20 meetings on master plan implementation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) plans to hold more than 20 meetings with stakeholders over the next three months to discuss the implementation of the Master Plan for Delhi-2047, the urban body stated in an official release on Sunday.

The meetings will involve MPs and MLAs, government agencies, industry bodies, architects and planners. Residents' welfare associations (RWAs), landowners, educational institutions and healthcare organisations will also participate. The DDA, on the directions of Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, will discuss major provisions of the master plan, including transi-

oriented development, high-density corridors, land pooling policy and low-density areas.

Meetings with RWAs, group housing societies and co-operative housing societies will also cover housing and redevelopment, the authority stated. Industry bodies and chambers will also be consulted on industrial development and the availability of land for industry.

Other meetings will focus on mobility and congestion, as well as the rejuvenation of the Yamuna river. Heritage conservation and redevelopment of commercial areas will also be discussed.

Meetings will also be held regarding the development of education and healthcare hubs such as Narela and Dwarka.

Beyond the gates: how ex-inmates rebuilt their lives after prison

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

When Lakshman (name changed on request), 28, walked out of prison after seven years, one of the first things he had to learn was how to use a smartphone.

WhatsApp, digital payments and the many everyday functions of a phone were unfamiliar to him. "I felt like I was a decade behind the world," he said.

His experience captures a less visible consequence of imprisonment: a sentence may end on paper, but reintegration can take much longer. For many former prisoners, education has offered a way to rebuild their lives after release.

Mr. Lakshman was convicted in a murder case in 2015 and remained in Tihar prison until 2022. His father had died in 2013 and his family was already struggling financially. In prison, he began working

in the canteen, earning ₹85 a day after six months, and started sending part of his earnings home to support his sister.

The years in prison exposed him to the psychological toll of incarceration. He saw fellow prisoners die by suicide and said the loneliness of the night could make it difficult to process emotions. "The thought crossed my mind too," he said, but work and education helped him stay focused.

He completed Class 12 and began pursuing a BA while in prison. When he learnt about BetterLife Prison School, a programme offering functional literacy and foundational education, he enrolled there as well. Today, Mr. Lakshman works as a field lead with Project Second Chance, an initiative of the TYCIA Foundation focused on education, mental health support, life skills and legal assistance for prisoners.



Inmates receiving education at the BetterLife Prison School inside the Tihar Central Jail in New Delhi. [SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT](#)

"My life's purpose changed. I dreamt of becoming a police officer or joining the Army, but after my jail term, I wanted to become a social worker. I don't want anyone to face what I faced," he said.

A sister's promise

For Karan Kumar, 27, education became a way to rebuild his life after prison. He was 18 and preparing for his Class 12 examination while pursuing a course in graphic and 3D animation when a fight assistance for prisoners.

school left another boy seriously injured. Karan was sent to Tihar in connection with the case in June 2017. The boy later succumbed to his injuries, and Karan remained in prison until his release in April 2025, though he was granted short periods of bail, including during the COVID-19 pandemic. His case is currently closed, with no court dates pending.

During his first Raksha Bandhan in prison, Mr. Kumar's sister told him she would become a lawyer so she could help people like

her brother. Her remark became a turning point for him. "If my sister can be so affected by my experience and make it into something positive, why can't I?" Mr. Kumar said.

In 2018, he completed Class 12 and subsequently pursued a BA from Delhi University alongside a Bachelor of Social Work. He also worked with the prison legal cell, where he learnt to draft bail petitions and RTI replies and underwent paralegal volunteer training. Today, he works with the Kunji Helpline and Project ALT (Access to Legal Aid Through Tech), providing legal support to inmates and their families.

A second life

For Jeevan Waghmare, 44, education became the bridge from prison to a career helping others navigate the legal system.

Sentenced to life imprisonment in 2005 along with five other members of

his family following a murder arising from a property dispute, Mr. Waghmare resumed his studies in prison. He completed a BA in history, followed by postgraduate degrees in sociology and history through Maharashtra's prison distance-learning programme, and a postgraduate diploma in human rights from the Indian Institute of Human Rights in New Delhi.

After his release in 2022, he became a practising lawyer, assisting prisoners in navigating the legal system. Mr. Waghmare said his experience convinced him that prisons need to give greater emphasis to education, mental health support, skills and post-release assistance. "Once a person realises that they made a mistake, at least 80-90% want to improve themselves. But we continue to treat them as criminals, and then change becomes hard to achieve."

States



N. Ram, Director, The Hindu Group; Pratik Sinha, founder, Alt News; Syeda Faiza, digital editor, The Siasat Daily; and moderator Uma Sudhir in Hyderabad on Sunday. NAGARA GOPAL

Original reporting is key to restoring trust in media, says N. Ram

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

N. Ram, eminent journalist and Director of The Hindu Group, has called for a return to the fundamentals of journalism, including ground reporting, investigative journalism, long-form journalism and explanatory writing, to help the media regain public trust.

Mr. Ram also called for media literacy to be introduced in school curricula to help students understand and critically evaluate news and information.

Speaking at a panel discussion at the National Conclave of the Federation of Press Clubs in Hyderabad on Sunday, Mr. Ram stressed the need for transparent codes of conduct for journalists, independent self-regulation, and a statutory framework for regulation.

"I think it really helps to build trust. Then it comes to self-regulation for the whole industry," he said.

Mr. Ram said self-regulatory mechanisms should

comprise journalists and respected media personalities. He also suggested that codes of conduct should have the backing of legislation enacted by Parliament.

"Investigative journalism is forte of print journalism. Long-form writing, data reporting and explanatory reports could help the print media strengthen its credibility," he said.

Mr. Ram also expressed concern over the impact of media ownership on journalistic standards and advocated reader-funded models of journalism. He cited successful news platforms, including Alt News and The Wire, as examples of alternative models.

Another panellist, Pratik Sinha, the co-founder and editor at Alt News, also stressed the need to develop new economic models for journalism.

Digital Desk Editor of The Siasat Daily, Syeda Faiza Kirmani, said print media continued to play an important role by providing in-depth and accurate information.

Adani calls on Karnataka CM, sparks political speculation

Shivakumar terms meeting a courtesy visit; Opposition leader R. Ashok takes a dig at Congress; Adani Group is the lowest bidder for Bengaluru's North-South twin tube tunnel road project

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

A meeting between Adani Group chairman Gautam Adani and Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar here on Sunday set off speculation in political circles. While the Chief Minister termed it a courtesy visit, the Adani Group is an interested bidder in the tunnel road project in Bengaluru being pushed by Mr. Shivakumar.

Government sources said the meeting was unscheduled, and that Mr. Adani, who was attending a private function in Bengaluru South was on his way to the airport, when

Rahul Gandhi has called Mr. Adani a BJP agent. However, the Karnataka government has rolled out a red carpet for Mr. Adani. Have the [Central] Congress leaders given permission for this? So, let them advise Mr. Gandhi properly

R. ASHOK
Karnataka Opposition leader



he dropped in at the Chief Minister's residence.

Incidentally, the Adani Group has emerged as the lowest bidder for the 7.1-km Bengaluru North-South twin tube tunnel road project, estimated to cost around ₹17,000 crore.

Of the total cost of the

project that has been proposed on a the build-operate-transfer (BOT) model, the government is expected to invest 40% through viability gap funding, financed by a loan from the Housing and Urban Development Corporation (HUDCO). The Adani

Group is learnt to have quoted just above ₹22,000 crore for the project.

Taking a dig at the Congress, Leader of Opposition in the Assembly R. Ashok said: "[Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha] Rahul Gandhi has called Mr. Adani a BJP agent. However, the Karnataka government has rolled out a red carpet for Mr. Adani. Have the [Central] Congress leaders given permission for this? So, let them advise Mr. Gandhi properly."

'Courtesy visit'

Mr. Shivakumar told reporters here: "Mr. Adani paid a courtesy visit after I became the Chief Minister."

Pinarayi accuses UDF govt. of yielding to BJP, RSS on Waqf law

The Hindu Bureau
MALAPPURAM

Keralam's Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan has accused the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government of surrendering to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Sangh Parivar on issues including the Waqf law.

Inaugurating a seminar on "Waqf law and UDF surrender" organised by the Communist Party of India

(Marxist) here on Sunday, Mr. Vijayan pointed out that the previous Left Democratic Front (LDF) government had not appointed two non-Muslim members to the Waqf Board. In contrast, he said, the UDF government told the High Court that there was no legal impediment to such appointments.

He questioned why the government should allow non-Muslims to be appointed to a Muslim religious institution. He al-

leged that such a move reflected a communal mindset and warned that similar interventions could target institutions of other religions.

He also alleged that the decision to sign the full version of *Vande Mataram* at the government's swearing-in ceremony reflected a surrender to the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) agenda.

Mr. Vijayan said the Congress was aligning with RSS policies.

Revanth cuts short visit, to return to India today

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy said he would speak about all the issues related to the denial of permission by the Centre for his United States tour, after returning to Hyderabad.

Mr. Reddy cut short his visit to the U.S. and London and is returning from London early on Monday.



The downed shutters of the iconic Indian Coffee House located in Lucknow's Hazratganj and spread over 700 square feet. MAYANK KUMAR

Temporary closure of Lucknow's iconic coffee house sparks concern

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The temporary closure of Lucknow's iconic Indian Coffee House has upset regulars and raised concerns over the loss of an affordable social space.

Vinayak Singh, 42, said he had spent more than ₹1,500 on coffee and snacks each time he met friends in Hazratganj over the past month as the coffee house remained shut.

"I ask friends to come to the Indian Coffee House, but on every occasion, we found it closed, forcing us to sit at the adjoining Cafe Coffee Day, where each beverage or snack is at least seven times costlier," he said. The coffee house is located at a prominent intersection in Hazratganj.

Political analyst Sharat Pradhan, who first visited it in the early 1970s, recalled meeting former Uttar Pradesh CMs Veer Bahadur Singh and Narayan Dutt Tiwari there and noted that former Prime Minister Chandrasekhar was also a regular visitor.

"It was a social space

where journalists, academicians, students, politicians and other professionals met as equals to freely talk," Mr. Pradhan said.

He added that socialist leader Ram Manohar Lohia had also visited in the 1950s. "In those days, a cup of tea used to cost 50 paise while coffee was a bit costlier," said the analyst.

The coffee house is run by the Indian Coffee Workers' Co-operative Society Ltd. The Hindu reached out to the workers' cooperative. A person who declined to be identified attributed the closure to staff-related issues and said it would reopen soon.

'Need to keep it open'

Political commentator Ram Dutt Tripathi, who has been visiting the coffee house since the 1980s, said the closure highlighted the shortage of affordable social spaces. "The closure may be due to poor planning. Staff could be hired and food sourced from nearby eateries at minimal cost. But keeping it open is crucial as Lucknow lacks social spaces," he said.

INBRIEF



ED searches residence of IAS officer in KPSC 'scam' case

A day after IAS officer and MSME Director Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar returned from his hometown in Uttar Pradesh after being out of contact for nearly two days, Enforcement Directorate (ED) officials on Sunday reportedly arrived at his residence in Bengaluru in connection with the ongoing probe into alleged irregularities in Karnataka Public Service Commission recruitment. The veterinary officer recruitment exam has come under the ED's scanner following claims that candidates were asked to pay huge sums of money.

Couple killed, three injured as car overturns in Telangana

A couple died and three others were injured when their car overturned in Rajanna Sircilla district of Telangana on Saturday night. The deceased, Mohammad Sadullah, 47, wife Haseena, 44, were travelling with three family members to Chandurthi to attend a pre-wedding ceremony at a relative's house. According to the police, the car overturned on the outskirts of Lingampeta village after Mr. Sadullah, who was behind the wheel, lost control of the vehicle. Those injured are said to be in a stable condition.

Non-resident Keralites will get pension before Onam: CM

The Keralam government has authorised the release of ₹32 crore for the payment of welfare pensions to non-resident Keralites. The *pranava* welfare pension had been in arrears for some months. The pension will be credited before Onam, Chief Minister V.D. Saheesha's office said. The State government said the arrears had piled up on account of the previous LDF government diverting the funds for other purposes. The pension is paid at the rate of ₹3,500 for Keralites who are abroad and ₹3,000 to individuals who are working in other States or have returned.

Ritual voyage



Anoop Narayana Bhattathiri, a member of the Mangattu Illam in Kumanallur, sets sail for the Sree Parthasarathy temple at Aranmula, in Kerala on Sunday. Every year ahead of Onam, the eldest male member of the Illam embarks on a ceremonial boat journey. VISHNU PRATHAP

ED arrests former A.P. Minister in liquor transport scam case

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Sunday arrested former Andhra Pradesh Civil Supplies Minister and YSR Congress Party leader Karumuri Venkata Nageswara Rao in connection with the alleged liquor transport scam.

An ED team picked up Mr. Nageswara Rao from his residence in Hyderabad and questioned him in connection with the case. The case relates to alleged irregularities in the transportation of liquor during the previous YSRCP government.

The investigation has re-

vealed, according to the agency, that the YSRCP government paid around ₹35 per kilometre for transporting liquor, against the prevailing rate of ₹13 per kilometre. The ED has also alleged irregularities in the award of tenders for liquor transportation.

Mr. Nageswara Rao, the fourth accused in the case, is likely to be produced before a court on Monday, sources said.

Meanwhile, former Ministers Chelluboina Venugopala Krishna, Anil Kumar Yadav and Vidadala Rajini described the arrest as an act of political vendetta by the TDP-led government.

Kerala HC allows cancer patient to be added as party in case on medicine prices

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court has allowed a breast cancer patient from Malappuram to be impleaded in a petition considering the issue of the 'exorbitant' price of 'life-saving' breast cancer medication, Ribociclib.

The petition was initially filed by another patient diagnosed with HR-positive HER2-Negative Metastatic Breast Cancer. She was taking Ribociclib, but had passed away while the case was pending before the court. Her petition sought directives to the government to take over the medication's



The court asked authorities to check if Palbociclib, a cheaper alternative, could be used.

patent and make it available at the lowest price possible. The court had then taken up the matter *suo motu*, considering the large public interest.

People will wipe out SP in U.P. Assembly poll next year: CM

Press Trust of India
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday claimed that people would "wipe out" the Samajwadi Party (SP) permanently in the 2027 Assembly poll, alleging that the poor have no place in the Opposition party's agenda.

Addressing a ceremony to felicitate midday meal cooks and distribute cashless healthcare cards, Mr. Adityanath said the BJP government is providing social security guarantees to cooks working in government primary schools.

The Chief Minister announced an increase in the cooks' honorarium, finan-

cial assistance of ₹2 lakh in case of accidents, cashless treatment of up to ₹5 lakh, and an increase in the amount provided for saris from ₹500 to ₹1,000.

'Not on Oppn. agenda'

"This could have been done earlier as well, but it did not happen because the poor were never an issue in the Samajwadi Party's agenda," he said.

Taking a jibe at SP president Akhilesh Yadav, Mr. Adityanath said Mr. Yadav claimed that the SP remained consolidated because five members of his family were MPs. "Notwithstanding, people will wipe it out in the next poll, permanently," he said.

Notice issued to building 66 days before collapse

Siddharth Kumar Singh
HYDERABAD

A multi-storeyed building in Gachibowli, Hyderabad, that collapsed on Saturday, killing two people and damaging an adjoining building, was issued a show-cause notice and speaking orders by the Cyberabad Municipal Corporation (CMC) 66 days earlier over unauthorised construction.

Following the collapse, CMC Commissioner G. Srijana ordered the immediate suspension of U. Santosh Kumar, Town Planning Building Officer, for failing to stop the unauthorised construction.



Triple test, adrift

The Supreme Court should not have discarded a workable test on 'industry'

On August 20, a nine-judge Bench of the Supreme Court of India delivered a judgment on the correctness of the ruling in *Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board vs A. Rajappa (BWSB) (1978)*. In that judgment, Justice V.R. Krishna Iyer had laid down what was called the "Triple Test" on what counts as an "industry" under Section 2(j) of the Industrial Disputes (ID) Act, 1947 (ID Act). Three conditions were to be met for an industry – a systematic activity, employer-employee cooperation, and production/distribution of goods and services to satisfy human wants other than those that are purely religious or spiritual. Profit motive was irrelevant; what mattered in this determination was the nature of the activity, and only "sovereign functions" stood outside it. A five-judge Bench in *State of U.P. vs Jai Bir Singh (2005)* raised a doubt about this definition and a seven-judge Bench sent it to the current nine-judge Bench. This Bench, led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, left the Triple Test standing for all pending disputes under the older ID Act, which was repealed on November 21, 2025 when the Industrial Relations Code, 2020 (IRC) came into force. However, a majority of the nine-judge Bench also ruled that BWSB will not be a "sheer anchor" for interpreting Section 2(p) of the IRC. That is a mistake. In her dissenting opinion, Justice B.V. Nagarathna held that the reference itself was unnecessary and that the Triple Test requires no interference – a view shared by three other judges. Her reasoning is compelling. Since 1978, and particularly after the liberalisation and privatisation reforms of 1991, a far higher number of workers have moved to the private sector, out of the security of public employment. An expansive definition of industry, as entailed in the Triple Test, is therefore even more necessary now as a bulwark for the worker.

Yet, Section 2(p) of the IRC does not move away from Justice Krishna Iyer's Triple Test formula in BWSB and reproduces much of its essence. It is therefore difficult to understand why BWSB has to be set aside when Section 2(p) itself comes up for interpretation. The Triple Test was also not merely a pro-labour device. An expansive definition of industry brought with it not just the ID Act's protections but also its restrictions – for instance, a regulated route to retrenchment and closure for the employer, and a bar on workers striking at will. In essence, the Triple Test allowed for industrial peace rather than worker welfare alone. Severing that principle from the IRC, as the majority has done, cuts away the interpretive framework that allowed such disputes to be resolved. With the essence of the Triple Test carried into Section 2(p), it is now incumbent upon courts and tribunals to ensure that a change of statute is not read as a change of intent even if the majority judgment has removed the anchor to do so.

Core concerns

The Indian economy looks set for tough times ahead

The slowdown in the growth of India's core industrial sectors in July was not surprising, with other indicators predicting easing demand conditions as well. Growth in the index of core industries (ICI) slowed to 5.4% in July from 6% in the previous month. This was in keeping with the Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index, which in July eased to its lowest level since August 2021 due to weak domestic demand conditions. While July's growth in the ICI was the second-highest growth rate in the last seven months, the data nevertheless highlight some concerning aspects of the Indian economy. The first has to do with the fact that a large part of even this slower growth seems to be based on a statistical low base effect. The coal sector, for example, grew at an 11-month high of 7.6% in July, but this was based on a contraction of 12.3% in July of last year. Similarly, the refinery products sector snapped a three-month streak of contraction to grow at 2.7%, but this too was based on a contraction in July 2025. The iron ore sector, however, grew at a very robust 29.5%, albeit slower than a blistering 44.5% in June. This seems heartening regardless of the contractions of 16.4% and 7.1% in June and July of last year, respectively. But the steel sector slowed drastically in July to 2.9% from 5.6% in June and 15.7% in July of last year.

The domestic crude oil and natural gas sectors have been lasting drags on the economy. Both have contracted continuously for at least the last 14 months for which the new series of the ICI has data. India's crude oil imports rose 13.3% in volume terms in July, while Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) imports grew a more marginal 1.5%, showing that the economy's appetite is being whetted from abroad. This external dependence is proving very expensive. High oil prices have meant that the crude oil import bill jumped 4% in July. The 100% tariffs that the United States is preparing to levy on countries such as India that import Russian oil will once again burden Indian exporters. Moving to 20% ethanol-blending has not impacted oil imports materially. Within the ICI, the only two bright spots of the economy were telecom and electricity sectors. The electricity sector grew at a robust 9% in July, although this was slower than the two consecutive months of double-digit growth in May and June thanks to the prevalent heatwave conditions in many parts of the country. The cement sector sped up to 13.1%, a welcome acceleration. Such positive trends were few and far between. Overall, the Indian economy looks to be in for a period of slack demand, higher costs, and moderating growth.

Not 'dehulu' – an AI tutor for every child in India



Srivatsa Krishna
IAS officer

Indian students rank among the top students almost anywhere in the world. The joke is that, from the womb to the afterlife, they are taught to study maths and science which serves them well throughout life. A report by Redseer says that India's test-preparation market has been estimated at \$14.8 billion in FY26, projected to reach \$23-\$26 billion by FY30 (12%-15% CAGR), with around 2,00,00,000 coaching centres nationwide. There are 65 million students in classes 9-12, of whom around 27 million attend government schools. A 2025 National Statistical Office survey found that 27% of students were taking or had taken private coaching in the academic year (30.7% urban, 25.5% rural). Across datasets, coaching incidence is around 27%-30%, implying that 17 million to 20 million students in classes 9-12 participate in some form of test-prep coaching.

No single private platform has the capacity or curriculum breadth to serve as the sole national provider. PhysicsWallah, for example, has around 4.9 million paid online users – while the target population is 10 to 100 times larger. This needs to be built as a platform and network play, not a vendor contract.

Better learning, better outcomes

How can the government take the help of Artificial Intelligence (AI) to deliver a free coach and tutor to every Indian child? The objective should not be to bring down the private coaching industry but to improve the learning standards and examination outcomes of the last child in the line who today spends thousands of rupees on dubious coaching centres without achieving the necessary results. Bring the industry in as suppliers, or they will lobby against it and the reputational risk of failing completely, is high for the government to sustain.

We should not nationalise coaching. Build a public rail, private engines model: the state supplies the digital public infrastructure (identity, payments, discovery, data, credentialing) and aggregates demand; the private sector – star teachers, ed-tech firms, local tutors – supplies content and last-mile delivery shared by both. Government becomes the platform and market-maker, not the content producer. This is exactly how UPI beat closed payment apps and how the pen Network for Digital Commerce is attempting to beat closed commerce: unbundling the monopoly, open the protocol, let a thousand providers compete on an open network.

The Indian coaching industry charges high fees because it bundles four things that do not have to be bundled: content; doubt-solving/mentoring; peer group and discipline, a credible signal of quality. DPI lets us unbundle these and drive the marginal cost of the first two toward zero. This can be anchored in an existing centre of excellence such as Bodhanai at IIT Madras

The government can create the digital infrastructure for every Indian child to access a free Artificial Intelligence (AI) tutor – which was the vision behind the Prime Minister's call

(which has a ₹500 crore, five year government grant) or a similar National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI)-like body that needs to be created for education (a Section 8 not-for-profit steward).

Where it should begin

It should start with the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET, and the Joint Entrance Examination, the two most widely taken examinations in India. JEE/NEET are objective, machine-gradable, and high-volume. The content is already freely available on YouTube; what is scarce is a trusted, standardised rank signal and personalised doubt-solving.

An IIT professor who teaches students who have cleared JEE 30 years ago may not be the best option for teaching test prep. Today's test prep skill and requirement is in a very different age, time, and pedagogy.

Government aggregates demand thereby drives down the customer acquisition cost for the private sector and owns the rails and the trust layer; the private sector and star teachers compete to deliver content and mentoring on an open network; the student owns the data and carries a voucher (optional). That is how you turn a \$15h payroll industry into free, plural, high-quality prep – without the state trying to become the teacher.

As with any private good using public rails, it will use Aadhaar/DigiLocker for student sign-up and to de-duplicate; APAAR ID to tie learning to the academic record. Along with this will be a curated content registry, an open catalogue where any accredited provider publishes lessons, problem sets, and mock tests against a standard syllabus taxonomy (NEET/JEE topic tree) and open metadata (language, difficulty, medium, accessibility tags). The government will set the taxonomy and standards for the content and ensure interoperability.

Content interoperability is the whole game – a student's progress in one provider's module must be portable to another's. There shall be a discovery layer, a government-run reference app plus open APIs so third parties (including the DIKSHA app, state apps, even Google/YouTube) can surface the same content – multiple front ends, one network. For example, PhysicsWallah, Vedantu, Allen or Narayana could offer their material for free and charge for doubt-solving or premium sessions with ranked professors. IIT professors could also upload their lectures and be rated and ranked on the platform. Adaptive personalisation should be a core feature and as a network service, an open recommendation/diagnostic engine that routes say a weak-in-organic-chemistry student to the best-rated module on that topic, regardless of provider. These will be accompanied by a learning wallet and a progress ledger, a student-owned record of what they have studied,

mock scores, and mastery per topic, consent-gated through the DEPA/Account Aggregator pattern. The student – not the ed-tech firm – owns the data, which is the single biggest structural break from today's walled-garden apps. Lastly, while the platform will be mostly free at the point of use, UPI-plumbed premium add-ons (live mentoring, graded assignments) can be micro-charged or voucher-funded, should the government wish to create a DBT-like e-Shiksha wallet. Deliberately thin the government software: The state builds protocols and a reference app; it does not try to build the best learning app. It will not win that race and should not try this. Government alone can aggregate the demand and credential the supply and outcomes – that is all it should do. It should auto-invite every registered Class 11-12 student through schools, CBSE/State boards, and the DIKSHA install base. The system should guarantee reach through free data-light streaming, downloadable content for low-bandwidth areas, and distribution through the five lakh-plus Common Service Centres and school computer labs for students without personal devices. Equity is the mandate – the ₹60,000 crore industry already serves the affluent; the gap is everyone else.

Government should publish open ratings and outcome data: publish, per provider and per module, how students who used it scored on official mocks and the real exam. Quality signal becomes objective, not marketing. This is the credential the coaching industry currently monopolises. Government alone can ensure independent accreditation of providers (content accuracy, no misleading claims), with delisting teeth. Further there should be a no-lock-in rule to ensure that providers cannot hold a student's progress data hostage; portability is enforced at the protocol level.

Models on offer

There is no dearth of content, good and bad, on YouTube but where an AI tutor helps is in practice, doubt solving and adaptive personalisation, which only AI can do. There are good open-source models such as Gemma, which give a million tokens for about 20 to 30 cents or 10,000 tokens per day or 3.6 million tokens per year for just \$100. Further, every AI minute is equivalent to 1,000 voice minutes of a human; frontier tech companies such as Meta and Google are paying star Kota teachers \$25 to \$30 per hour for commoditising their content. Further, their models will get trained on it and Generative Inference will do the rest on top of it.

We should not be dehulu – as Gen Z would put it – government should not become the AI tutor itself. It should only enable the AI tutor through the blueprint given.

The views expressed are personal

The return of profanation as a new political language

In his work *Profanations*, Italian philosopher Giorgio Agamben observes how the act of profanation applies to the game of chess and children playing with household items as toys. For Agamben, profanation refers to removal or transfer of objects, places, animals, personalities or languages from the realm of sacred or restricted use to the common or ordinary use of people. Religion, state, political ideology, and marketplace are identified by him as the agents that make things sacred, removing them from common use and transferring them to a separate sphere. What chess does is profanation, converting wars or ancient divinatory rituals into a game, a playful activity.

The same thing happens when a child plays with a household object; they free or liberate it from its restricted use and open it up for a new purpose. These two textbook examples of desecration are best understood within the context of the recent student protest at Jantar Mantar.

The protest led by the Cuckooarch Janta Party (CJP) has sparked a national debate over what is "sacred" and "profane", and what is "formal" and "informal" in Indian politics. It shows how students can desecrate a "sacred" and "invincible" political force through a measured act of profanation. Interestingly, labelling the movement "profane", "informal", or "violent" also serves as the ruling party's best defence.

Admittedly, a fraction of the students used profanity, slurs and abusive slogans which were directed at the administration out of anger. No one can justify this. However, one must not ignore the instances of profanation in the protest expressed through informality, casualness, and fearlessness, which mainstream media labelled as "anarchism" and the "collapse of political civility".

As anti-colonial strategy

Profanation as a mode of serious political intervention is not something new to Indian



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The recent student protest challenges political power through humour, informality, and profanation

politics. The Indian national movement has, at various times, resorted to such acts as a part of its core political strategy. Instead of violent means, the movement strategically employed non-cooperation, economic boycotts, and public burning of clothes made in England to strip away the authority, prestige and institutional power of the British Raj. In an act tantamount to profanation, some of its leaders publicly renounced awards and honorific titles conferred on them to show that no honours superseded their national sentiments.

Mahatma Gandhi sometimes used satirical language to ridicule the authority. To the question by a reporter about his unimpressive dressing while meeting King George V at Buckingham Palace in 1931, Gandhiji is reported to have remarked, "The king had enough on for both of us." This was not at all a personal insult or act of belittlement, but a powerful political statement highlighting the vast disparity in power and wealth between the British colonisers and the Indians, the colonised.

Universally, when conventional means of expression are restricted or suppressed by force, humour, satire, comedy, and trolling fill the vacuum, challenging hegemonic structures in a subtle but more powerful manner. Charlie Chaplin explored this possibility in his 1940 satirical masterpiece, *The Great Dictator*, satirising Hitler's mannerisms through a character who closely resembled him. More recent examples come from Palestine, where humour serves as a political tool, transforming the daily suffering of Palestinians into a collective form of resistance.

India's new politics

In a novel shift, the students function as the agents of profanation in India; they deal with the excessive power of the state by weaponising humour, satire, memes and trolls in ways unheard of. India's political orthodoxy may refuse to acknowledge that Indian democracy is

equally built through such acts of profanation, not solely through the intervention of formal political institutions. This orthodoxy clearly resonates in media debates, which often write off any form of unconventional politics as either liberal denunciation or left adventurism, completely missing the hopeful cues of a new mode of politics to emerge.

Further, the demand for greater accountability and transparency in governance from the students, a "non-party" political entity, has elicited sceptical responses from across the political spectrum. Much of the concern stems from the movement's "informal" and "non-institutional" character and its "single-issue" oriented politics. Critics argue that such "street politics" alone does not have the power to bring about radical political transformation.

More optimistically, those on the other side argue that it should remain one of the tactics at our disposal when formal opposition struggles to deliver the desired results. The Congress Party, for instance, does not dismiss the potential of the CJP's mode of politics, even as it detects and warns of an Aam Aadmi element within it. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi himself occasionally adopts an informal style, engaging directly with people through street-level interventions.

Rethinking informal politics

The Jantar Mantar protest has definitely offered a radical component for a rethinking of the ways in which informal politics works in India's democracy. Expressions of dissent in informal forms are often downplayed as subordinate to "popular consensus", which is measured chiefly through electoral victory. The question of where to place this protest or what basket suits it – whether as an impromptu student mobilisation driven by anger, a street protest with intensive political content, or a sign of an unconventional style of politics – is therefore a significant one.

Mayakkathile, brought out the best in Sowcar Janaki in *Bagyalakshmi* (1961). In her production, *Kovya Tholai*, her dual portrayal of mother and daughter was equally outstanding.

S.V. Venugopalan, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Opinion

A civilisational approach to social media

The debate over banning social media for minors is rapidly becoming one of the defining policy questions of the digital age. As countries around the world move toward restrictions, India is faced with a choice: follow regulatory models developed elsewhere or draw upon its own traditions to address the challenge.

Recent measures in Australia, proposals in the U.K., and differing approaches in the U.S. have intensified calls for similar action elsewhere. The arguments are often compelling, particularly when framed around the safety and well-being of children.

The concerns are not imaginary; social media can expose young people to manipulation, addiction, bullying, and harmful content. While these dangers deserve serious attention, it does not automatically follow that bans are the answer. Regulation is important but the more important question is whether regulation alone can prepare the next generation for a world increasingly shaped by AI and digital technologies.

Fear is not the answer

History suggests that every major communications revolution has generated anxiety. The printing press triggered fears about the uncontrolled spread of information; radio, television, and the Internet provoked similar concerns. The enduring challenge has never been about whether information should flow but how societies can encourage its responsible use.

Today's challenge is magnified by scale and speed. The smartphone has become the printing press, library, marketplace, classroom, and public square of the modern age combined. Social media, AI, and emerging digital technologies are together driving perhaps the greatest transformation in society since the Industrial Revolution.

Many young people understandably find this transition



Milinda Moragoda

Former Sri Lankan Cabinet Minister, diplomat, and founder of the Pathfinder Foundation, a strategic affairs think tank

unsettling. They are growing up amid rapid technological disruption, geopolitical uncertainty, widening inequality, and a pervasive sense of instability. In such an environment, fear can become a powerful political force. However, societies should be careful not to allow fear to become the principal driver of policy. Policymakers should ensure that legitimate concerns about children's well-being do not evolve into a broader resistance to innovation itself. The challenge is not to stop technological change, but to ensure that society develops the institutions to manage it.

Governments are now attempting to erect barriers against technologies that are becoming more sophisticated, personalised, and difficult to control. The contest between regulation and innovation is increasingly unequal. Sophisticated technology will easily enable people to circumvent the barriers the government creates. Virtual private networks, encrypted applications, alternative platforms, and future AI-driven tools will make circumvention increasingly easy. The real question is therefore not how to keep young people away from technology, but how to prepare them to live with it.

Indeed, the debate may already be overtaken by events. The next generation will interact not merely with social media platforms but with intelligent AI systems that can educate, entertain, mentor, and potentially manipulate. The challenge before us is therefore much larger than social media.

Governments unquestionably have a role. They should demand greater transparency from platforms, establish clear standards for child protection, combat criminal activity, and encourage responsible innovation. However, regulation alone cannot solve what is fundamentally a social, cultural, and civilisational challenge. India should explore a broader response rooted in its

own civilisational experience.

Drawing from one's roots

For centuries, Indian society developed mechanisms to transmit values, wisdom, and social responsibility across generations. Family structures, religious traditions, and educational institutions helped young people navigate periods of change and uncertainty. Among the most enduring of these was the *guru-shishya* tradition, a relationship that extended far beyond the transmission of knowledge. It sought to cultivate character, self-discipline, and a sense of responsibility.

The challenge today is not to recreate the past but to adapt its strengths to the realities of the 21st century. Parents must become more digitally literate and engaged in the online lives of their children. Schools should teach not only technological skills but also digital citizenship, critical thinking, ethical reasoning, and resilience. Religious and cultural organisations should engage with technology rather than retreat from it. Technology companies, educators and civil society should work together to encourage responsible behaviour online.

Just as previous generations learned how to navigate the physical world responsibly, future generations must learn how to navigate the digital world responsibly. This is not simply a technological challenge. It is an educational and cultural one.

India's civilisational strength has always been its ability to absorb powerful external influences without losing its cultural core. As one of the world's oldest civilisations with a growing digital society, India is positioned to demonstrate that tech progress and cultural continuity can coexist. The challenges posed by social media will not be resolved by building a bigger firewall. They will be addressed by combining safeguards with the human institutions that shape judgment, resilience, and responsibility.

The Jat, non-Jat fault line in Haryana

The Opposition is shifting the debate from transparency to employment worries

STATE OF PLAY

Ashok Kumar

The controversy over Haryana Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) president Archana Gupta's reference to a "vishesh varg" (particular class) in the context of government jobs has once again brought the State's deeply entrenched Jat versus non-Jat political fault line to the centre of public debate.

At a press conference in Panipat on August 11, Ms. Gupta said that the previous Congress and Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) administrations facilitated government appointments for a "particular class". Opposition parties immediately construed the remark as a reference to Jats as both governments were headed by Jat Chief Ministers. They accused the BJP of deliberately reviving the Jat, non-Jat divide for political consolidation.

The Jat, non-Jat question

The BJP, which formed a government on its own in Haryana for the first time in 2014 and secured a historic third consecutive term in 2024, has faced similar allegations for much of the past decade. Its critics contend that the party has sought to consolidate non-Jat voters — particularly Backward Classes (BCs) and upper castes — against the State's influential Jat community.

Ms. Gupta's subsequent clarification attempted to shift the focus from caste to the alleged role of middlemen in government recruitment. She said the "vishesh varg" remark referred not to any caste but to intermediaries who, during the Congress and INLD governments, allegedly helped candidates secure jobs through recommendations



and bribes. According to her, such middlemen have been rendered "jobless" under the BJP government, with recruitment now being based on merit and not recommendations.

The clarification, however, did little to contain the controversy. The Congress and the two Chautala-led parties — the Janayak Janta Party and the INLD — have sought to portray the BJP as anti-Jat and anti-farmer. The INLD has been particularly aggressive. Party convenor Sampat Singh approached the Haryana police seeking registration of an FIR against Ms. Gupta under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita relating to public tranquility and caste-based enmity. Further, INLD president Abhay Chautala mocked Ms. Gupta's assertion that she was a daughter of the "Jat Samaj".

The exchange is revealing of the political sensitivity surrounding caste in Haryana. Ms. Gupta's attempt to underline her Jat lineage can be read as an indication that, despite the BJP's gains among non-Jat communities, the party cannot afford to be seen as detached from the Jat community, particularly in rural and farming constituencies.

BJP's evolution in the State

The BJP's own evolution in Haryana helps explain this sensitivity. After coming to power in 2014, the party initially sought to project an inclusive Haryana identity through slo-

gans such as "Haryana Ek, Haqami Ek" (One Haryana, One Haryana). It also appointed Jat leaders Subhash Barala and Om Prakash Dhankar successively as State party presidents to broaden its appeal. Over time, however, the BJP increasingly consolidated its support among non-Jat communities, with the shift becoming more pronounced ahead of the 2024 Assembly election. Meanwhile, the Congress and the Chautala-led parties retained a stronger base among Jats. This divergence has made the Jat, non-Jat divide a visible feature of Haryana's electoral politics.

The jobs controversy has an additional dimension because government employment carries unusual political and socio-economic weight in Haryana. The BJP has repeatedly highlighted its record of selection on merit as an important achievement. The Opposition, however, has sought to turn the same issue against the government by pointing toward allegations of paper leaks, recruitment-related controversies and unemployment among young people. In doing so, it is attempting to move the debate away from BJP's claim of transparent recruitment and towards the question of whether the State has created sufficient job opportunities.

The controversy therefore exposes a larger contradiction in Haryana politics. The BJP may continue to benefit electorally from a broad non-Jat coalition, but it cannot ignore the political weight of the Jat community. At the same time, the Opposition has every incentive to keep the binary alive, particularly when it can connect caste identity with questions of farmers and government employment.

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The rural-urban divide in female labour force participation

The participation of women in the labour market has increased, with the rise being more pronounced in rural areas than urban areas

DATA POINT

Chandrasekar K.

The Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) 2025 reveals a significant increase in the Female Labour Force Participation Rate (FLFPR) since 2020, following the COVID-19 pandemic. The overall FLFPR for those aged 15 years and above increased from 30% in 2019-20 to 40% in 2025. The increase was more pronounced in rural areas, where the FLFPR rose from 33% to 45.9%, compared with an increase from 23.3% to 27.7% in urban areas. This substantial rural-urban difference warrants a more granular analysis.

Chart 1 shows the Average Annual Percentage Point (AAPP) change in rural FLFPR for each State between 2019-20 and 2025. West Bengal, Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat, Odisha, Bihar, Rajasthan and Haryana recorded AAPP above the all-India rural average. In contrast, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Uttarakhand, Maharashtra, Goa, Himachal Pradesh and Andhra Pradesh recorded AAPP below the national average.

Similarly, Chart 2 shows the AAPP change for urban areas. Rajasthan and Gujarat, with AAPP above 2 percentage points per year, recorded particularly sturdy improvements. Uttarakhand, Kerala, Chhattisgarh, Karnataka, Odisha, Bihar and Andhra Pradesh also recorded AAPP above the all-India urban average. In contrast, the remaining States recorded AAPP below the national average. This indicates that several States recorded relatively strong gains despite overall pace of improvement being lower in urban areas than in rural areas.

However, AAPP alone is insufficient as it measures only the pace of change and does not consider the level of female labour force participation from which a State

started. Therefore, combining the baseline level — 2019-20 FLFPR for each State — with the AAPP helps better assess the States.

Chart 3 shows the rural baseline-AAPP relationship. Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal and Haryana started with relatively low female FLFPR but recorded AAPP above the all-India average, indicating a relatively faster pace of improvement. In contrast, Goa and Punjab started from relatively low baseline levels but recorded AAPP below the national average, indicating slower improvement despite having considerable scope. Odisha, Gujarat and Rajasthan started with relatively higher baseline rural FLFPR and recorded an above-all-India average AAPP, indicating that faster improvement is not confined to States starting from a low base. Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand, Uttarakhand, Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra, Himachal Pradesh and the five southern States had relatively higher baseline levels but recorded AAPP below the national average.

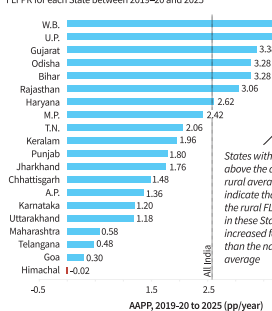
Chart 4 shows the urban baseline-AAPP relationship. Rajasthan, Gujarat, Uttarakhand and Bihar started from relatively low baseline levels but recorded AAPP above the all-India average. In contrast, Uttar Pradesh, Jharkhand, Haryana and Punjab also started from relatively low levels but recorded below-average AAPP, indicating slower improvement. Among the States with relatively higher baseline urban FLFPR, Kerala, Karnataka, Chhattisgarh, Odisha and Andhra Pradesh recorded above-average AAPP, showing that some States with already higher participation continued to make relatively rapid gains.

Taken together, all charts show that female labour force participation differs substantially across States and between rural and urban areas. It also demonstrates why AAPP should not be interpreted in isolation: a State with a lower AAPP may already have a relatively high FLFPR.

Wide variations

The data for the charts were sourced from PLFS 2025. The author is an Indian Statistical Service Officer serving as Joint Director in MoS&PI

Chart 1: Average annual percentage point (AAPP) change in rural FLFPR for each State between 2019-20 and 2025



1 Average annual percentage point change (AAPP) is used to indicate the pace of improvement and is not intended to rank States

2 In Chart 1, Himachal Pradesh is particularly notable, with a marginally negative AAPP, despite nearly 90% of its population residing in rural areas

Chart 3: Baseline (2019-20 FLFPR) and AAPP relation for rural FLFPR

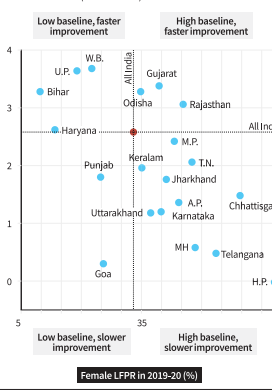
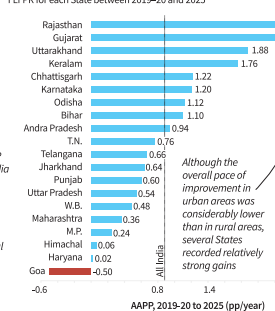
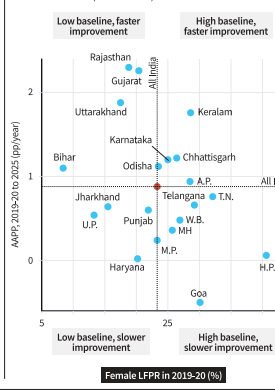


Chart 2: Average annual percentage point (AAPP) change in urban FLFPR for each State between 2019-20 and 2025



3 As shown in Chart 4, States like Tamil Nadu, Telangana, West Bengal, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh and Goa recorded slower improvement despite their relatively higher starting levels

Chart 4: Baseline (2019-20 FLFPR) and AAPP relation for urban FLFPR



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO AUGUST 24, 1976

Protection of Taj from damage by effluents

New Delhi, August 23: A series of measures, including a detailed study by an Italian firm are under way to protect the Taj in Agra from possible damage by the effluents of the Mathura refinery.

The services of the Italian firm have been obtained by the Indian Oil Corporation for establishing the concentration of effluents under various meteorological conditions at different distances from the refinery and determining the concentration permissible from the point of view of preservation of monuments.

The firm Tecneco, a subsidiary of the ENI group, will calculate the ground level concentration of effluents, particularly sulphur dioxide, in the region on account of emission from the refinery, determine the existing level of pollution in Agra, examine the present state of preservation of the monuments and determine the permissible concentration of effluents.

The studies will be conducted partly in India and partly in Italy. The important portion of the study relating to the present state of the monument will be carried out by Tecneco under the guidance of the Institute Dei Restauo Italiano and the International Centre of Conservation, Rome. Indian experts will be associated with these studies.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 24, 1926

Cricket and entertainment tax

Poona, August 21: A public meeting attended by a very large number of the cricket loving public of Poona was held yesterday evening on the grounds of the Deccan Gymkhana under the Presidentship of Mr. L. B. Bhopale, M.L.C.

Resolutions protesting against the entertainment tax levied on the admission tickets of the quadrangular cricket matches to be played in Poona in September, condemning the abnormal increase in the rent for plots charged by the Poona Gymkhana Club, requesting the Gymkhana authorities to reserve as usual the bill enclosure for schooling students and appointing an influential committee to wait upon His Excellency the Governor of Bombay to get the grievances redressed were unanimously adopted.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of drownings recorded by France this summer

301 France has recorded over 300 drownings this summer, up sharply from last year, a minister said, linking the surge to the heatwaves that have swept Europe. The 301 drownings are an increase of 14% from the summer of 2025, Sports and Youth Minister Marina Ferreri said. *AP*

Members in election committee for DUSU elections

84 The Students' Federation of India has formed an 84-member election committee and launched its "Dream DU of Daffi Gang" to outline the organisation's strategy for the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections, the student body said on Sunday. *PTI*

Stolen two-wheelers recovered by Delhi Police in 4-day drive

161 Delhi Police recovered 161 stolen two-wheelers and arrested or apprehended 109 people, including 24 history-sheets, during a four-day crime-prevention drive in Rohini, officials said on Sunday. The operation was conducted from August 18 to 21. *PTI*

Persons arrested by Indonesian police for starting forest fires

72 Indonesian authorities arrested 72 people suspected of starting some of the forest and peatland fires as huge blazes in central and west Indonesia triggered choking haze. Indonesia has been battling fires driven by an intensifying El Niño pattern and a prolonged dry season. *AP*

E-bus charging points to be established in Himachal Pradesh

80 Deputy Chief Minister Mukesh Agnihotri on Sunday said the Himachal Road Transport Corporation is strengthening charging infrastructure for electric buses across the state by establishing charging stations at 80 locations for ₹122 crore. *PTI*

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Vande Mataram and the right to dissent

The 2026 amendment protects *Vande Mataram* from being stopped or disrupted, but does not make singing it compulsory or prescribe all six stanzas; the Supreme Court's *Bijoe Emmanuel* judgment protects an individual's right to remain silent when participation conflicts with freedom of conscience

LETTER & SPIRIT

Haris Beeran

Parliament has given *Vande Mataram* the same criminal-law protection long enjoyed by the national anthem. But a closer look at the Constituent Assembly's own reasoning, the actual text of the new law, and the Supreme Court's judgment in *Bijoe Emmanuel v. State of Kerala* (1986) suggests that the position is far less settled and far more protective of individual conscience than the political rhetoric around the amendment implies.

Why it was not the anthem

The question of India's national anthem was left open for nearly the entire life of the Constituent Assembly. It was finally settled not by a vote, but by a presidential statement on January 24, 1950, at the Assembly's last sitting, when Dr. Rajendra Prasad declared that *Jana Gana Mana* would be the National Anthem of India, and that *Vande Mataram*, "which has played a historic part in the struggle for Indian freedom, shall be honoured equally with *Jana Gana Mana* and shall have equal status with it."

That formula is worth reading carefully, because what it conspicuously does not do is make *Vande Mataram* the anthem or even a co-anthem. The Constitution, when it came into force two days later, contains no reference whatsoever to a "national song". The status of *Vande Mataram* rests entirely on Dr. Prasad's 1950 statement and on subsequent convention, and nothing more.

The reason for this restraint lies earlier, in the Indian National Congress's own reckoning with the song in the 1930s. *Vande Mataram*'s later stanzas, rarely sung today, invoke the motherland in explicitly devotional, goddess-centred terms. In the context of the 1882 novel *Anandamath*, from which the song is drawn, some of its verses were also read as casting Muslims as adversaries. Objections from the Muslim League and others led the Congress Working Committee, in October 1937, to resolve that only the first two stanzas – pastoral, secular in imagery and free of any reference to a deity – would be sung at official gatherings.

That 1937 compromise is what Dr. Prasad's Constituent Assembly statement inherited and preserved in 1950: full-throated reverence for the song's role in the freedom struggle, but a deliberate decision to keep its more contentious, devotional verses out of India's civic and constitutional life. It was not an oversight.

What the amendment says

The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, was introduced in the Rajya Sabha on July 24, 2026, and cleared both Houses within a week. The Rajya Sabha cleared it on July 29 and the Lok Sabha on July 30, each after only a brief discussion, with the Opposition, including the DMK and Congress, raising strong objections about the Bill being used to advance a particular cultural agenda and about the timing amid unrelated protests in the House. It received Presidential assent shortly after.

Given the speed and thinness of the debate, the Amendment – one of 12 Bills passed in a Monsoon Session in which, by Parliament's own record, most legislation went through with barely any discussion – has had remarkably little parliamentary scrutiny for a law that touches on religious sentiment, free expression and



The law penalises disrespect and disruption of a performance; it does not, on its text, mandate participation in one, nor does it fix which version of the song is entitled to protection. *ANI*

criminal liability all at once.

What the Amendment actually does is narrower than the headlines suggest. It substitutes Section 3 of the 1971 Act with a provision that punishes two things, and only two things, in relation to both the national anthem and the national song: intentionally preventing their singing and causing disturbance to an assembly engaged in singing them. The punishment – up to three years' imprisonment, a fine, or both, with a mandatory minimum of one year for repeat offenders – is now common to both compositions.

Here is the question mark worth putting squarely to the government: nowhere does the amended Act say which stanzas of *Vande Mataram* must be sung, or that all six stanzas must be sung, for the law's protection to apply. The statute does not prescribe a mandatory version of the song at all. It does not compel singing in the first place by anyone, of any stanza.

All the amended Section 3 requires is that if the national song is being sung, at whatever length and in whatever form, that rendition must not be intentionally prevented or disturbed. That is a materially narrower obligation than the political framing around the Bill – including the government's own push, since late 2025, to popularise and even mandate all six stanzas at official functions – might lead the public to believe. The law penalises disrespect and disruption of a performance; it does not, on its text, mandate participation in one, nor does it fix which version of the song is entitled to protection.

The later stanzas

The commonly sung opening stanzas of *Vande Mataram* describe the motherland in pastoral terms, her waters, her fruit, her cooling breezes, her fields. It is the later stanzas, historically dropped from public renditions by the Congress in 1937 but increasingly promoted for full recitation since the government's commemoration of the song's 150th anniversary in late 2025, that shift register entirely.

In substance, and in every available English rendering, they describe the motherland as embodied in the Hindu goddesses Durga, Lakshmi and Saraswati, respectively, goddesses of power, wealth and learning, and speak of her as an object of worship enshrined in temples, with "crores" of arms raised in her

defence. This is not patriotic verse loosely coloured with cultural reference; on a plain reading, it is a devotional address to a deity, structured in the grammar of prayer.

Freedom of conscience

India is constitutionally committed to a plurality of faiths: Hindu, Muslim, Christian, Sikh, Buddhist, Jain, Parsi and others, each entitled under Article 25 to freedom of conscience and the free profession, practice and propagation of religion, and under Article 26 to manage its own religious affairs without State interference.

For adherents of monotheistic faiths in particular, being required, whether by direct compulsion or by the coercive pressure of a criminal statute looming over any public assembly, to stand through or refrain from disrupting an extended recitation addressed to Hindu goddesses raises a genuine and serious constitutional difficulty. A citizen's discomfort with participating in what is, on the text, an act of worship of deities outside their own faith is not eccentric; it is exactly the kind of conscientious objection that Articles 25 and 26 exist to protect.

Articles 25 and 26 are fundamental rights. It is a basic proposition of Indian constitutional law that no ordinary legislation, however patriotically framed or however overwhelming its parliamentary majority, can override a fundamental right. A law that has the effect of pressuring citizens, on pain of criminal liability for anyone thought to be "disturbing" its recitation, to acquiesce in a devotional performance contrary to their faith would not survive that Part III scrutiny. The 2026 Amendment does not, fortunately, go that far on its text, but the danger, as the next section shows, lies in how it may be applied.

The Bijoe Emmanuel ruling

This is not an abstract or first-time question for Indian courts. It was addressed directly and decisively in *Bijoe Emmanuel & Ors. v. State of Kerala* (1986), a case that remains the single most important precedent on the collision between compelled patriotic ritual and freedom of conscience.

Three siblings, Bijoe, Binu Mol and Bindu Emmanuel, practising Jehovah's Witnesses, stood respectfully and silently while their schoolmates sang *Jana Gana*

Mana during morning assembly. They did not sing themselves because their faith forbade what they understood as an act of worship of anyone or anything other than god. For this, they were expelled.

The Kerala High Court upheld the expulsion, holding that Article 51A's fundamental duty to respect the national anthem overrode any claim under Articles 25 and 26, and that Jehovah's Witnesses could not even invoke those protections.

The Supreme Court, in a judgment authored by Justice O. Chinnappa Reddy, reversed the High Court in emphatic terms. The Bench held that compelling a person to join in singing despite a genuine, conscientiously held religious objection contravenes both Article 19(1)(a) – freedom of expression, which the court held extends to the freedom to remain silent – and Article 25(1), the guarantee of freedom of conscience.

Crucially, the court held that the fundamental duties enumerated under Article 51A cannot be used to cut down or override the fundamental rights guaranteed under Part III of the Constitution; a duty to respect national symbols cannot, in law, be turned into a licence to punish sincere religious dissent. The court also read the 1971 Act itself as requiring nothing more than respectful conduct, not active participation from anyone present. It closed with the observation that the country's tradition, philosophy and Constitution alike "practise tolerance," urging that this not be diluted.

That ruling has never been overturned, and its logic transfers with full force to *Vande Mataram*, arguably with greater force, given that the song's later verses are, unlike the anthem, addressed to specific deities. If the Supreme Court held that a Jehovah's Witness could not be compelled to sing a secular anthem against conscience, the same protection must extend, a fortiori, to a citizen who objects to reciting verses that are, on their face, prayers to Hindu goddesses.

Legal position

Put together, the three strands here point to a single, clear conclusion.

First, the Constituent Assembly and the country's founding leadership deliberately confined official recognition to the first two, secular stanzas of *Vande Mataram*. That is precisely why the fuller, devotional version was never made compulsory, then or since.

Second, the 2026 Amendment, whatever its political framing, imposes no textual obligation on any citizen to sing any particular version of the song, let alone all six stanzas. It penalises only the prevention or disturbance of a singing that is already taking place.

Third, and most importantly, even where the song, including its later stanzas, is sung, a citizen who chooses not to join in because doing so would offend their freedom of conscience under Article 25 is under no legal obligation to participate.

The law as laid down by the Supreme Court in *Bijoe Emmanuel* gives that citizen complete protection: standing respectfully, in silence, without disrupting others, is not an offence under this Act, was not an offence under the original 1971 Act, and cannot be made one merely by extending the statute to a new composition.

Citizens uneasy about the fuller version of *Vande Mataram* do not need to wait for a court to vindicate them after the fact. The law, correctly read, already protects them.

(Haris Beeran is a Rajya Sabha MP and a lawyer)

THE GIST

▼ *Vande Mataram* was given equal status with *Jana Gana Mana* in 1950 for its historic role in the freedom struggle, but was never made the national anthem or a co-anthem.

▼ The 1937 Congress compromise limited official renditions to the first two stanzas, keeping the later devotional verses invoking Hindu goddesses out of civic and official life.

▼ The 2026 amendment has renewed debate over the song's later stanzas and the constitutional questions surrounding religious freedom, freedom of conscience and the State's role in patriotic expression.

CACHE

What changes when AI moves from reading viral genomes to designing them?

The Stanford experiment does not show that AI can casually manufacture dangerous human viruses; it shows that computers are beginning to move from analysing biological information towards proposing biological designs that scientists can physically build

Abdul Ghafur

The computer did not create a virus. It did not touch a test tube or handle a living cell. What it did may ultimately be more consequential: it helped decide what the virus's genome should be. Researchers at Stanford University and the Arc Institute used artificial intelligence (AI) to design complete genomes of bacteriophages - viruses that infect bacteria. Of 285 AI-generated designs physically synthesised and tested in the laboratory, 16 produced functioning phages. Some were able to overcome bacterial resistance that defeated the original virus. The phrase 'AI-created viruses' therefore needs qualification. Humans have been synthesising viral genomes and deliberately modifying viruses for decades. What is new is not the physical manufacture of a virus. AI has entered the design stage of biology. For medicine, that creates remarkable opportunities. For biosecurity, it raises equally important questions.

From reading genomes to designing Bacteriophages - literally "bacteria eaters" - have been known for more than a century and are among the most abundant biological entities in nature. In 1977, one particularly small phage, ΦX174, pronounced roughly 'phi-X-one-seventy-four', became the first complete DNA genome to be sequenced. By the early 2000s, scientists had shown that viral genetic material could be synthesised from known sequence information and used to recover functioning viruses. Humans had progressed from reading viral genomes to writing them. Scientists then became increasingly capable of deliberately altering viruses. The controversial influenza gain-of-function experiments of 2011-12 showed that genetic changes could modify important properties such as transmission in experimental animals. Such research highlighted a dilemma that remains unresolved: the same science that can improve pandemic preparedness may also create biosafety and biosecurity risks.

The Stanford-Arc experiment represents the next step. The scientists already knew the ΦX174 genome and already knew how to synthesise viral DNA and recover functioning phages. What changed was who - or what - proposed the genome. They used Evo 1 and Evo 2, genome language models. The principle resembles a large language model, except that instead of learning patterns in words, Evo learns patterns in DNA. It studies the genetic alphabet - A, C, G and T - across vast numbers of genomes and then generates new genetic sequences. For this experiment, the models were further trained on thousands of bacteriophage genomes related to ΦX174.

AI did not invent a completely unrelated virus from nothing; it generated previously unseen ΦX174-like whole genomes within a known biological framework. Scientists selected some of these sequences, physically manufactured the DNA and introduced it into *E. coli*. If the genetic instructions were biologically coherent, the bacterial machinery produced new phage particles. 16 designs succeeded. The progression is striking: we learnt to read viral genomes, then to write them, then to



GETTY IMAGES

modify them. Now AI is beginning to help decide what should be written.

One finding shows why this matters. An AI-designed phage successfully combined a viral protein with other genetic changes in a way that conventional engineering had struggled to achieve. The significance is not simply that AI can propose individual mutations; it may increasingly be able to identify multiple genetic changes that work together across an entire genome, exploring combinations that would be extremely difficult for humans to test one by one.

The medical opportunity

The most immediate application may be phage therapy. Antibiotic resistance is steadily eroding conventional treatment options, while bacteriophages offer another way of killing bacteria. Their major limitation is specificity: a phage effective against one bacterial strain may fail against another, and bacteria can also develop resistance to phages. Traditionally, researchers have searched nature and phage libraries for suitable candidates or modified existing viruses. Generative biology introduces another possibility. Instead of asking only, "Can we find the phage we need?", medicine may increasingly ask, "Can we design the phage we need?"

The Stanford experiment offered an early demonstration. Combinations of AI-designed phages overcame resistance in *E. coli* strains against which the original ΦX174 failed. For clinicians confronting antimicrobial resistance, this is potentially important.

The possibilities extend beyond phage therapy. AI can assist the design of vaccine antigens, antibodies, therapeutic proteins and viral vectors used to deliver genetic treatments. It may eventually help optimise oncolytic viruses that selectively attack cancer cells. The larger revolution is therefore not simply 'AI making viruses'. It is AI becoming capable of designing biological function.

The danger is acceleration

It is tempting to be reassured because ΦX174 is an exceptionally simple bacteriophage, while dangerous human

viruses are vastly more complicated. Human pathogens must negotiate receptor binding, host range, tissue tropism, replication, immune escape and transmission. But complexity should not become false reassurance. Human scientists already understand much about these determinants. Decades of virology, reverse genetics and gain-of-function research have linked many genetic changes to viral behaviour.

AI does not need to rediscover virology. Its power lies in integrating what humanity already knows, examining vastly more combinations than humans can explore manually and accelerating the path from hypothesis to experimental design. This is the real biosecurity concern: capability amplification. The relevant question is not whether an untrained individual can ask today's chatbot to generate a pandemic virus. It is whether increasingly capable AI could make a knowledgeable and well-equipped laboratory substantially more effective at designing biological systems.

Future systems may compress months or years of literature review, modelling and experimental planning into much shorter cycles. Combined with increasingly automated laboratories, that acceleration could become profound. Even the apparently modest success rate in the Stanford study deserves this perspective. Only 16 of 285 designs worked, but digital systems can generate enormous numbers of candidates. A low success rate is reassuring only while the number of attempts remains small. Biosecurity will therefore also have to evolve. Traditional DNA-synthesis screening often asks whether an ordered sequence resembles a known pathogen or toxin. In the age of generative biology, researchers increasingly argue that screening must also consider biological function: not simply whether a sequence looks dangerous, but what it might actually do.

Safety without paralysing science

AI companies are already confronting this dilemma. Claude Fable 5 was initially deployed with strong safeguards around biology, chemistry and cybersecurity. Legitimate scientific work could

sometimes trigger a fallback to a less capable model. The intention was understandable, but the experience illustrated the problem: too little restriction creates risk, while too much restriction can obstruct legitimate science.

Those safeguards have since been refined to reduce false-positive biology fallbacks, while more sensitive capabilities remain restricted. This points towards a more practical model: graduated, auditable access in which legitimate researchers can obtain stronger capabilities under appropriate institutional and security controls. Biosecurity also cannot rest entirely on what an AI model agrees or refuses to answer. Safeguards are needed throughout the chain - AI systems, DNA-synthesis providers, laboratories and institutional biosafety oversight.

India must build capability

There is an important implication for India. If frontier AI becomes central to drug discovery, genomics, vaccines, protein engineering and experimental design, access to advanced AI becomes part of national scientific infrastructure. Smaller and specialised models will be sufficient for many tasks. But a country can choose to use a small model because it is sufficient; it should not be forced to use one because somebody else owns the frontier. If researchers elsewhere receive trusted access to highly capable biomedical models while Indian scientists depend on restricted public versions, the resulting disadvantage could accumulate across drug discovery, vaccines, antimicrobial resistance and other fields. India is already investing through the IndiaAI Mission and indigenous foundation-model programmes. That ambition should include scientific and biomedical AI, secure compute, high-quality datasets and trusted-access frameworks for legitimate researchers. AI sovereignty without biosecurity would be reckless; biosecurity without AI sovereignty could leave us scientifically dependent.

Governing biological intelligence

The Stanford experiment does not show that AI can casually manufacture dangerous human viruses. It shows something more precise: computers are beginning to move from analysing biological information towards proposing biological designs that scientists can physically build. That capability could transform antimicrobial resistance research, vaccines and therapeutics. It could also accelerate harmful biological engineering. The answer is neither prohibition nor unrestricted access, but controlled acceleration - allowing beneficial science to progress while safeguards increase with capability and risk.

The challenge is no longer simply whether AI should be allowed to understand biology. It is how we govern AI when understanding biology increasingly becomes the ability to design it. India must be capable not only of regulating and consuming that revolution, but of participating in its science and helping shape its safeguards. (Dr. Abdul Ghafur is a senior consultant in infectious diseases, Apollo Hospital, Chennai and coordinator, Chennai Declaration on AMR)



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

She dummied up when asked about the case

Three hours on the phone left Shreya with scroll fatigue

S. Upendran

"If you ask me, you should delete points 3 and 5. I don't think they..."

"What? In the meeting we had the day before, you insisted they be included. They were your brainchild."

"Really? I don't remember."

"Are you feeling okay? Or have you fallen victim to scroll fatigue again?"

"Scroll fatigue? What does..."

"There are times when we spend a lot of our time scrolling on the phone looking for interesting stuff to read or watch on social media."

"I spend nearly two hours every day scrolling. But scrolling doesn't make me tired."

"It doesn't make you physically tired, but it does mentally."

"That's probably because you focus really hard when you're scrolling. You are either reading or watching something with total concentration."

"That's right! You're processing a lot of new information very quickly."

"You're also making very quick decisions. Which article you want to read first, and when you have started reading it, whether you wish to continue reading it, etc."

"Very good! Most of the time, we don't feel the strain sneaking up on us. And when it does, we're not able to focus on anything; we become highly irritable. After spending three hours on the phone, Shreya experienced a severe case of scroll fatigue."

"I've never experienced scroll fatigue. I don't stay online for more than 15 minutes."

"That's hard to believe."

"That was just an example."

"Okay! The marathon session on the computer resulted in total scroll fatigue."

"I think scroll fatigue is going to become a bigger problem in the near future."

"Yes. Parents need to discourage..."

"They need to discourage children from using the phone and..."

"You encourage someone to do something. But you discourage someone from doing something. Here's an example. The father encouraged his children to read books. He discouraged them from watching movies."

"My parents always encouraged me to wake up early. They discouraged me from wasting money on movies."

"When my cousin Revathi said she was joining politics, all the elders in the family discouraged her from joining the profession."

"Did your cousin have a showdown with your uncles and aunts?"

"No, she was smart. When they asked her questions, she just dummied up."

"Dummied up?"

"One of the meanings of dummy is 'stupid'. But the word has another meaning as well. A model of a human being is also called a dummy. One of the meanings of the expression 'dummy up' is to remain silent."

"In other words, the person stops talking?"

"Exactly!"

"When my cousin Arun went to the States, he dummied up whenever a stranger asked him a question."

"In the case of Arun, he didn't have to dummy up. He is a dummy!"

upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Simulacrum:

something that looks like somebody/something else or that is made to look like somebody/something else

Synonyms: replica, effigy, imitation

Usage: The robot was a simulacrum of a human being.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/simulacrum

International Phonetic Alphabet: /sɪmjʊləkrəm/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Text & Context'

THE DAILY QUIZ

August is observed as 'Women in Translation' month. A quiz on women novelists and their translators

Joan Sony Cherian

QUESTION 1

This writer became the first physically disabled author to win the Akutagawa Prize, the most prestigious literary prize in Japan. Name the author who won her the prize. Also name the writer and its translator.

QUESTION 2

This novel won the Man Booker International Prize in 2018. Its author recently made some controversial statements regarding AI. Name the novel and the author.

QUESTION 3

This elusive Italian novelist

writes under a pen name. The last book in her famous quartet series was shortlisted for the International Booker Prize in 2016. Name her, the book and the series.

QUESTION 4

This author from Kerala has won most of the major literary awards the State has to offer. Her works in translation include *Hangwoman* and *Yellow is the Colour of Languishing*. Name her.

QUESTION 5

Noted feminist theorist Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak translated short stories of this prolific Bengali author. Name the author.

**Visual Question:**

This translator won the 2022 International Booker Prize for her work on a Hindi novel. Name her, the book, and its author. GETTY IMAGES

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz:

1. Which Maratha ruler appointed Bajirao I as Peshwa in 1720? **Ans: Chhatrapati Shahu I**

2. Bajirao I is particularly associated with which form of warfare, relying on speed, mobility and cavalry rather than slow, set-piece engagements? **Ans: Manoeuvre warfare**

3. Which Bundela ruler sought Bajirao's assistance against the Mughal commander Muhammad Khan Bangash? **Ans: Maharaja Chhatrasal of Bundelkhand**

4. Which battle of December 1737 saw Bajirao confront the Nizam and allied Mughal forces near a fortified town? **Ans: Battle of Bhopal**

5. Bajirao died in 1740 on the banks of which major river? **Ans: Narmada**

Visual: This is a copy of Bajirao I's handwriting. Identify the script used in it. **Ans: Modi script**

Early Birds: Arun Kumar Singh | Tito Shiladitya | Tamal Biswas

From Page One

U.S. MoU best way out of war, says Iran President

The Iranian security chief, whose remarks were his most extensive public comments since being named to the post earlier this month, said Iran would target oil-shipping routes out of the Persian Gulf if neighbouring countries join in on the U.S. efforts to hurt Tehran's economy.

Mr. Rezaei, a former Revolutionary Guard commander and military adviser to Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, was part of senior appointments widely seen as hardening Tehran's political and military stance.

Referring to the new wave of sanctions threatened by the U.S., Mr. Pezeshkian said that, thanks to U.S. President Donald Trump, Iran was "in a full-scale economic, military, and security war".

"He says he is imposing the most crushing and terrifying sanctions on Iran," Mr. Pezeshkian said.

"I understand we have many problems in society right now. We are trying to prevent these as much as we can," he said. "We are striving with all our hearts to overcome inflation, livelihood problems, unemployment, and to secure the future of the people, so that they can live with dignity and pride."

(With inputs from AFP)

Search continues for 22 from vessel that sunk

"Sustained monitoring and focused aerial search by Indian Navy P8I aircraft led to the successful detection of two floating lifeboats and oil slick near the reported position," the Navy posted on X.

According to Equasis, a global merchant shipping database, *Ocean Winner* (IMO 945530) was a 28-year-old vessel that could carry around 73,000 tonnes of cargo.

Built in 1998, it was 225 metres long and 32.26 metres wide, and was in its end-of-life period. Periodic inspections by national authorities uncovered several deficiencies. The last inspection by Bangladesh authorities in Chittagong this June reported three deficiencies, including in the ship's magnetic compass. *Ocean Winner* was covered by Protection and Indemnity insurance that would compensate for the loss of life. The insurance is up-to-date, starting from August 1, 2026. The ship has changed hands many times, starting with Greek ownership. The current owner is located in Fujian, China.

(With inputs from Saurabh Trivedi in New Delhi)

Doval heads to China with eyes on Xi's visit

Mr. Doval's visit follows a meeting between officials from both sides on August 6, under the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC) on border affairs, during which the situation along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) was reviewed. Both sides also "held detailed exchanges on issues related to boundary delimitation, border management, mechanism-building and trans-border cooperation," according to a statement.

At the previous round of SR talks when Mr. Wang visited India in August 2025, both sides agreed on "the need to take a political perspective of the overall bilateral relationship while seeking a fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable framework for settlement of the boundary question in accordance with the Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for Settlement of the India-China Boundary Question signed in 2005".

The 2005 agreement marked the conclusion of the first of a three-stage process to settle the long-running boundary dispute. Since then, both sides have been negotiating a framework to settle the dispute. The third stage will involve delimiting and demarcating the boundary on maps and on the ground.

'Early harvest' agreement

Recent references to the exchange of views on "border delimitation" suggest both sides are exploring an "early harvest" agreement in some areas, pending the agreement of a complete framework.

At last year's SR talks, both agreed on setting up an Expert Group under the WMCC "to explore Early Harvest in boundary delimitation in the India-China border areas", as well as the "creation of General Level Mechanisms in Eastern, and Middle Sectors, in addition to the existing General Level Mechanism in Western Sector."

Cong. flags 'abnormal' LS prorogation delay

The page from *Practice and Procedure of Parliament* posted by the Congress leader also stated that the President terminates a session of the House under Article 85(2) acting on the advice of the Prime Minister, and the Cabinet may be consulted before the advice is submitted.

The text also notes that prorogation "may take place any time, even while the House is sitting", but "usually... follows the adjournment of the sitting of the House sine die". Mr. Ramesh also said there have been instances when "adjournment and prorogation have taken place on the very same day".

India can become global shipbuilding hub: Rajnath

Minister says the defence sector must be self-reliant to ensure strategic autonomy; the country has a large workforce, steel companies and the willpower to adapt to new technologies, he adds

Senjuti Sengupta
Saurabh Trivedi
KOLKATA/NEW DELHI



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and West Bengal Chief Minister Suvedu Adhikari in Kolkata. PTI

A vacuum created by the declining capacities of traditional shipbuilding industries across the world presents a major opportunity for India to emerge as a global shipbuilding hub, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Sunday.

Mr. Singh was addressing a gathering in Kolkata after virtually presiding over the *Bhumi Pujan* ceremony for three expansion projects of the Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE) and two projects of Yatra India Ltd. (YIL).

The projects at GRSE's facilities in Kidderpore, Shalimar and Raichak are aimed at expanding India's shipbuilding and ship repair capabilities, while the two projects at YIL's Metal and Steel Factory, Ishapore, will strengthen indigenous metallurgical and precision manufacturing capabilities.

Mr. Singh said the projects reflected the government's vision of "aatma-

nirbharta [self-reliance]", "Make in India" and "Make for the World".

Referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Independence Day address, he said the defence sector must become fully self-reliant to ensure strategic autonomy.

"Self-reliance is not merely a policy; it is a force multiplier for battlefield capability," he said, adding that Operation Sindoor had demonstrated the importance of indigenous weapons and platforms.

The Defence Minister also emphasised the importance of quality assurance,

Self-reliance is not merely a policy; it is a force multiplier for battlefield capability, says Defence Minister

timely delivery and high-quality maintenance and reit services to strengthen India's capabilities and enable the country to emerge as a global shipbuilding hub.

New projects in Bengal

"The country has a large workforce, steel companies and the willpower to adapt to new technologies.

India is capable of seizing this opportunity to become a global shipbuilding hub," he said.

Mr. Singh said, "GRSE has delivered more than 100 vessels in recent years and has the potential to play a leading role in India's future shipbuilding ambitions. GRSE is building a cargo vessel for Germany, underlining the growing global recognition of India's shipbuilding capabilities."

He also said that the West Bengal government would take steps to usher in a "new renaissance of development".

"Change in Bengal took place for the development of the State. The news of closures and lockouts of factories in West Bengal has now been replaced by the launch of new projects," Mr. Singh said.

Mr. Singh said expanded manufacturing capacity would strengthen MSMEs.

"Our mindset should no longer be about what India needs to buy from the world. Instead, it should focus on what the world wants to buy from India," he said.

After taxi associations in Assam, Meghalaya bodies too call off stir

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Taxi associations in Meghalaya called off their stir on Sunday, a day after their Assam counterparts made a similar decision.

The announcement followed a meeting between representatives of these associations and Meghalaya's Deputy Chief Minister Sniawbhalang Dhar at the State Secretariat in Shillong.

Mr. Dhar, who met Assam Border Protection and Development Minister Atul Bora in Guwahati on Saturday, said the two State governments would collect reports on damaged vehicles to ensure compensation for those affected in Meghalaya and Assam. "Traffic will, henceforth, not be disturbed," Mr. Dhar said.

After Saturday's meeting, Assam-based taxi operators and pressure groups called off the blockade against Meghalaya-registered vehicles on the inter-State boundary. However, their Meghalaya counterparts continued to protest on Sunday.

Shillong-bound passengers were forced to get off at Umiam, 20 km short of Shillong, and hire Meghalaya-registered vehicles to move ahead.



Meghalaya CM said the States would ensure compensation for those affected. PTI

laya-registered vehicles to move ahead.

The All Khasi Meghalaya Tourist Taxi Association, which prevented Assam-registered vehicles from proceeding beyond Umiam during the day, defended its action. "Our main demand was compensation for Meghalaya vehicles damaged in Assam. We called off the protest after the government's assurance," a leader of the association said.

Violence during abikie rally by the Khasi Students' Union in Shillong on August 19 triggered the stand-off. Masked participants of the rally, armed with stones, sticks, and rods, attacked Assam-registered vehicles and assaulted bystanders.

Goyal to begin Japan visit today to boost trade, investments

Press Trust of India
TOKYO

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal is leading a 200-member business delegation to Japan on a four-day visit starting Monday to boost trade and investment ties between the two countries.

The visit assumes significance since Japan set an investment target last year of 10 trillion yen (about ₹60,000 crore) India over a decade. The Minister will travel to Tokyo, Nagoya, and Osaka. The business delegation has representatives from various sectors, ranging from manufacturing, semiconductors, clean energy, steel, automotive, financial services, healthcare and start-ups, industry chamber FICCI direc-

tor-general Jyoti Vij told presspersons in Tokyo.

In Tokyo, Mr. Goyal will hold a series of meetings with the top leadership of major Japanese conglomerates and industrial houses that have long been partners in India's growth, alongside a round-table with the Keidanren (Japan Business Federation), representing over 1,500 leading Japanese companies.

The visit will conclude in Osaka with an business roadshow, along with meetings with leading Japanese companies.

The visit will conclude in Osaka with an investors and business roadshow

Following student protests regarding the ongoing Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC) issues in Jharkhand, Ranchi Deputy Commissioner Manjunath Bhajantri on Sunday issued detailed guidelines for protests and rallies, making it mandatory to obtain prior permission from the competent authority.

Posting on X, Mr. Bhajantri said, "It is often observed that various sit-ins, protests, encirclements, processions, rallies, and public meetings are being organised at different locations, where sometimes the administration is not provided with prior necessary information. Due to such events, not only law and order and public safety but also traffic arrangements can be affected, causing difficulties in commuting for ordinary citizens."

The Deputy Commissioner added that for such events, it will be mandatory for the organisers to obtain permission in advance under the prescribed pro-

Prior permission must for protests, rallies: Ranchi Deputy Commissioner

Amit Bhelari
RANCHI



The official appealed to all political parties, voluntary organisations, and citizens to follow the law. SHASHI SEKHAR KASHYAP

cedure. "The organisers are appealed to provide the necessary information regarding the proposed programme to the administration in a timely manner. It will be necessary to provide information related to the proposed route, the date of the event, the start and end time, and the expected number of participants. Information about key individuals participat-

ing in the program should also be provided to the administration where necessary," Mr. Bhajantri wrote.

Safety, law and order

He clarified that the purpose of the arrangement for prior notice and permission is not to stop any peaceful and democratic programme, but to ensure necessary administrative arrangements for the safety of participants, law and order, traffic management, and the convenience of ordinary citizens.

He also appealed to all political parties, social and voluntary organisations, and ordinary citizens to follow the applicable law.

Meanwhile, the Ranchi Police urged citizens to not believe any information circulating on social media without verification.

CBI books former DGCA official over 'corruption'

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has registered a case against a former official of the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) and several aviation-related companies for alleged abuse of official position, extending undue favours to select flying training organisations and suspicious aircraft transactions, officials said.

The FIR alleged that the probe brought to light a "systematic network of corporate entities" controlled and managed by the immediate and extended family members of Captain Anil Gill, then director of flying training at the DGCA.

It said the case followed a complaint received by the CBI's Anti-Corruption Branch in Delhi on August 17.

HC questions police as probe into attack on Dalit family changes hands six times

The Hindu Bureau
JAIPUR

The police investigation into a case of alleged land encroachment and attack on a Dalit family in Rajasthan's Bharatpur district changed hands six times in the last two years, prompting the High Court to intervene. There was also a complete absence of supervisory review of the pending probe.

The victim, Jitendra Kumar, 24, a resident of Bharatpur's Bayana block, moved the High Court seeking a fair investigation, completion of the probe and filing of a chargesheet in the case. The first information report (FIR) was registered in May 2024, following an attack on Mr. Kumar and his family members.

The "politically influential" people who allegedly attacked the family in Kair village in a bid to encroach upon its agricultural land also registered an FIR

A Dalit rights group linked the delay with officials failing to comply with the SC/ST Act

against the victims. Though the police found the counter-case to be frivolous, the original case has been proved by as many as six investigating officers.

"Despite the lapse of 26 months and a provision in the Scheduled Castes/Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, for completion of probe in 60 days, the police have failed to act," Mr. Kumar said in his writ petition. The investigating officers included a Circle Officer and five Additional Superintendents of Police, including one serving in the civil rights cell.

The offences for which 12 accused belonging to the Gujar community were

booked under the Indian Penal Code and the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act included rioting, attempt to commit culpable homicide, causing grievous hurt, unlawful assembly, criminal trespass and criminal intimidation.

Persistent harassment

The present investigating officer, Dinesh Kumar Meena, stated in the High Court that the offences against the accused had been proved and the result of the probe would be submitted in the trial court within two weeks.

Justice Shubha Mehta at the High Court's Jaipur Bench observed earlier this week that the failure to complete the investigation in time was "concerning" and no satisfactory reason had been given for the delay. The petitioner also stated that calling him to join the probe every time

after the change of hands amounted to his harassment. The court directed the Public Prosecutor to obtain affidavits from all investigating officers named in the factual report, "explaining why the probe was not completed in 60 days and reasons for the subsequent delay".

Similar affidavits were also sought from the officers forming the supervisory committee under Rule 7(3) of the SC/ST (PoA) Act.

Welcoming the High Court's order, the Centre for Dalit Rights (CDR) said here on Sunday that the investigation could have been completed and the accused arrested if the authorities had complied with the statutory review mechanism.

The members of the supervisory committee under the Home Secretary, Director-General of Police, Social Justice & Empowerment Secretary, and Director of Prosecution.

Death toll in Gujarat hooch tragedy rises to 13

Press Trust of India
BHAVNAGAR

The death toll due to the consumption of spurious liquor in Gujarat's Bhavnagar district went up to 13 on Sunday after two more victims died during treatment, officials said.

Three other persons were still in hospital, they said.

In the last two days, five persons have lost their lives. Mukesh Damor, 36 and Bhargav Upadhyay, 42 are the latest victims of the hooch tragedy. With their death, the number of victims has gone up to 13, the officials said.

Upadhyay was undergoing treatment at a private hospital, while Damor was admitted to the civil hospital. According to officials, 67 persons had consumed the liquor containing methanol, a highly toxic substance.

BJP president holds strategy meeting for Assembly elections

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Sunday held a meeting with the party's office-bearers to discuss a range of organisational matters, especially the strategy for high-stakes Assembly elections due in seven States next year, including Uttar Pradesh and Gujarat, sources said.

The crucial meeting was attended by the newly appointed office-bearers of the party, presidents of its State units and other key functionaries. Those in charge of the BJP State units were also present at the meeting held at the BJP headquarters here, according to the sources.

BJP national general secretary (organisation) B.L. Santhosh was also present at the meeting, which delved into measures for strengthening grassroots outreach and youth connect, especially in the States where elections are due next year, the sources said.

There was no official word from the BJP on what transpired in the meeting.

Assembly polls are due in Punjab, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Goa, Himachal Pradesh and Gujarat



Nitin Nabin

in 2027. The BJP is in power in five of these poll-bound States, except Punjab and Himachal Pradesh. While the Aam Aadmi Party currently rules Punjab, the Congress is in power in Himachal Pradesh.

"It is a crucial meeting to discuss a range of organisational matters with prime focus on the party's preparations and strategy for the upcoming elections in States next year," a source said.

This comes a day after Mr. Nabin held his first meeting with all newly appointed national office-bearers of the party. Former office-bearers of BJP's national team were also present. Prime Minister Narendra Modi also interacted with the 67 newly-appointed office-bearers of the party.

Help operationalise women's reservation: Smriti to Rahul

BJP general secretary asks Leader of Opposition to support the PM's initiative on providing 33% reservation for women; she appeals for full rendition of *Vande Mataram* at Cong. headquarters

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) general secretary Smriti Irani challenged the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi to demonstrate his publicly expressed sentiments on women's empowerment by offering support to the government's Bills, which could operationalise the Women's Reservation Act, 2023. Ms. Irani's remarks came after Mr. Gandhi's speech at the Congress's 'Chaatron ki Goonj' (echo of students) event in Pune on Sunday.

Mr. Gandhi had addressed a gathering of mainly women students at the public meeting. He had sharp words for the government's approach on women's empowerment, and the docking of women protesters at the Gen Z protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party at Jantar Mantar in the national capital in July.

The Modi government had, in April 2026, brought a Bill for the delimitation of Lok Sabha seats in tandem



BJP national general secretary Smriti Irani during a meeting at the party headquarters in New Delhi on Saturday. PTI

with amendments to the Women's Reservation Act, which would increase seats in the Lower House to 850 based on the 2011 Census, with 33% reservation for women. The Opposition defeated the Constitution amendment Bill, and the Congress Working Committee said that it was in favour of freeing Lok Sabha seats at 543, and 33% reservation for women to be implemented for the 2029 general election.

Ms. Irani, in a statement in New Delhi, spoke of the Bill linking delimitation to reservation for women. "Former national president

of the Congress party stated at an event that he supports women. Today, I would like to make a request to the former national president. Prime Minister Modi has passed a law providing 33% reservation for women across the country, enabling them to enhance the dignity of the nation's Parliament. Prime Minister Modi has appealed to all political parties to cooperate with him in the swift implementation of this women's reservation law. I humbly ask him to support the Prime Minister's initiative, specifically the swift implementation

of the law providing 33% reservation for women and enabling them to take on leadership roles in Parliament," the former Union Minister said.

National Song rendition

Ms. Irani added that she was also "aware of" certain remarks made by Mr. Gandhi about the Hindu religion and appealed for the full rendition of *Vande Mataram* at the Congress headquarters.

"I am also aware that remarks regarding the Hindu religion were made at that Congress leader's event yesterday. Given that he has invoked religion, I make one further request to that leader – the lines of *Vande Mataram* that were halted at the Congress headquarters actually contain a reference to Goddess Durga. Regarding Mother Durga, whom we worship as the embodiment of Shakti, the full rendition and singing of *Vande Mataram* should take place at the Congress headquarters. This would reflect the interest and inclination they have shown towards women's issues," she said.

Haryana Congress leaders seek action against Deepender

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM

Amid a political controversy over Rohtak MP Deepender Singh Hooda's remarks on the late Sajjan Kumar, senior Haryana Congress leaders have sought action against him, saying that his comments could hurt the party's prospects among the Sikh community.

Mr. Hooda, meanwhile, issued a video statement on Sunday expressing regret over the controversy and said his earlier remarks had been distorted. He clarified that he had not described Kumar as a "role model", adding that never intended to hurt the sentiments of the Sikh community.

'Immature remarks'

Former Haryana Assembly Speaker Kuldip Sharma has written to Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge seeking Mr. Hooda's removal as a permanent invitee to the Congress Working Committee. Describing the remarks as "immature" and "irresponsible", Mr. Sharma said such statements were particularly damaging at a time when Punjab is heading towards Assembly election.

Mr. Sharma told *The Hindu* that Sikh voters had supported the Congress in the 2024 Lok Sabha election despite the party's alleged association with the legacy of the 1984 anti-Sikh riots.

"Punjab elections are at our threshold. Such an irresponsible statement is going to harm the pros-



Deepender Singh Hooda

pects of the party in Punjab," he said, adding that instead of assuaging the feelings of Sikhs, a party leader had made comments in support of Kumar.

Sajjan Kumar, a former Congress leader, was convicted in a 1984 anti-Sikh riots case. His death three days ago triggered Mr. Hooda's remarks, in which he described Kumar as a prominent political figure whose connect with people was an example for others to follow.

Congress leader Shamsher Singh Goli, said such remarks reopened the wounds of families affected by the 1984 anti-Sikh violence and undermined the Congress's efforts to rebuild its relationship with the Sikh community.

BJP slams Congress

Haryana BJP president Archana Gupta criticised the Congress over the controversy. In a post on Facebook, she said the memories of the 1984 violence remained alive among thousands of Sikh families and demanded that the Congress leadership clarify what action it would take against Mr. Hooda.

Bengal govt. appoints BJP legislators to lead college bodies

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in West Bengal has appointed MLAs and MPs belonging to the party as presidents of governing bodies in more than 200 government-aided colleges across the State.

The Suwendu Adhikari government, after coming to power in Bengal in early May, had dissolved the governing bodies that were helmed by legislators from the Trinamool Congress.

A notification issued by the West Bengal Higher Education Department pointed out that president of college governing body have been appointed for 247 State-run colleges.

Some of the BJP leaders appointed to head college governing bodies include Health Minister Sharadwat Mukherjee, who has been appointed president of the governing body of East Kolkata Girls College, and Minister of State for Fire Services Kaushik Chowdhury, who has been appointed head of the managing com-

Suwendu Adhikari
had promised to
make educational
institutions free
of politics

mittee of Raiganj B.Ed. College. Union Minister of State and Balurghat MP Sukanta Majumdar has been made president of the governing body of Balurghat College, while the Speaker of West Bengal Assembly, Rathindra Bose, has been made the president of Coochbehar College.

State Higher Education Minister Jagannath Chattopadhyay said there was nothing unusual in these appointments. The Minister said that those who have a Bachelor's degree have been made presidents of college governing bodies.

'Free of politics'

"Local MLAs and MPs are members of the college management committee ex officio. In that case, those who have a Bachelor's degree have been made presidents. This go-

vernment will not allow the educational field to become a playground for politics in any way," the Minister said.

After coming to power in West Bengal, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari had promised to make educational institutions free of politics. "We have cancelled the political nominations that were in various schools, colleges and universities with the aim of making educational institutions free from political influence. Because, making educational insti-

tutions free from politics and giving autonomy to universities – these should be our priorities," the Chief Minister had said.

Political observers see the move of appointing BJP MLAs and MPs as president of college governing bodies as a departure from what the BJP had promised. The culture of having politicians at the helm of State-run colleges had been prevalent during the Left Front regime and there was no exception to this in the Trinamool Congress regime.

CJP to review status of Centre's assurances; to keep options 'open'

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) will convene a meeting of its national working committee on Monday to review the status of the commitments made by the Centre following the withdrawal of its nationwide agitation on July 25. The outfit stated that the government is yet to formally

communicate the steps being taken to fulfil the assurances.

The CJP said it will consider all steps to secure fulfilment of the commitments, including the possibility of launching another peaceful nationwide agitation.

"The CJP called off its agitation in good faith because the government gave its word to the young peo-

ple of this country," it said, adding that it would not allow that "good faith" to be mistaken for "weakness".

This comes days after the Supreme Court sought a consolidated list of FIRs registered against students and protesters across the country on August 18. "Despite the court repeatedly asking for this list, the Centre did not commit to providing it," the CJP said.

कोल इंडिया लिमिटेड
(एक भारतीय कंपनी)

*All the tenders issued by CIL and its Subsidiaries for procurement of Goods, Works and Services are available on website of Coal India Ltd. www.coalindia.in / respective Subsidiary Company, CIL e-procurement portal <https://coalindiaindia.in> and Central Procurement Portal <https://e-procurement.gov.in>. In addition, procurement is also done through GeM portal <https://gem.gov.in>.

REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RFP)

RFP No. 251/2026

Proposals are invited for "Selection of a Co-Developer to Develop, Build and Operate a Mixed Use Facility in Technopark Phase I Campus, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala".

The last date of submission of RFP is 23.09.2026.

For further details, please visit <https://www.technopark.in/tenders>

Date: 21-08-2026 Chief Executive Officer
Trivandrum D3/498/2026/IS&PRD Technopark

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA - DEPARTMENT OF SPACE CONSTRUCTION & MAINTENANCE GROUP, SDSC - SHAR SRIHARIKOTA - 524124

Brief E-TENDER NOTICE

No: SHAR: CMG CIVIL-MAINT-E-PT-0826-27 Dt: 21.08.2026

On behalf of President of India, Item Rate tenders are invited through e-tendering for following works:

Name of Work	Tender No	Estimate Cost
Term Contract for Civil works @KRRP(PCN) Colony, Sullurupeta.	T/C-26-016	₹ 80 Lakhs
Term Contract for Civil works @SMN & PNN Colonies, Sullurupeta.	T/C-26-017	₹ 80 Lakhs
Term Contract for Painting works of facility buildings and residential quarters for one year @SDSC SHAR.	T/C-26-018	₹ 75 Lakhs

Tender documents can be downloaded up to 07.09.2026, 14:30 hrs. For eligibility criteria and other details, interested tenderers may please refer to the detailed bilingual (Hindi-English) Notice Inviting Tenders (NIT) on the website <https://www.isro.gov.in/Tenders.html> and tender free view at <https://www.tenderwizard.com/isro>

Sd/- GROUP HEAD, CMG/SDSC SHAR

Uttarakhand Tourism Development Board (UTDB)
Pt. Deendayal Upadhyay Parvatan Bhawan,
Near O.N.G.C. Helipad, Nimbuwala, Garhi Cantt, Dehradun - 248003 (UK),
Ph. 91-135-2559898, Fax, 91-135-2559988

Ref. No: 3002/2-7-1035/2026-27 Dated: 22/08/2026

SELECTION OF A TRAINING AGENCY FOR OUTDOOR EDUCATION, WILDERNESS MEDICINE & GUIDE CAPACITY BUILDING

Details may be obtained on website: uktenders.gov.in from 3:00 PM on 24.08.2026. Pre-bid meeting will be held at 12:30 PM on 31.08.2026.

Prospective Bidders may seek clarification till 3:00 PM on 29.08.2026 through E-mail: adventurewingutdb@gmail.com with CC to procurement.utdb@gmail.com. Any Addendum / Corrigendum including date extension will be uploaded on uktenders.gov.in.

Proposals must be submitted online through uktenders.gov.in. The last date for submission of proposals is 14.09.2026 till 3:00 PM.

Chief Executive Officer

TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH LIMITED
(A Government of Andhra Pradesh Undertaking & An ISO 27001:2022 Certified Company)

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The APTRANSCO invites bids online for Spec.No.PM/32-e/17/2026 Supply of 30 Nos. 220V, 100AH Battery Chargers with separate DC/DC and 28 Nos. 220V, 200AH Battery Chargers with separate DC/DC. Date & Time of availability of above tender: 27.08.2026 at 6:00PM. Website: www.tender.approcurement.gov.in. Contact No. CE/Transmission: 0866-2429230. E-Mail: gmcc@aptransco12262627@gmail.com Sd/- CHIEF ENGINEER/TRANSMISSION

BANGALORE ELECTRICITY SUPPLY COMPANY LIMITED
(Wholly Owned by Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
(CIN:UJ04010KA2002SGC030438)

BRIEF TENDER NOTIFICATION (Through KPP portal)

BESCOM invites tender for the following Enquiry No.: **BESCOM/2026-27/EL/ WORK_INDENT1166-1174** through KPP Portal for eligible bidders for "Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning (SITC) of Electric Vehicle Public Charging Stations (EVPCS) and associated equipment, along with Bidder-led Operation & Maintenance (O&M), at Government-owned locations across Karnataka under Category-A and Category-B of the PM E-DRIVE Scheme, on a cluster-wise basis".

For the above Work: Bid document available from **31-08-2026 at 11:00 am** Onwards.

The Bid documents can be downloaded and necessary assistance can be obtained from Karnataka Public Procurement Portal (KPPPP) website <https://kpppp.karnataka.gov.in>. Aspiring bidders need to register on KPP portal. Further, bidders can take assistance with KPP portal helpdesk at 9240214000, 9240214001.

Sd/-
Download BESCOM Mitra Mobile APP General Manager (El.)
DSM & EV, BESCOM

THE TAMIL NADU CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' FEDERATION LIMITED
THE JOINT MANAGING DIRECTOR, No. 29 & 30 Ambattur Industrial Estate,
Ambattur, Chennai-600098, Phone 044-2464220/301512 E-Mail avnrt@tnmilk.com
Ref. No. 177/RMT/TP/2026 Date: 21.08.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (e-Submission)
(Only through e-Procurement Portal at www.tntenders.gov.in)

The TCMFP Ltd. Invites TWO PART TENDERS by way of e-Submission through e-Procurement Portal from Private tender providers/Contractors for following contract works.

Sl.No.	Name of the items/work	EMD (In Rs.)
1	Hiring of 9 KL, 15 KL, 20 KL and 30 KL capacity Road Milk Tankers on Contract for 3 years for Transportation of Milk with & outside State of Tamil Nadu	Rs. 20,000/-

Tender document Availability The tender document can be downloaded from website e-Procurement Portal <https://tntenders.gov.in> from 28.08.2026 to 30.09.2026 upto 3.00 PM

Date & Time of Pre-Bid meeting	10.09.2026 at 11.00 AM
Date & Time of closing of e-Submission of Technical Bid and Financial Bid	30.09.2026 upto 3.00 PM
Date & Time of Opening of Part 1 Technical Bid of e-Tender	The Technical Bids shall be opened through online e-Procurement Portal https://tntenders.gov.in on following date at above mentioned address 01.10.2026 at 11.30 AM

The tenderer should submit their bids only through e-Procurement Portal <https://tntenders.gov.in>. All other details can be seen in the tender documents. Corrigendum/Addendum to this publication, if any would appear only on the above said website.

JOINT MANAGING DIRECTOR
The Tamilnadu Co-op. Milk Producers' Fedn. Ltd.,
DIPR/2648/Tender/2026

TAMILNADU MEDICAL SERVICES CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of Tamilnadu Undertaking)
No. 417, Pantheeran Road, Egmore, Chennai - 600008.
Phone: 044-2619 1890, 2319 0259 Website: www.tnmsc.coop.in
E-Mail: gm@tnmsc.coop.in, mn@tnmsc.coop.in, mn@tnmsc.coop.in

Online Tender is invited by the Tender Inviting Authority, Tamilnadu Medical Services Corporation Ltd., Chennai - 600008, from Licensed Drugs and Medicines Manufacturers having three years Market Standing and holding Good Manufacturing Practice Certificate (as per latest revised Schedule "M" of D&C Act, 1940) issued by the Drugs Control Authority, Direct Importers holding a valid Import License and experienced for a minimum period of three years and Loan Licensees having valid Loan License are also eligible to participate in this tender.

Sl. No	Description	e-Tender Reference	Tender Floating Period	e-Tender Submission Duration	Date and time of online opening of Technical Bids
1	Online Re-Tender for the supply of Speciality Drugs to TNMSO (Limited under rate contract system for one year from the date of acceptance)	e-020(MP)/RE-SPL/DRUGS/ TNMSO/2026, Dated, 24.08.2026	24.08.2026 at 4.00 PM to 23.09.2026 upto 3.00 PM	31.08.2026 at 10.00 AM to 23.09.2026 upto 3.00 PM	23.09.2026 at 4.00 PM

The tender document can be downloaded and the tender shall be submitted at <https://tntenders.gov.in>. The tender document can also be downloaded at www.tnmsc.coop.in for reference purpose.

DIPR/ 2614 /Tender/2026 Tender Inviting Authority / General Manager (Drugs)

IN BRIEF



Assam in final stage of partner selection to build satellite: CM

The Assam government is in an advanced stage of evaluation to select a partner from the private sector to launch its own satellite, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said on Sunday. Claiming that Assam will be the first State in India to have its own earth observation system, he said that the government will have the satellite under the "DBLOTT model", which is design, build, launch, operate, train and transfer. "Following strong interest from India's private space sector companies, we are now in the final and critical stage of partner selection, with dedicated committees evaluating the proposals," Mr. Sarma said in a social media post.

Indian expat killed, 9 injured after vehicle crashes in Oman

One Indian national was killed, and nine others were injured after a vehicle veered off the road in Oman, police said. The incident occurred on Saturday on Sultan Said bin Teymur Street. The police Air Wing carried out an operation to transport two of the injured from Al Hema Governorate to Nizwa Hospital, the Royal Oman Police said in a post on X. "The incident resulted in one fatality and injuries to nine people of Indian nationality, who were subsequently transferred to Nizwa Hospital by ambulance for medical treatment," it said.

'No new H1N1 strain in India, existing vaccines sufficient'

Influenza strains circulating are well matched with the vaccine strains, and the seasonal flu is self-limiting, ICMR says, adding that people with underlying conditions are at risk of complication

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) on Sunday said that the Influenza A (H1N1) viruses currently circulating in the country belong to the A/Missouri/11/2025 (H1N1) pdm09-like virus strain. It clarified that no new strain of H1N1 has been identified and there is no cause for panic.

"These viruses belong to clade 6B.1A.5a2a, sub-clade D.3.1.1, and have been in circulation since 2025. The Influenza strains currently circulating are also well matched with the vaccine strains recommended for the Northern Hemisphere," the ICMR said.

"Seasonal influenza, including H1N1, is mostly self-limiting," it added.

Common symptoms of the illness include fever, cough, headache, and body ache, and most people recover with appropriate care and rest.

However, young children, elderly persons, and



Patients wait at the swine flu (H1N1) outpatient department in Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital in New Delhi in 2015. V. SUDERSHAN

individuals with underlying medical conditions may be at a greater risk of complications. If symptoms persist, worsen, or become severe, consultation with a doctor is advised, it said.

The Union Health Ministry has said that it is closely monitoring the situation through regular surveillance and is undertaking necessary public health measures.

India has registered a rise in seasonal Influenza A (H1N1) cases, commonly called swine flu, this mon-

soon, especially in major cities. Delhi has reported 1,777 confirmed H1N1 cases so far this year, including 114 new cases on August 20. Karnataka has registered over 4,000 cases, with more than half reported from Bengaluru. Rising influenza activity has also been reported in Mumbai, Chennai and parts of Kerala.

Past trends The National Centre for Disease Control (NCDC) data show that H1N1 activity was relatively low in 2021

(778 cases, 12 deaths) after the pandemic period, but rebounded sharply in 2022 (13,202 cases, 410 deaths) and remained substantial in 2023 (8,125 cases, 129 deaths). By June 2024, India had already recorded 7,215 cases and 150 deaths, and year-end numbers were higher. The NCDC's 2025 reporting shows that H1N1 continued to circulate across multiple States.

The NCDC maintains a nationwide influenza surveillance network and publishes State-wise data and H1N1 treatment/prevention guidelines. It recommends seasonal influenza vaccination based on WHO strain recommendations. For the 2025-26 season, India's recommended trivalent vaccine included H1N1, H3N2 and B/Victoria components, with circulating Indian H1N1 strains aligning with vaccine strains.

"People at higher risk should consider annual vaccination and seek medical advice promptly if flu symptoms become severe," Anil Bansal of the Delhi Medical Association said.

PM calls upon space start-ups to make India a talent hub

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has called upon India's private space sector to build an ecosystem that can attract global talent, companies, and investment, saying the country should create an "aura" that makes it a destination for people seeking to build careers in the sector.

Mr. Modi's remarks came during an interaction with CEOs and founders of 20 Indian space start-ups in Delhi on Friday, the transcript of which was made public on Sunday, coinciding with the third National Space Day. The day is observed on August 23 to commemorate the Chandrayaan-3 landing on the moon in 2023.

"You have shown courage in entering a new field," Mr. Modi told the entrepreneurs. "We should create such an aura that people around the world feel that if they want to build a future in this field, they should come to India," he said. "India's space sector can become a magnet for the global talent pool."

Mr. Modi highlighted India's cost competitiveness



Prime Minister Narendra Modi interacted with the founders of space start-ups on Friday.

and talent, saying these advantages could help the country quickly establish itself in the global space industry. He urged start-ups to look beyond space applications and work with sectors such as agriculture, livestock, and dairy, as well as with organisations that work for the environment to improve lives.

The entrepreneurs outlined a range of ambitions. Skyroot Aerospace, represented by its co-founder and CEO, Pawan Kumar Chandana, highlighted plans to scale rocket production and launches after its July 18 orbital mission.

He urged the start-ups to work with Atal Tinkering Labs to nurture interest in space among school children.

SC committee pulls up Assam government for inaction over mining activity near Kaziranga

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Amid a controversy over a plan to reduce the Eco-Sensitive Zone of Kaziranga National Park, a Supreme Court-constituted panel has pulled up the Assam government over its handling of mining on the southern boundary of the one-horned rhino habitat.



The CEC said the government did not address the issue near the Parkur Pahar Range.

The Central Empowered Committee (CEC) said the government did not address the issue in and around the Parkur Pahar Range, a declared wildlife sanctuary and vital ecological corridor, with the seriousness it deserved. The latest development follows a June 15 Right to Information (RTI) application filed by environmental activist Rohit Choudhury, seeking details of compliance with the CEC's directions to the Assam Chief Secretary on May 30, 2025.

Mr. Choudhury sought the comprehensive Watershed Drainage Analysis Report along with quarterly status reports on action taken against reported violations.

The CEC's July 17 response to the RTI stated it did not receive the comprehensive Watershed Drainage Analysis Report. It also said the quarterly status reports had been attached, but the response does not show that the wa-

tershed exercise the CEC ordered was completed.

The CEC had fixed October 2025 as the deadline for submitting the watershed report.

The issue predates the RTI application. In its May 30, 2025, report on "Application No.1592 of 2024", the CEC recorded allegations of renewed mining in Parkur Pahar despite the Supreme Court's April 12, 2019, order restraining all mining and related activities along the southern boundary of Kaziranga and throughout the catchments of rivers and streams originating in the Karbi Anglong hills and flowing into the park.

The same order prohibited new construction on private lands forming part of nine identified animal corridors.

On March 3, the CEC wrote to the Assam Chief Secretary, noting that mining and related activities had been going on "in

some way on one pretext or the other", and that the Karbi Anglong Autonomous Council (KAAC) was not presenting a holistic picture to the courts. The KAAC administers Karbi Anglong, the district that forms Kaziranga's southern boundary.

Termining the issues sensitive, the CEC asked the Chief Secretary to take immediate action. The letter further noted the failure to identify the catchment areas of the streams and rivers originating in the Karbi Anglong hills even after more than six years. "The committee, vide its letter dated May 6, 2021, specifically requested that the action taken by the State government to notify the animal corridors connecting KNP be communicated to the committee at the earliest. However, no response has been received from the State government," it stated.

The panel also pointed

to areas of the Karbi Anglong Elephant Reserve (covering Karbi Anglong and Kaziranga National Park) which had been ravaged by large-scale mining and the death of several elephants due to conflicts with humans. It questioned how mining leases around Borjuri could have been sanctioned at all, given that the area forms part of the elephant reserve.

"The KAAC seems oblivious of all these notifications and is not conscious of the measures that need to be taken to protect the ecology and wildlife of the area," the CEC said.

In its latest communication, the panel, reiterating that its May 30, 2025 recommendations remain unimplemented, asked the government to ensure speedy implementation of all its recommendations and immediately notify the nine identified animal corridors.

Systemic problems, sabotage behind delays in Annapurna scheme aid: Bengal BJP chief

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

West Bengal BJP president Samik Bhattacharya on Sunday attributed delays in disbursing benefits under the Annapurna Bhandar scheme to "system problems" and alleged attempts to sabotage amid protests across the State by women over non-payment.

"There are some deviations and problems with the system. In some places, attempts are being made to sabotage it. That is why this has happened," Mr. Bhattacharya said.

Under the scheme, eligible women are entitled to receive aid of ₹3,000 a month. Several women who applied within the stipulated period and were found eligible have alleged that they did not receive the money by August 20, the deadline set by the State government.



Samik Bhattacharya

Mr. Bhattacharya assured the beneficiaries that the payments would reach them. "I am saying that everyone will get the Annapurna money," the State BJP president said.

He said nearly 50 lakh more women are entitled to be brought under the scheme and claimed that only a small proportion of beneficiaries had not received the money. "Another nearly 50 lakh women will receive the benefits. Only 2-3% have not received the money. Everyone will get

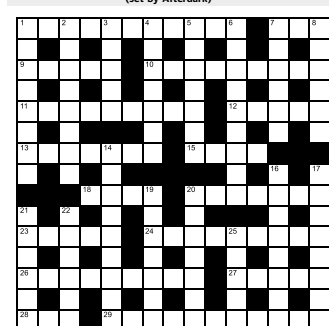
it," he added. Mr. Bhattacharya's remarks came amid protests in several parts of the State by women who claimed that they had completed the application and verification process but were yet to receive the assistance.

Chief Minister Suvedu Adhikari and State government officials have repeatedly assured beneficiaries that all eligible women would receive the money.

Trinamool targeted Mr. Bhattacharya also blamed the previous Trinamool Congress government for alleged irregularities in the earlier Lakshmi Bhandar scheme.

"The kind of fraudulent practices that took place during the Trinamool Congress government, where men received Lakshmi Bhandar benefits, will not happen in the Annapurna Yojana," he said.

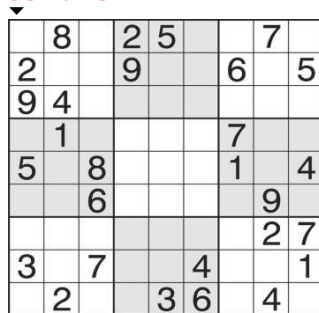
THE CROSSWORD



- Across**
- Mediation about last daughter's two shares (11)
 - Catch a policeman (3)
 - Belief of socialist lies in Cuba's offensive (5)
 - Say, extractor frequently upsets a soldier on a hill (9)
 - Final offer to retain e-reader, perhaps son renews (9)
 - Dismiss English judge at London area approached by leading tout (5)

- Down**
- A catholic clergy is faithful (8)
 - Escape from engagement; trapped spinster ultimately finds energy to take a risk at the end (5,3)
 - Spike is absent, in short a sham (5)
 - Free sailors, essentially told to take vaccine at the borders (7)
 - Limp ass escapes within a dead end (7)
 - Hector insured, ma got covered with nanny (9)
 - Say, editor is seen in a sailing vessel... (6)
 - ... with good judge and sea robber (6)
 - Readily available gift, rep in hurry (9)
 - Protective clothing for artist in action shoot (8)
 - I handle leadership city to a state of being perfect (8)
 - Say, Bush's passion runs on that woman (7)
 - IMO, play should be reorganised at a plain in Greece (7)
 - Cavalryman's network primarily collects Euro to begin rehabilitation (6)
 - Jumped to the step of a ladder after a small gap ultimately (6)
 - Meaning of feeling (5)

SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★



FAITH

In praise of Surya

Sage Dhaumya told Yudhishtira the names by which Surya is worshipped, said Kidambi Narayanan in a discourse. Following the sage's advice, Yudhishtira worshipped the sun. Surya is Aryama – the honourable one. He is tvashtha – the creator, pusha – the one who nourishes, aja – the unborn one, kala – time, mrityu – death, and daata – the bestower of everything. He manifests as Brihaspathi (Jupiter), Sukra (Venus), Budha (Mercury) and Angaraka (Mars). Surya is vedakarta – the originator of the Vedas, and vedavahana – he carries the Vedas. He is lokadhyaaksha – one who watches over the world. He is jimatul, because he sustains the world as clouds do. He is Bhutashraya – the one who supports all beings. He is Bhutapati – the king of all beings. Surya is Vishaala – the one with a huge form. He is Jaya (victorious), Varada (giver of boons). He is Ananta – infinite. He is Suparna – like Garuda in his brightness. He is Bhutadith – the origin of all life. He is Aravindaksha – the lotus eyed one. He is pita (father), mata (mother) and pitamaha (grandfather) of all beings.

When Yudhishtira worshipped Surya, the latter gave him a vessel, which would provide food for countless people every day. The vessel would yield unlimited quantities of vegetables, fruits, rice and greens. Thus, Yudhishtira's worry about how to look after the sadhus who were with him was taken care of. Vaisampayana tells Janamejaya the mantra through which Yudhishtira worshipped Surya. He tells Janamejaya that the mantra must be recited with the mind under control. Anyone who recites these names at sunrise will be blessed with knowledge and courage. He will gain knowledge about his previous births too.

MONEYWISE

Informed consumers can shape insurance markets

Amit Chhabra

One of the defining characteristics of mature consumer markets is not simply the abundance of products, but the quality of consumer decision-making. Across sectors, rising financial awareness, easier access to information and digital discovery are changing what people choose to buy and how they choose to buy. Consumers now expect to evaluate multiple options, understand trade-offs and make decisions based on their individual needs rather than limited visibility.

Well-functioning markets around the world have something in common - informed choices. Insurance is undergoing the same shift. As customers become more informed and digitally engaged, purchasing decisions are becoming more deliberate, more comparison-led and ultimately more aligned with individual protection needs. While not necessarily the cheapest, the chosen product is often the one delivers the greatest value.

The data is starting to reflect this shift. Nearly 75% of customers on our platform now compare at least three plans before choosing one.

That effort is certainly paying off. Customers who compare policies end up paying, on average, at least 20 per cent lower premiums for similar levels of coverage than those who buy without comparison. In an industry that still suffers from low awareness and limited product understanding, this comes as a welcome change.

Here's what the data tells us about changing consumer outlook: Amid rising healthcare costs, consumers want to better understand the quality of financial protection they are signing up for. Two policies may appear similar on paper, but they can actually differ significantly.

For instance, the premium for a ₹10 lakh family floater health plan for a young family of 3 in Delhi ranges from ₹773 to ₹2,426 per month, which means -68% difference in price.

This is also visible among senior citizen plans. For a 62-year-old couple in Delhi with pre-existing conditions, the range is from ₹2,423 to ₹5,562 per month, which shows close to 60% variation in premium from options available to them.

The variation comes from factors like whether the policy has room-rent limits, co-payment clauses, restoration benefits, and optional riders, among others.

Similarly, when it comes to term insurance, age and habits can make all the difference.

For a 30-year-old salaried non-smoker seeking ₹1 crore cover until age 60, monthly premiums can range from ₹635 to ₹958, representing a difference of about 50%. For a 30-year-old woman seeking ₹1 crore cover, monthly premiums range from ₹551 to ₹812, while for a 35-year-old woman, premiums range from ₹633 to ₹975 for a similar profile.

Some interesting trends come to light when we analyse these buying patterns. In health insurance, first-time buyers tend to be more price-sensitive, and use comparison primarily to reduce premiums. Repeat buyers, however, engage more deeply with features, claims experience, and long-term value. Comparison engagement is highest among customers aged 28-45, particularly families. This group reflects a segment that is both digitally active and financially conscious. Preferred network, deductibles, co-pay, and single private room are add-ons or features that are most commonly traded off for lower premiums.

In term insurance, claim settlement indicators emerge as the single most influential comparison feature among buyers. Claim settlement ratios are an important measure of confidence that their family's claim will be honoured even in their absence.

When customers make informed choices, they look for better value for money. So, the market forces respond by improving product quality, increasing affordability, simplifying the offering, and most importantly, strengthening the claims experience.

(The author is Chief Business Officer, General Insurance, Policybazaar)



Instead of putting a large sum into bonds that all mature together, the investor spreads the maturities over several years. ILLUSTRATION: B. SAINATH

Stagger your bonds and steady your cash flow

You don't have to take the pain of predicting interest rates - staggering bond maturities can spread risk and create future cash flows, giving opportunities to reinvest as interest rates change

BOND LADDERING

Vaishali R. Venkat

Imagine reaching retirement with a bond portfolio that works like a staircase. One bond matures this year, another next year, and another the year after, giving you access to money at different points instead of having to unlock the entire investment at once. This is the idea behind a bond ladder: spreading maturities across time so your money becomes available at different points of time, while giving you opportunities to reinvest as interest rates change.

Time diversification

The strategy is essentially a form of time diversification. Instead of putting a large sum into bonds that all mature together, the investor spreads the maturities over several years.

When one bond matures, its principal can be used for spending or moved into a new bond at the far end of the ladder. This creates a rolling cycle of maturities and reduces the need to make a single bet on where interest rates will be when the entire portfolio needs to be renewed.

Let's say, for instance, you have ₹7 lakh to allocate for bond investments. Rather than investing the entire amount into a single bond in one go, you could



When one bond matures, its principal can be used for spending or moved into a new bond at the far end of the ladder

time-diversify it among several bonds with staggered maturity periods, say with maturities of one, two, three, four, five years and so on. When the first bond matures, you get that money back. You can use it if required or reinvest it in a long-term bond. The interest you receive along the way is separate from this maturity amount.

A bond's coupon is the interest calculated on its face value, while its yield reflects the return based on the price at which you buy it. So, while the ladder spreads the return of your principal over time, the coupons can provide income during the holding period.

If interest rates have risen by then, you get an opportunity to lock into the higher rate, while your existing bonds continue to earn their contracted interest. If rates have fallen, the new bond may offer a lower return. The ladder does not remove interest-rate risk; it spreads it over time and gives you periodic access to your principal.

This way, bond laddering can improve cash flow during retirement. As



Companies, institutional investors too use maturity-staggering strategies to manage their fixed-income portfolios

bonds mature at different times, the principal becomes available periodically, helping you meet expenses without having to sell a bond in the secondary market during an emergency, when its market price may have fallen. Bond laddering is not a strategy meant only for retirees. It can be tailored to different financial goals and time horizons, whether the money is needed over a few years or earmarked for retirement.

Even companies and institutional investors use similar maturity-staggering strategies to manage their fixed-income portfolios.

For an individual investor, each maturity also provides a chance to reassess the situation: the money can be spent, reinvested or moved into another debt instrument depending on the financial goal and risk appetite at that point.

But staggering maturities doesn't make the bonds themselves safer.

The issuer can still default on interest or principal, and a problem with one bond can disrupt the expected cash flow from that rung.

This is why credit quality matters when building a ladder. Investors should examine the issuer, credit rating and terms of each bond rather than choosing securities simply because they offer a higher yield. A ladder should diversify maturity dates, not become a collection of risky bonds.

The same principle can extend beyond individual bonds. When different fixed-income instruments are arranged around staggered maturity dates, it is broadly referred to as fixed-income laddering.

Depending on their goals and suitability, investors may build such a ladder using instruments such as bank fixed deposits, government securities, Treasury bills, corporate bonds and other fixed-income products. The idea remains the same: spread maturities so that money becomes available at different points rather than having the entire investment mature at once. The choice can be tailored to the investor's goals, time horizon and risk appetite.

Bond laddering is a strategy for organising fixed-income investments, not a recommendation to buy bonds. Bonds carry risks.

Investors should therefore consider the issuer, credit quality, maturity, liquidity and financial needs before investing.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)

Elusive alpha?

THINKINVESTOR

A skilled portfolio manager can experience bad luck, which could be a reason for the difficulty in generating alpha consistently

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Nearly three-fourth of large-cap active funds underperformed a blended (LargeMidCap) benchmark over a 10-year period, according to the 2025 report by SPIVA (S&P Indices Versus Active). In this article, we discuss two reasons that could, perhaps, explain why active funds find it difficult to consistently beat their benchmark.

Alpha is the excess returns that a portfolio generates over an appropriate benchmark. Simply put, portfolio return minus the appropriate benchmark return is equal to a portfolio's alpha. This alpha is a function of skill and luck. Typically, two factors, knowledge and information, determine skill. Knowledge is typically acquired through a credentialing exam. Information refers to corporate news and macroeconomic developments that help portfolio managers take investment action.

The difference in skill levels among portfolio managers have narrowed over the years. This is because portfolio managers now have similar credentials (knowledge). Also, market participants can use only publicly disseminated information to take investment action. The upshot? The difference in returns between the worst-performing fund and the best-performing fund cannot be entirely explained by the difference in skill levels. That could mean luck plays an important role in alpha generation. The issue is that a skilled portfolio manager can experience bad luck. This could be one reason for the difficulty in consistently generating alpha. The second reason could be attributed to the market structure. Markets are inefficient in that assets are mispriced. Yet, markets are efficient in that such mispricing does not last long because too much money chases the same universe of stocks. With cheap computational power and the same level of information across market participants, the opportunity for a portfolio manager to consistently pick mispriced stocks well before their competitors do is small. The above argument is not to suggest that active funds can't generate alpha or that you should not invest in such funds. It is just that the role of luck coupled with efficiently inefficient market structure, perhaps, drive fund performance, leading to the difficulty in consistently generating alpha. What if a fund's underperformance (even if it were because of bad luck) coincides with the time horizon for your life goal? You may have a shortfall in your terminal wealth, the amount required to achieve a life goal. Failing to achieve a goal can cause grief. Remember, for the same level of alpha returns, negative alpha can give you more pain than positive alpha can give you happiness.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.35	7.40	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.10	7.10	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	8.00	6.00	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.00	8.00	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	8.00	6.00	7.50	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	8.25	7.25	7.25	8.25
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.80	7.25	7.25	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	8.10	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.50	6.25	6.50	6.50
Bandhan Bank	7.45	7.00	7.25	5.85
City Union Bank	7.25	6.65	6.50	6.55
CSB Bank	7.10	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.85	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.50	6.90	7.00	7.50
Federal Bank	6.70	6.25	6.50	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.25	6.50	7.25	6.75
IndusInd Bank	7.00	6.75	7.00	6.65

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Public Sector Banks				
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	7.05	6.55	6.80	6.85
IDBI Bank	6.50	6.20	6.35	6.25
Karnataka Bank	7.00	6.50	6.15	6.15
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.80	6.35	6.40	6.25
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70
SBI Bank India	7.65	7.10	7.65	7.00
South Indian Bank	6.80	6.25	6.20	5.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.25	6.80	6.70	6.70
YES Bank	7.25	6.65	7.00	6.75
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda	6.75	6.25	6.25	6.30
Bank of India	6.85	6.50	6.70	6.00
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.40	5.25	5.00
Canara Bank	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
Central Bank of India	6.75	6.10	6.00	6.00
Indian Bank	6.65	6.10	6.05	6.00
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10
Punjab National Bank	6.60	6.25	6.30	6.35
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.85	5.85	5.85	5.95
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05
Union Bank of India	6.55	6.20	6.10	6.00

Home Loan Interest Rates

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
Public Sector Banks			
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.00-9.00	7.00-9.00	7.00-9.00
Central Bank of India	7.00-9.15	7.00-9.15	7.00-9.15
Indian Bank	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55
Indian Overseas Bank	7.20	7.20	7.20
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.35-10.75	7.35-10.75	7.35-10.75
Punjab National Bank	7.30-9.30	7.25-9.20	7.25-9.20
State Bank of India	7.25-9.05	7.25-9.05	7.25-9.05
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.60	7.15-9.60	7.15-9.60
Private Sector Banks			
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00-9.10
Bandhan Bank	8.55-13.52	8.55-13.52	8.55-13.52
City Union Bank	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
CSB Bank	8.30	8.30	8.30
Federal Bank	8.35-10.00	7.35-10.00	7.35-9.00
HDFC Bank	7.75	7.75	7.75
HSBC Bank	7.45	7.45	7.45
ICI Bank	7.50	7.50	7.50

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
Karnataka Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
Aditya Birla Capital	7.75	7.75	7.75
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.25	7.25	7.25
GIC Housing Finance	8.20	8.20	8.20
Godrej Housing Finance	7.65	7.65	7.65
IOCI Home Finance	7.50	7.50	7.50
LIC Housing Finance	7.15	7.15	7.15
PNB Housing Finance	7.75-14.50	7.80-14.50	7.90-9.95
Sammam Capital	8.75	8.75	8.75
SMFG India Home Finance	9.25	9.25	9.25
Tata Capital	8.00	8.00	8.00

*Extra interest rate concession of 0.85% to borrowers opting for insurance policy. #Onwards Rates as on August 19 Source:Policybazaar.com

GAZA CITY

Israeli strikes kill three, including four-year-old child, in Gaza strip

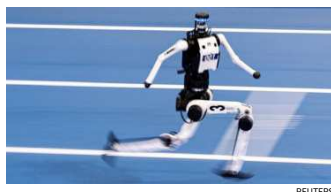


REUTERS

Israeli strikes in the Gaza Strip killed three people on Sunday, including a child, rescuers said, while the Israeli military said it had targeted a "terrorist" in one strike. An airstrike killed two people in the town of Al-Zawayda, including a four-year-old child. Another Israeli strike killed one person in the Nuseirat refugee camp. AFP

BEIJING

Chinese humanoid robot breaks Usain Bolt's 100m world record



REUTERS

Chinese robots on Saturday broke records set by humans at the World Humanoid Robot Games in Beijing. A robot ran 100 metres in 9.39 seconds surpassing Jamaican great Usain Bolt's 9.58 seconds. While another robot reached 2.88 metres in standing high jump, beating the record of 2.45 metres set by Cuba's Javier Sotomayor. AP

KUWAIT CITY

Kuwait approves decree stripping naturalised citizens of their vote



AFP

Kuwait's Emir has approved a decree banning naturalised citizens from voting, two years after dissolving Parliament and embarking on a mass national stripping campaign. Previously, naturalised Kuwaitis were able to vote 30 years after acquiring the nationality, but were banned from running for office or being appointed. AFP

JAKARTA

Indonesian police arrest 72 people suspected of starting forest fires



REUTERS

Indonesian authorities arrested 72 people suspected of starting some of the forest fires as huge blazes in central and west Indonesia triggered choking haze. Indonesia has been battling fires driven by an erratic El Niño pattern and a prolonged dry season. The arrests were made in connection with 89 forest and land fire cases. AP

New sanctions a sign of 'desperation', U.S. measures will fail, says Araghchi

U.S. expected to announce 'toughest sanctions in history' on Iran today; Iranian Minister says Washington must speak to Tehran respectfully for 'a solution based on justice and honour'; shipping remains at a virtual standstill in Strait of Hormuz

Reuters
DUBAI

Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi dismissed the threat of new U.S. sanctions as a sign of desperation on Sunday, and said the expected new measures would fail to defeat Tehran.

U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, who is due to hold a press conference on Monday, has threatened to impose "the toughest sanctions in history" on Iran.

Iran's economy is already under huge pressure from international sanctions, its infrastructure has been hit repeatedly and



Passing facade: A woman walks by a mural depicting Iran's late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Tehran. REUTERS

thousands of people have been killed in air strikes on the Islamic Republic since the U.S. and Israel launched attacks on February 28.

But Tehran remains defiant after nearly six months of war and has brought shipping to a virtual standstill in the Strait of Hormuz.

Describing what he said were "repetitive scenarios", Mr. Araghchi said in a video posted on Telegram: "The fact that they (U.S. leaders) have moved on from military operations... to bring up the same old plans shows that they are desperate."

He said Washington must speak to Iran respectfully to find "a solution based on justice and honour."

"We have never been afraid. All of their actions—whether blockades or other military moves they have made—have failed, and this new issue of theirs will fail as well," he said.

U.S. President Donald

Trump has warned of economic consequences against any country that provides "any type of lifeline to Iran".

Meanwhile, Iranian Parliament Speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf said on Saturday that Tehran had received "numerous messages" from neighbouring countries about establishing new regional security arrangements and economic cooperation.

Munir to visit Tehran Iran said Pakistan's Army chief, Asim Munir, would visit Tehran on Monday as part of efforts to restore peace and security in the region.

Holding election during war will 'split' Ukraine: Zelenskyy

Agence France-Presse
KYIV

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said in remarks made public on Sunday that it would be too dangerous for Ukraine to hold an election while it fights Russia's invasion, after a call by his former Defence Minister to organise a vote.

Ukraine has suspended elections under martial law, a measure still widely supported by the population as the country focuses on fighting off the Russian invasion launched in 2022.

"I believe that in a war like this, elections as such are a huge risk. Elections right now are a tsunami for the country that will split Ukraine," Mr. Zelenskyy said.

"If we want to destroy



Volodymyr Zelenskyy

the country, then we can move in the direction of elections during these times of war," added the 48-year-old, who became President in 2019.

He made the comments on Saturday in a briefing with journalists, in a month amid several political crises. The latest upheaval saw thousands of people take to the streets after Mr. Zelenskyy fired

popular Defence Minister Mykhailo Fedorov.

Mr. Fedorov this week made a surprise call to find a way to organise elections – but without offering a road map, and prompting even some of his supporters to distance themselves from him.

Experts have cited a flurry of obstacles to elections, including how soldiers, millions of Ukrainian refugees and people from occupied territories would vote, as well as disinformation threats from Russia.

The election call also came as Ukraine struggles to fend off daily Russian strikes on Kyiv and other cities. Only 15% of Ukrainians believe elections should be held before the end of hostilities, according to a poll by the Kyiv Institute of Sociology.

Escalating tariff trade war 'devastating' for Canada: U.S. official

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

U.S. Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy said on Sunday that Canada would come out worse from Donald Trump in a trade war.

Negotiations between Washington and Ottawa broke down late on Friday, putting into effect new 50% U.S. tariffs impacting about \$20 billion worth of Canadian goods.

"We're great trading partners, right? But Canada gets the benefit of trad-

ing with the U.S. way more than the U.S. gets the benefit of trading with Canada," Mr. Duffy said.

He predicted that Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney would return to negotiations "very very quickly, because it's going to be devastating for his country."

Mr. Carney was defiant on Saturday, announcing retaliatory tariffs on the U.S. Mr. Trump hit back at Canada on Sunday, saying, "Canada wants the benefits of being a State, without being one!!!"

On battle anniversary, Taiwan leader vows 'never to yield an inch' to China

Reuters
TAIWAN

Peace can only be secured through strength and not even an inch of territory can be sacrificed, Taiwan President Lai Ching-te said on Sunday, visiting a sensitive frontline island to mark a key battle with Chinese forces almost seven decades ago.

Taiwan has controlled the Kinmen and Matsu islands since the Republic of China government fled to Taipei in 1949 after losing a civil war with Mao Zedong's communists.

No peace treaty or ar-



Honouring the fallen: Soldiers pay tribute during the anniversary of the 1958 Taiwan Strait Crisis in Kinmen, Taiwan, on Sunday. AP

mistice has ever been signed.

In heavy rain, Mr. Lai laid a wreath and bowed at a memorial park for the

68th anniversary of the 1958 clash with Chinese forces, known as the start of the second Taiwan Strait crisis. Addressing veterans la-

ter, Mr. Lai expressed gratitude to those who "stood united and fought a bloody battle to repel Communist totalitarian aggression".

"Our resolve to unite in defending national sovereignty and safeguarding peace across the Taiwan Strait must never waver," Mr. Lai said.

The 1958 battle proves "that peace is secured through strength," he said, adding it was necessary to maintain "the spirit of never yielding an inch" of Taiwan, Kinmen and other group of islands, while continuously boosting military spending.

DR Congo and M23 fighters agree to road map for peace talks

Agence France-Presse
GENEVA

The Democratic Republic of Congo and the Rwanda-backed M23 armed group have agreed on a road map for peace talks, according to a joint statement published on Sunday by Switzerland.

The eastern DRC has been riven by decades of conflict, with multiple armed groups fighting over its mineral-rich territory, including the M23.

The two sides signed a U.S.-brokered peace agree-

ment late last year in the Qatari capital Doha, but fighting has continued. Following a new round of talks held in Switzerland last week, the two sides said they had staked out a path forward.

"The Parties developed a road map setting out sequenced steps and timelines for negotiations under the Doha Framework Agreement, the statement said. "They reaffirmed their commitment to pursue negotiations towards comprehensive peace," it added.

Sport

Deshpande and Kotian put West in control

DULEEP TROPHY

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU

The 2026-27 Indian domestic cricket season opened to some lively action as first-rate four-wicket hauls from Tushar Deshpande (four for 57) and Tanush Kotian (four for 72) helped West Zone dismiss North Zone for 251 on day one of the Duleep Trophy at the BCCI Centre of Excellence here on Sunday.

After opting to bat, North lost openers Yash Dhull and Qamran Iqbal with only 45 on the board but Ayush Badoni (51, 57b, 6x4, 2x6) and Ayush Doseja (42, 110b, 4x4) combined for 72 confident runs. Badoni was indeed reprieved twice, but the Delhi batter impressed with his flicks,



Striking big: West's Kotian had an action-packed day while East batters Shahbaz and Gharami slammed centuries. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

pulls and controlled hooks. However, a middle-order collapse saw North score from 117 for two to 161 for seven. Deshpande, operating with pace and verve, had Badoni caught

behind before bowling Abdul Samad through the gate. Kotian sent back Doseja and captain Kanhaiya Wadhawan, with the former caught at silly-point and the latter trapped leg-be-

fore on the back-foot. The Mumbai off-spinner also took two outstanding high catches, one running in from fine-leg to end Abid Mushtaq's stay and the other off his own bowling to excise Arshdeep Singh.

Aggressive knock

If not for Anshul Kamboj's 60 (52b, 5x4, 5x6), North would have been down in dumps, with the 25-year-old bringing up his entertaining half-century with a fierce six over mid-wicket off Kotian.

Teenaged sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, though, could not have similar impact as he was dismissed for a paltry eight (6b, 2x4) while opening for East Zone versus North East Zone on the adjacent ground. The 15-year-old hit his third ball to the mid-wicket fence and the

fourth to the point boundary before pacer Bishwajit Konhoujan had the youngster caught at gully off the sixth.

Century-makers

However, Sudip Gharami (146, 185b, 25x4, 1x6) and Shahbaz Ahmed (100 batting, 137b, 9x4, 2x6) played with poise to carry East to a healthy 355 for six. Kumar Kushagra lent a steady hand too (55, 65b, 9x4), helping his side stabilise from 25 to two after being asked to bat.

The scores: North Zone 251 in 66.5 overs (Ayush Doseja 42, Ayush Badoni 51, Anshul Kamboj 60, Tanush Kotian 47/2, Tushar Deshpande 4/57) vs. West Zone 31/2 in 10 overs; **Toss:** North East. East Zone 355/6 in 80 overs (Kumar Kushagra 55, Sudip Gharami 146, Shahbaz Ahmed 100 batting) vs. North East Zone; **Toss:** North East.

Starc reality for Bangladesh

Agence France-Presse
MACKAY

An irrepressible Mitchell Starc bagged four in the second innings to finish with a 10-wicket match haul as Australia earned an innings and 51-run victory over Bangladesh inside two days of the second Test here. With the win on Sunday, the host levelled the two-game series.

After the high in Darwin, the visiting side was brought crashing back to earth by some scintillating fast bowling, led by Player-of-the-Match Starc (40-5). Australia was bowled out for 210 in Sunday's morning session, securing a first-innings lead of 146 on the back of Cameron Green's 67. Left-arm pacer Shoriful Islam claimed seven for 48, the best figures by a Bangladesh bowler in an away Test. The away



Breathing fire: Starc, centre, posed probing questions that Bangladesh could not answer. GETTY IMAGES

team, which was bundled out for just 64 in the first essay, crumbled to be 95 all out in the second, with Starc being the chief tormenter again. "A lot of things went right these couple of days and a lot of things went wrong last week," said Australia captain Pat Cummins.

"We needed to bounce

back, and it was a great few days from the lads. I thought that everyone was sharp. It was a great start and we did not really let up after that."

The scores: Bangladesh 64 & 95 in 38.3 overs (Starc 4/39, Cummins 3/10, Lyon 3/25) lost to Australia 210 in 52.3 overs (Smith 42, Green 67, Shoriful 7/48); **PoM & PoS:** Starc.

HEAT OF THE MOMENT

Kotak and van Niekerk attribute Jaiswal-Asitha skirmish to impulse

The skirmish between Yashasvi Jaiswal and Asitha Fernando was judged as an impulsive reaction by both team managements. "There was an overflow of emotions and it's up to the match referee," said Ryan van Niekerk. "Things happen in the heat of the moment, but Jaiswal shouldn't have got close," said Sitanshu Kotak.

UNFORTUNATE

'Kuldeep had a viral infection and wasn't available for selection'

Saransh Jain made his Test debut on Sunday. While he stepped in as a replacement for Kuldeep Yadav, batting coach Sitanshu Kotak insisted that the latter's viral bout forced the change. "Kuldeep had a viral infection and he was not available for selection. This choice was not about Sri Lanka having many left-handed batters."

COACH'S BACKING

'Asitha showed he could continue to threaten and take wickets'

Asitha Fernando's three for 46 yield against India in the second Test enthused Sri Lanka's bowling coach Ryan van Niekerk. "Asitha showed through his spells that he could continue to threaten and take wickets. Getting him to bowl for long periods of time is the key to his success. The more he bowls, the better he gets," he said.

CALLING IT QUILTS

India leg-spinner Karn announces retirement from all formats

India leg-spinner Karn Sharma announced his retirement from all formats of competitive cricket on Sunday. The 38-year-old made the announcement following Kanpur Superstars' loss to Meerut Mavericks in the UP T20 League, confirming that the reverse fixture against Meerut on Tuesday will be his final game.

Padikkal makes scoring centuries a habit as India touches 300

The southpaw smashes his second ton of the series as the Indian batters thrive on the opening day; Jaiswal, Gill, and Jadeja chip in with valuable contributions; Pant retires hurt after getting hit on the wrist; Asitha the pick of the Lankan bowlers

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
COLOMBO

In a city where Sir Don Bradman batted in 1948, Devdutt Padikkal carved his own space of batting heaven.

Colombo back then was the transit port for ship-bound Ashes cricketers and while Bradman played at the P. Sara Oval, Padikkal found his favourite turf in the Sinhalese Sports Club Ground.

Padikkal's second hundred of the series was the spine that held the Indian first innings together and while Bradman played at the P. Sara Oval, Padikkal found his favourite turf in the Sinhalese Sports Club Ground.

Padikkal's second hundred of the series was the spine that held the Indian first innings together and while Bradman played at the P. Sara Oval, Padikkal found his favourite turf in the Sinhalese Sports Club Ground.

It was a partnership that was both sedate and stylish. Gill pulled and drove



Solid and smooth: There was a serenity to the manner in which Padikkal batted on Sunday. PTI

left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya while Padikkal tucked into speedster Lahiru Kumara. The right-left combine of Gill and Padikkal unsettled the Sri Lankans. Padikkal also relished the width at times offered by Prabath and off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha, and the rasping cut that stretched from the first session to the third and final one. He shared a 120-run first-wicket alliance with skipper Gill, and kept the scoreboard ticking.

It was a partnership that was both sedate and stylish. Gill pulled and drove

Once the individual fifties were registered, Gill in a moment of poor judgement tried to guide one past the slips and fell to seamer Asitha Fernando. India was on 187 for three at tea, with Padikkal being

the adhesive.

In the last session, Rishabh Pant copped a blow on his wrist and left, and Ravindra Jadeja allied with Padikkal. There was a serenity to the manner in which Padikkal batted, nudging singles and striking the odd four.

Soon the century was acquired, the celebration, though, was muted, when compared to the more expansive gestures at Galle last week. And when Padikkal (117) lost his timber to Nuwantha, most rival felders ran to pat his back. Later, as the shadows lengthened, Jadeja shouldered

arms to the new ball and Asitha clipped the stumps.

Earlier, in an easy Sunday morning with a languid air, blazing sun and less traffic, Gill won the toss and opted to bat.

Yashasvi Jaiswal dug out the match's first ball, a yorker from Asitha, and then drove with ease. While Jaiswal etched streaky fours, Rahul covered Asitha.

Captain Dhananjaya de Silva employed Prabath and the spinner was driven by Jaiswal and Rahul hoisted a six.

However, Rahul played an uncharacteristic slash

SCOREBOARD

INDIA - 1ST INNINGS

Yashasvi Jaiswal b Asitha 45 (53b, 9x4), K.L. Rahul b Dickwella b Kumara 18 (33b, 2x4, 1x6), Devdutt Padikkal b Nuwantha 117 (193b, 12x4), Shubman Gill c Dickwella b Asitha 50 (108b, 6x4), Rishabh Pant ret'd. hurt 3 (15b), Ravindra Jadeja b Asitha 43 (83b, 4x4), Dhruv Jurel (batting) 7 (21b, 1x4), Saransh Jain (batting) 4 (5b, 1x4); Extras (b-4, lb-3, nb-1, w-5); 13; Total (for five wks. in 85 overs): 300.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-37 (Rahul, 10.4 overs), 2-66 (Jaiswal, 16.6), 3-186 (Gill, 51.5), 4-281 (Padikkal, 76.2), 5-296 (Jadeja, 84.1).

SRI LANKA BOWLING

Asitha 16-5-46-3, Kumara 13-4-38-1, Prabath 21-4-90-0, Nuwantha 22-0-83-1, Dinusha 1-0-2-0, Dhananjaya 2-0-8-0, Mishra 4-0-16-0.

Toss: India.

against Kumara, and edged.

Padikkal walked in and had two lucky breaks as sharp catches ended Sonal Dinusha and Dhananjaya. Just as he settled in, Jaiswal remained his merry-self. The opener pinched three fours from an Asitha over before getting castled by the seamer.

Words were exchanged. Jaiswal and Asitha got too close for comfort before sanity prevailed and the batter left. Next-man Gill and Padikkal anchored India to 88 for two at lunch, a score that found incremental growth.

Former captains appeal to Pakistan PM for humane treatment to Imran Khan

Sports Bureau

Former Australian captain Greg Chappell, with the support of 20 other former international skippers, appealed on Sunday to the Pakistan Prime Minister Muhammad Shehbaz Sharif to provide 'humane treatment and proper medical care' for former Pakistan cricket captain and Prime Minister Imran Khan.

The letter is reproduced below:

His Excellency Mian Muhammad Shehbaz Sharif, Prime Minister of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan, Prime Minister's Office Islamabad, Pakistan

Appeal by 21 Former International Cricket Captains on the Medical Treatment and Welfare of Imran Khan

Dear Prime Minister, Six months ago, fourteen former international cricket captains wrote to you and the Pakistani government appealing for humane treatment and proper medical care for Imran Khan. We wrote then not as politicians, but as former colleagues and rivals who share a bond forged on the cricket field — one that transcends the borders and disputes that too often divide countries.

We write again now — joined by seven further former captains — because of what has reportedly just occurred. Pakistan's Su-



Imran. FILE PHOTO

preme Court ordered that Imran Khan be transferred to hospital for examination by a medical board that was to include his own personal physicians and his sister, Dr. Uzma Khan. The Court also reinstated weekly family visits. These were very welcome steps.

Concerningly, Mr. Khan's hospital stay lasted only a few hours. He was examined by a state-appointed team rather than the board the Court had directed, declared "medically fit," and returned to Adiala Jail before that board could complete its work. His family and legal team say this falls short of what the Court ordered.

We do not presume to adjudicate Pakistan's domestic legal processes. That is not our place, and it was not the spirit in which we wrote in February. But we do ask, again, respectfully:

1. That the medical board directed by the Supreme Court — including

Mr. Khan's own doctors — be permitted to complete a full and independent assessment of his health, particularly the reported loss of vision in his right eye.

2. That the weekly family visits reinstated by the Court be honoured without interruption or administrative delay.

3. That whatever the outcome of that medical assessment, the treatment recommended by it be provided without delay. Imran Khan is 73 years old and has now spent more than three years in custody. Whatever the legal and political arguments surrounding his case, the basic decency of ensuring a court-ordered medical process is actually completed is not, in our view, a controversial request.

It is one we believe every nation that plays this game would recognise as fair. We hope this matter can be resolved expeditiously and with the dignity Mr. Imran Khan deserves.

Yours in cricket, Michael Atherton, Alex Blackwell, Allan Border, Michael Brearley, Greg Chappell, Ian Chappell, Belinda Clark, Alastair Cook, Sunil Gavaskar, Lee Cernon, Adam Gilchrist, David Gower, Kim Hughes, Nasser Hussain, Clive Lloyd, Kapil Dev, Nikhanj, Arjuna Ranatunga, Andrew Strauss, Dilip Vengsarkar, Stephen Waugh, John Wright.

It is time for our all-rounders and lower-order to score: Kotak

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
COLOMBO

In his prime, Sitanshu Kotak was a domestic giant. The Saurashtra batter amassed runs and was a steady presence on Indian pitches.

Now as India's batting coach, Kotak is happy with the way Devdutt Padikkal has shaped up in the current Test series between India and Sri Lanka.

"His intent, temperament and the pace with which he batted looked good. It is a good sign for us. He has been waiting for his turn and I am happy with the way he has prepared for this opportunity," Kotak told the media on Sunday.

Asked if Padikkal had sealed the No. 3 slot, Kotak remained diplomatic. "He has done well at No. 3; previously Sanjiv Sathian had a steady presence on Indian pitches. Now as India's batting coach, Kotak is happy with the way Devdutt Padikkal has shaped up in the current Test series between India and Sri Lanka.



Minor score: Kotak confirmed that the injured Pant was 'fine and should play'. PTI

though, would have preferred fewer dismissals: "I would have liked 300 for three or four. Some of the dismissals were soft, set batters losing wickets, but it happens in cricket. Now it is time for our all-rounders and lower-order to score."

As for the injured Rishabh Pant, Kotak added: "He seems fine and should play."

Kotak felt that the pitch assisted both pace and spin: "Fast bowlers had a

little movement and that was good. We felt that the spin was also good. On day three and four, the pitch will assist spinners a little more."

The second day's first one-hour would be the key, reckoned Kotak: "You don't want to lose wickets in the last 15 minutes before the break. Now, the new-ball is there and the first hour would be crucial. If we bat well maybe we could get to the par-score of 400-plus."

India eliminated after a goalless draw with Australia

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad
AMSTERVEEN

The light faded over the Wagener Stadion and so did India's hopes of making the hockey World Cup semifinals. In a must-win game, an error-strewn Indian women's team paid the price with a goalless draw against Australia.

While the Salima Teteled side made an inspired run into the second round, this phase exposed its chinks as it finished third in Group A. Australia pipped India on the basis of more goals scored to reach the last-four stage.

For India, chance creation in field play was found lacking as its goalless run extended to three games. Even adding an extra outfielder in place of the goalkeeper in the final minutes wasn't enough to find the elusive goal.

India struggled to play through Australia's close marking set-up and the theme continued throughout the game, resulting in



Agony: India was close to booking a semifinal berth before bowing out. FILE PHOTO

turnovers in key areas of the pitch. Luck seemingly was with India, though, after Australia had two goals ruled out for dangerous play. Inside 90 seconds, Grace Stewart swept home from close range after a deflection off Sushila Chanu's thigh, but the TV umpire deemed it high enough to overrule it.

Australia found a lot of joy down the right side with Amy Lawton managing two reverse-hits, which needed saves from Savita Punia and Bichu Devi in the opening two quarters. A more ruthless Australia

could have punished India heavily from the turnovers.

In the third quarter, Stephanie Kershaw was in shock when another goal was ruled out from an Australian PC. India improved in the final quarter by beating Australia's press to reach the final 25, but lacked the composure and creativity to get into goal-scoring areas.

India defended a flurry of PCs in the final stretch to keep itself alive but couldn't find the answers in front of goal. India will now figure in the fifth-sixth classification match.



Last-gasp win: Guardiola snatches victory for City late into the second half. REUTERS

Man City rallies past Bournemouth

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
MANCHESTER

Manchester City made a winning start to life without Pep Guardiola as late goals from Marc Guehi and Josko Gvardiol snatched a dramatic 2-1 victory against Bournemouth on Sunday in Enzo Maresca's first Premier League game as the Spaniard's replacement.

The results: Premier League: Brighton 4, Lendelof 8-og, De Cuyper 18, Hinchelwood 30, 31; De Aston Villa 0; Manchester City 2 (Guehi 84, Gvardiol 90+1) bt Bournemouth 1 (Tavernier 26);

Newcastle 2 (Elanga 5, Willock 57) drew with Liverpool 2 (Gakpo 55, Szoboszlai 90+9 pen). **LaLiga:** Atletico Madrid 2 (Pubill 59, Simeone 85) drew with Villarreal 2 (Moreno 66 pen, Mikautadze 78 pen). **On Saturday: Premier League:** Brentford 3 (Lewis-Potter 12, Janelt 33, Kayode 49) bt Tottenham 0. **Serie A:** Inter Milan 4 (Calhanoglu 6, Zielinski 48, Esposito 55, Bisseck 63) bt Monza 1 (Varela 29); Udinese 1 (Kamara 29) drew with Como 1 (Douvikas 54); Genoa 0 lost to Napoli 2 (De Bruyne 82, Vergara 87). **LaLiga:** Athletic Bilbao 1 (Paredes 70) lost to Sevilla 3 (Oso 15, Ejike 50, Ruyter 57); Valencia 0 drew with Celta Vigo 0; Espanyol 1 (Calatrava 30) lost to Real Madrid 2 (Bellenghnam 9, Espi 90).

Sport

Dominant Lanier and Se-young power their way to the top

The 21-year-old becomes the first French men's singles champion, compatriots Gicquel and Delrue make it a double delight by winning the mixed doubles title; Keng and Chang bag the men's doubles crown, China's only gold in the tournament

BADMINTON WORLDS

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

Alex Lanier walked into history books and Alex Se-young asserted her supremacy after being crowned World champions in style at the 2026 World badminton championships here on Sunday.

Lanier, at 21, became the first French men's singles champion with a clinical, one-sided 21-11, 21-11 dismantling of Japan's Kodai Naraoka in the final to make it a double delight for the French.

The mixed doubles pair of Thom Gicquel and Delphine Delrue became the first-ever French champions in the morning, defeating the top-ranked Chinese pair of Feng Yan Zhe and Huang Dong Ping 22-20, 19-21, 21-15.

Top-ranked Se-young, meanwhile, extended her winning streak against World No. 2 and defending



Soaring high: Lanier's clinical performance proved too much for Naraoka. SHIV KUMAR PUSHKAR

champion Akane Yamaguchi to six matches in their 35th encounter with a 21-17, 21-14 victory to regain

the title. The 10th-ranked Lanier was all over Naraoka for a large part of the final, nev-

er letting the Japanese settle. The two were circumspect early on, probing, lifting and dropping tentatively rather than going all-out on the attack.

Shifting gears

Leading 11-9 in the opening game, Lanier shifted gears, becoming more aggressive and forcing Naraoka into errors to clinch the game 21-11.

The second stanza witnessed more of the same as Naraoka tried everything but was unable to find any gaps in Lanier's defence or repel his smashes. From 14-11, Lanier cleared through the next seven points to seal the deal.

The women's final was on expected lines and saw high intensity, high speed action. The opening game was close with the lead exchanging hands regularly. Se-young was ahead 15-12 but Yamaguchi won four straight points to move to 16-15. However, the Korean went on to win 21-17.

The second game followed a similar pattern. Ya-

maguchi went ahead early before Se-young hit a couple of winners to go up 11-7. A combination of unforced errors and missed chances from the Japanese saw the top-ranked player jump to a 17-13 lead before wrapping up the win.

Second Korean duo

In women's doubles, Baek Ha Na and Lee So Hee beat top seeds Sheng Shu Liu and Ning Tan 21-15, 21-15 to become only the second Korean champions in the event after a gap of 31 years, the last being Gill Young-ah and Jiang Ye-ock in 1995.

The results (finals):

Men: Alex Lanier (Fra) bt Kodai Naraoka (Jpn) 21-11, 21-11. **Doubles:** Liang Wei Keng & Wang Chang (Chn) bt Aaron Chia & Soh Wooi Yik (Mas) 21-17, 21-16. **Women:** An Se-young (Kor) bt Akane Yamaguchi (Jpn) 21-14, 21-14. **Doubles:** Baek Ha Na & Lee So Hee (Kor) bt Sheng Shu Liu & Ning Tan (Chn) 21-15, 21-15.

Mixed doubles: Thom Gicquel & Delphine Delrue (Fra) bt Feng Yan Zhe & Huang Dong Ping (Chn) 22-20, 19-21, 21-15.

SNAPSHOTS

Norris wins Dutch Cup

ZANDVOORT: Lando Norris gave McLaren a third successive Dutch Cup victory on Sunday in a race that had to be re-started after crash hero Max Verstappen smashed on the opening lap.

The results: 1. Lando Norris (McLaren) 2h:4m:44.859s (McLaren); 2. Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes) +11.536s; 3. George Russell (Mercedes) 15:50.6; 4. Lewis Hamilton (Ferrari) 16:75; 5. Charles Leclerc (Ferrari) 17:25; 6. Oscar Piastri (McLaren) 32:32; 7. Liam Lawson (Red Bull) 1:19:51; +1 lap: 8. Nico Hulkenberg (Audi); 9. Fernando Alonso (Aston Martin); 10. Pierre Gasly (Alpine); 11. Yuki Tsunoda (Racing Bulls); 12. Arvid Lindblad (Racing Bulls); 13. Gabriel Bortoleto (Alpine) +2 laps; 14. Franco Colapinto (Alpine); 15. Sergio Perez (Cadillac); 16. Carlos Sainz (Williams). **DNF:** 17. Alex Albon (Williams); 18. Valtteri Bottas (Cadillac); 19. Esteban Ocon (Haas); 20. Lance Stroll (Aston Martin); 21. Oliver Bearman (Haas); 22. Max Verstappen (Red Bull).

Standings Drivers: 1. Antonelli 242; 2. Russell 182; 3. Hamilton 183; 4. Norris 159; 5. Leclerc 155; 6. Hamilton 152; 7. Ferrar 338; 8. McLaren 263; 4.

Treesa-Gayatri combine cherishes medal moment

Devvanshi Bihani
NEW DELHI

The Indian flag rose at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium on Sunday as Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand received their World championships bronze, bringing a ceremonial close to a week in which they gave India's first women's doubles medal since 2011.

"We'll cherish this medal forever," Gayatri said. The unseeded pair lost to China's Liu-Tan in the semifinal after beating reigning Olympic champion Jia Yifan and her partner Zhang Shuxian in the quarterfinals.

"We were just so happy after the quarterfinal match. And even in the semi-finals match, we gave 100%. It just wasn't our day," Gayatri said.

For coach Pullela Gopi Chand, the medal reflected six weeks of work paying off. "It's good to see when the practice you do actually gives you dividends on court," he said on Saturday.

After an injury-hit period that raised questions about their ability to perform at this level, Treesa said their results provided



Surreal: Gayatri and Treesa gave India its first women's doubles medal since 2011. SHIV KUMAR PUSHKAR



We wanted to do something big. We did that.

TREESA

the answer: "We both were here to do something big. What we can show is our result. I think we did that."

They now turn towards the Asian Games, with the Chinese pair still on their minds.

"It's obviously a matter of time. Just believe in yourself that you can beat them," Treesa said.

Gopi Chand was best placed to understand the significance of this week,

watching his daughter win a World Championships medal after receiving the Arjuna Award earlier in the week.

"I think whenever my players have played, I've always had the same feeling," he said. "And there's nothing extra for Gayatri, nothing more than I've had for any of my other players."

Proud coach

There was pride, nevertheless. "I'm very proud of her performance and her results. And the way she's conducted herself," he said. "With God's grace, in a family, there are two Arjuna awardees. It's rare," he added.

Vive La France at the World championships

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

The French are known for a lot of things but badminton isn't one of them. Till Sunday, when the country that has never been considered among the top nations even in Europe created history at the 2026 World championships, in more ways than one.

Less than two hours after Thom Gicquel and Delphine Delrue stroked and smashed their way into history books as the first-ever French World champions in the sport, Alex Lanier won the men's title to join the celebrations. The wins, however, were anything but fluke given the recent rise of French players on the BWF circuit.

"It's amazing, 10 years ago no French player could have even thought about so that makes us feel happy and proud," Gicquel admitted. That was also when he and Delrue first came together as a pair and since then, have seen the deve-



Making history: Delrue and Gicquel sliced through the mixed doubles field. SHIV KUMAR PUSHKAR

lopment of the sport back home from close quarters.

Asked about the reasons for the growth of French badminton, Delrue credited the mentality and influx of resources from the national federation.

Winning mentality

"It's the mentality that we can win. Sports is more professional in France than before, there are more staff and players and we can focus on performance. We had a good group when we were

young and won a lot in Europe. The federation put more money into infrastructure and facilities for us to be better," she explained.

The fact that Lanier was on the verge of creating history on his own only pushed them harder.

"We have a healthy competition between all of us, we try to bring France to the top of every tournament and see that every week someone is achieving something. To be the first was a pressure we en-

joyed," Delrue agreed and Gicquel chimed in, "We were also a bit stressed that Alex can win in one hour so we wanted to win before him!"

Lanier, meanwhile, was a lot more emotional about France's triumphs on the day.

"Today was a day for France and French badminton, I didn't feel like I was for me today, unlike yesterday or the day before when it was for me. After the mixed doubles win I felt I needed to give them a double smile and make this a historic moment," he said after his victory.

Delrue admitted the results have only just started. "We are really proud of helping take France to the top among European countries and now at the World level, there's Alex and Popov brothers and others. Asked what kind of welcome they expected back home, Gicquel laughed. "Nobody knows us, nobody would be waiting for us," he quipped.

One N Only oblige

HYDERABAD: Trainer D. Netto's ridden One N Only, ridden by Akash Kumar, won the Governor's Trophy, the feature event of Sunday's races here. The winner is owned by M/s. Rama Seshu Eyyuri, Shankar Srinivas, Ashok Ramesh & Donald Anthony Netto. Akash Kumar stole the limelight by riding to four victories while Trainer D. Netto saddled three winners.

HIDDEN BLOOM PLATE (DIV. I, 4,000m): CORINTHIAN (Ashay Kumar) 1, Ragnakar (Shivam) 2, Deccan (Mukesh K) 3 and India's Destiny (Gaurav) 4, 1/2, 3 and 3/4. Im. 25:78.5 (5w), 10 and 20 (p). SHP: 99; THP: 39, FP: 137; Q: H/S, Tanaka: 487. Favourite: Corinthian. Owner: Mr. C. Aryama Sundaram. Trainer: D. Netto.

2. SILVER PHANTOM PLATE (4,000m): YOU TUBER (Ashay Kumar) 1, Ashwa Jaffna (Gaurav) 2, French Lieutenant (P. Ajesh K) 3 and Belgium Waffle (Mohit) 4, 2/12, 2 and 1/2. Im. 26:28.5 (2w), 18, 162 and 10 (p). SHP: 59; THP: 67; FP: 162; Q: 148, Tanaka: 510. Favourite: French Lieutenant. Owners: Mr. M. Rajgurunath rep. Gora Racing Syndicate LLP & Mr. P. Amarendra Reddy. Trainer: S. Sathesh.

3. HUSSAIN SAGAR TROPHY (6,000m): PRIDE ASIDE (Imran Chisty) 1, Hoping Hope (Mohit) 2, Quintessential (P. Ajesh K) 3 and Bartolino (A.A. Vikran) 4, 3, 1/4 and 9/14. Im. 41:63. 329 (w), 10, 17 and 10 (p). SHP: 28; THP: 41; FP: 168; Q: 102, Tanaka: 369. Favourite: Quintessential. Owner: Kunwar Divyesh Singh Shekhawat. Trainer: R. Ravinder Singh.

4. HIDDEN BLOOM PLATE (DIV. II, 4,000m): KNIGHT CRUSADER (B.R. Kumar) 1, Annihilator (Mukesh K) 2, Victoria Dossani (Ashay K) 3 and Quintessential (P. Ajesh K) 4, 2/12 and 2, Im. 27:05. 741 (w), 11, 15 and 13 (p). SHP: 61; THP: 35; FP: 224; Q: Tanaka: 723. Favourite: Victoria Dossani. Owner: Mr. C. Aryama

Sundaram. Trainer: R.H. Sequiera. **5. RED RUM PLATE (4,000m):** ZORRA (P. Ajesh Kumar) 1, Ane-mara (Ashay K) 2, Khamangani (B. Nihal) 3 and Trend Setter (D. Gistay) 4. Short Head, 1/2 and Nose. Im. 8:76. 764 (w), 17, 16 and 31 (p). SHP: 37; THP: 97; FP: 253; Q: 70, Tanaka: 5, 084. Favourite: Anemara. Owners: Col. S.B. Nair & Mr. Aditya P. Thacker. Trainer: L.V.R. Deshmukh.

6. GOVERNOR'S TROPHY (6,000m): ONE N ONLY (Ashay Kumar) 1, Timeless Vision (T.S. Jodha) 2, Dhallo (P. Sai K) 3 and D. Minchu (B.R. Kumar) 4. Not run. Im. 11:42. 1/4, 16 and 10 (p). SHP: 44; THP: 31; FP: 75; Q: 40, Tanaka: 105. Favourite: One N Only. Owners: M/s. Rama Seshu Eyyuri, Shankar Srinivas, Ashok Ramesh & Donald Anthony Netto. Trainer: D. Netto.

7. FAIR HAVEN PLATE (2,000m): HANUMANMAHARAJA (Neeraj Rawal) 1, Screenshot (Arjun) 2, Red Hot Punch (P. Ajesh K) 3 and Aditya (Rafique SK) 4. Dist. 1 and Neck. Im. 14:36. 171 (w), 12, 53 and 14 (p). SHP: 85; THP: 47; FP: 220; Q: 178, Tanaka: 1,458. Favourite: Hanumanmaharaja. Owners: M/s. Balam Mohla, Kishore M. Diagra, Yara Prasad Reddy & Sultan Singh. Trainer: Neeraj Rawal.

Riders outclass Queens with all-round show

DPL Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

East Delhi Riders produced a disciplined all-round performance to defeat Central Delhi Queens by 19 runs in the women's leg of the Delhi Premier League at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Sunday.

Chasing 175, Queens were restricted to 155 for seven in 20 overs despite opener Deeksha Sharma scoring 86.

Earlier, Riders posted 174 for two after being asked to bat. Wicketkeeper Pragma Rawat led the way with an unbeaten 70 off 55 balls at No. 3, while Simran Bahadur provided the impetus to an unbeaten 60 that included seven fours and a six. The unbroken stand between Pragma and Simran for the third wicket was worth 118 runs. Opener Vanshika Lila offered a solid foundation by contributing 30.

The chase saw Deeksha take control. She struck



On song: East Delhi Riders' Pragma and Simran forged an unbeaten 118-run stand. SPECIAL ARRANGMENT

the ball cleanly throughout the boundary regularly. Despite her efforts, Riders managed to apply the brakes on the run rate with frequent breakthroughs.

Purva Siwach was the standout bowler for Riders, claiming four for 24 in her quota of four overs. Bharti Rawal provided ex-

cellent support with figures of two for 33, while Simran added a wicket after her noteworthy contribution with the willow.

Easy for Strikers

Outer Delhi Warriors all-rounder Harsh Tyagi excelled with bat and ball, but his unbeaten 54 and

three for 15 went in vain as North Delhi Strikers clinched a 39-run win in the men's section. Batting first, Strikers rode on Yash Bhatia's 53 to compile 166 for seven. Warriors were restricted to 127 for seven.

The scores: East Delhi Riders won 174/2 in 20 overs (Vanshika Lila 30, Pragma Rawat 70 n.o., Simran Bahadur 60 n.o.) bt Central Delhi Queens 155/7 in 20 overs (Deeksha Sharma 86, Purva Siwach 4/24, Bharti Rawal 2/33).

North Delhi Strikers 166/7 in 20 overs (Yash Bhatia 53, Kaushal Suman 33, Harsh Tyagi 3/15) bt Outer Delhi Warriors 127/7 in 20 overs (Harsh Tyagi 54 n.o., Parmit Tiwari 2/20, Prikshit Sehrawat 3/10).

LIVE TELECAST

Duleep Trophy: Quarterfinals, Day 2, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m. **Sri Lanka vs India:** Second Test, Day 2, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10 a.m.

Hockey World Cup: (Men) SS Select 2, Star Sports First & JioHotstar, 1 p.m.; Argentina vs India, 6:15 a.m. & 9:30 p.m. (Women) SS Select 2, Star Sports First & JioHotstar, 2:30 p.m., 5:30, 8:30 p.m. & 12 a.m. (Tuesday)

Double delight for Syndrela; Payas claims men's title

Amol Karhadkar
KANPUR

Syndrela Das marked her 17th birthday in style, claiming a double crown, while Payas Jain bounced back from the disappointment of losing the Commonwealth Championship final three weeks ago to headline the final day of the UTT National ranking table tennis on Sunday.

The results: Men: Final: Payas Jain (Del) bt Manav Thakkar (PSPB) 11-3, 9-11, 11-5, 12-10, 11-8.

Semifinals: Payas bt Jeet Chandra (PSPB) 11-8, 11-5, 11-8, 1-11, 11-7; Manav bt Ankur Bhattacharjee (Har) 12-10, 13-11, 11-9, 9-11, 11-8.

Women: Final: Syndrela Das (WB) bt Divyanshi Bhowmik (Mah) 9-11, 11-8, 11-8, 11-5, 11-7, 11-9. **Semifinals:** Divyanshi bt Yashaswini Ghoshale (PSPB) 11-4, 11-6, 11-4, 9-11, 11-2; Syndrela bt Swastika Ghosh (PSPB) 11-9, 5-11, 11-8, 8-11, 11-8, 8-11, 11-9.



Syndrela and Payas with their big reward. AMOL KARHADKAR

Youth (U-19): Boys: Final: Priyanshu Bhattacharjee (RSPB) bt Abhinand P.B. (TN) 9-11, 11-5, 11-3, 8-11, 21-23, 11-4, 11-7. **Semifinals:** Priyanshu bt Punish Bhaswa (WB) 11-7, 11-11, 11-3; Abhinand bt Saharab Mukherjee (WB) 12-10, 12-10, 11-9.

Girls: Final: Syndrela bt Ananya Muralidharan (TN) 11-8, 10-12, 11-9, 11-9, 11-4. **Semifinals:** Syndrela bt Nisha Rewaskar (Mah) 8-11, 11-9, 11-7, 11-7; Ananya bt Divyanshi Bhowmik (Mah) 11-5, 2-11, 11-7, 11-7.

When two is too few

Given that the World Test Championship has been in vogue since 2019 and there is no compulsion for teams to play more than two Tests, commercial considerations have driven most teams to stick to the bare minimum; however, a three-Test series is ideal as both teams are in with a shout even if they lose the first match

R. Kaushik
COLOMBO

Earlier this year, India celebrated the 25th anniversary of one of the most iconic Test series ever, a series like no other. On its own, it was a triumph of extraordinary proportions, but it meant even more from an overarching perspective because of the circumstances under which it was fashioned.

Indian cricket was ensnared in a mesh of shame and lack of trust after the match-fixing scandal broke out in 2000. The average fan had lost faith in their heroes, not knowing what was fact and what was make-believe. Without the patronage of the average fan, of course, no sport can even survive, let alone flourish.

To compound the woes of India's superstars and superstars-in-the-making, they were confronted within a few months of the lid being blown off corruption in the sport by the world's most formidable outfit at the time, a compelling force of the irresistible and the immovable. Steve Waugh's Australians were the gold standard of Test cricket, indeed of any form of cricket, when they arrived in India in early 2001, looking to conquer the Final Frontier that had proved insurmountable for nearly three and a half decades.

Waugh's warriors were sitting on a 15-Test winning streak when the teams lined up at Mumbai's Wankhede Stadium for the first of three matches. Within three days, they had extended their run to a record-equaling (their own record, lest it should be forgotten) 16 matches, blowing Sourav Ganguly's men away with a powerhouse performance with Glenn McGrath, Shane Warne, Matthew Hayden and Adam Gilchrist leading the way.

The primacy of Test cricket cannot be protected merely by paying lip service; it is incumbent upon every stakeholder involved in this wonderful sport to ensure that the longer version is thriving and vibrant

That Australian side was as formidable as any Test cricket has witnessed. India, outclassed by 10 wickets, were on a hiding to nothing. Their fans, disillusioned and morose, feared a chastening, humbling, humiliating 3-0 rout, a fear that grew exponentially after India

were shot out for just 171 in the first innings of the next Test at the Eden Gardens in reply to the visitors' 445.

Not even the fact that Harbhajan Singh had become the first Indian to take a Test hat-trick on the opening day of the match provided any solace as India began their second innings, 274 runs in arrears and facing another loss. Their three team scores at that point were 176, 219 and 171. Where was the light at the end of the tunnel? Did the tunnel even end?

Then began the mother of all fightbacks, a bounce-back of unprecedented magnitude and impact. The decision to thrust V.V.S. Laxman to No. 3 as he swapped places with incumbent Rahul Dravid, who dropped down to No. 6, turned out to be a masterstroke, a call that impacted not just the Test and the series, but also the way teams viewed the follow on and the way teams viewed the Indian side, which now felt that no situation was too daunting, no task was beyond them.

The Hyderabad with the wrists of steel and the Bengalurean with the heart of a champion joined hands in the first of several massive Test associations that would dot their careers. This one was worth 376 - savour that. They batted throughout the fourth day, and when Ganguly applied the closure on the final morning, only one team was in with a winning chance. With Harbhajan continuing his grand form and Sachin Tendulkar atoning for twin knocks of 10 with the scalps of Hayden, Gilchrist and Warne (with a ripping googly, no less),



Miracle men: The Eden Test of 2001 is a classic example of why a three-Test series is a must as India roared back to make it 1-1 and went on to win 2-1. FILE PHOTO: V.V. KRISHNAN

India romped home by the princely margin of 171 runs.

Dramatic turnaround

Just 72 hours previously, the dramatic turnaround wasn't even in the realms of fantasy. Through 281 and 180 and the office's six for 73 and the genius' three for 31, India pulled off a victory for the ages, a result that not just squared the series but also returned the confidence of the fans. Suddenly, cricket and cricketers weren't looked at askance. There was genuine hope and the realisation that this was a bunch of good men in whom faith and trust and belief could be invested without inhibition and doubt.

That was amplified in the next game in Chennai when, in another tight contest, India squeaked home by two wickets to close out a 2-1 victory, one of the most memorable in Test history. Even today, people talk in awe and with reverence of the deeds of Laxman and Dravid, of Tendulkar and Harbhajan, of Ganguly's captaincy, of the spirit and resolve of a bunch of warriors who could so easily have capitulated abjectly after the hammering in the first Test and the meltdown in the first innings of the second, but who refused steadfastly to roll over and who fashioned a miracle of extraordinary proportions.

Now, for a moment, think what it would have been like if it was only a two-Test series, like most are these days unless they involve two of England, Australia and India. Imagine if the series had ended in a 1-1 stalemate after India's epochal comeback at the Eden. If there was no winner only because there wasn't a third match pencilled in. A 1-1 scoreline with one of the Tests drawn is still acceptable but a 1-1 scoreline because a third game is unavailable leaves you with a sense of being deprived of the logical denouement that sport promises. And often delivers.

Think also what it would have been like had India's tour of Sri Lanka in 2015 been a two-Test affair, like it is this time around. At the time, India hadn't won a series in this country since 1993. It was Virat Kohli's first full tour as Test captain in his own right, following the retirement some seven months previously from the five-day game of Mahendra Singh Dhoni. The first Test was in Galle, as it generally is in Sri Lanka, and India ruled the exchanges for three whole days.

Enjoying a first-innings lead of 192, India did allow the hosts to pull away to 367 in their second innings from 95 for five on the back of a special 162 from Dinesh Chandimal, but even then, a fourth-innings target of 176 with more than two days to go was well within the reach of Kohli's lads, among whom were K.L. Rahul, Shikhar Dhawan, Rohit Sharma and Ajinkya Rahane. It seemed as if India had taken it for granted that they would get the job done when they resumed day four on 23 for the loss of Rahul's wicket. The end result - seven wickets for the indefatigable Rangana Herath, a 63-run shock win for the Lankans under Angelo Mathews.

That evening, the Indian dressing room shook with the reverberating aftershocks of the defeat. Harsh words were said, Kohli and then team director Ravi Shastri

read the riot act, and Indian cricket took a massively significant step towards erasing its tag of being lambs overseas. There was a sea change in attitude and team culture, which manifested in convincing victories in the next two games and a fabulous 2-1 triumph that was the genesis of the six-match winning streak on which the team is currently sitting in this nation. Now, what if that had been a two-Test series? How would Indian cricket have shaped up?

"Ideally, I would want a three-Test series," Gautam Gambhir, the India head coach, agreed ahead of the ongoing second Test in Colombo. "I've always believed that there should always be a possibility that a team that loses in the first Test should have the chance to come back. Sometimes, what happens is, in a two-Test match series, if you lose the first Test match, there is no chance for the other team to come back and win the series. The maximum you can do is to try and draw the series.

"I still remember that series, between India and Australia (2001), where India was one down, and they still managed to come back, and win that series 2-1."

Given that the World Test Championship has been in vogue since 2019 and there is no compulsion for teams to play more than two Tests, commercial considerations have driven most teams to stick to the bare minimum. There is a greater demand for T20 Internationals, which is right now the goose that lays the golden eggs, and therefore two-Test showdowns have become the norm. Why, one of the unfounded criticisms against South Africa's march to the WTC final (and eventually the title) last year was that they had shaped their success around two-match faceoffs. That was an unkind cut, because South Africa did what they had to do within the ambit of the rules as they exist. But a greater standardisation of series will help ward off such loose talk, something Arjuna Ranatunga, the legendary Sri Lankan skipper who took the team to the 1996 World Cup crown, strongly espouses.

"For me, playing a Test tournament is not the criterion, it's all about playing bilateral Test matches, playing three- and five-Test series," Ranatunga told this writer a few days back.

"What's this two-Test series about anyway? It's so unfortunate, this World Test Championship is (just) another commercial venture."

Cricket calendars are already packed, with ICC events thrown in every alternate year, be it the T20 World Cup or its 50-over counterpart that still drives the sport despite the dwindling popularity of bilateral ODIs. Then, there are continental events such as the Asia Cup, which also make demands on the Asian Test-playing nations of whom there are five (though only four are involved in the WTC). All of these also contribute a great deal to ensuring that three-Test series become rare as hen's teeth, but as much as the problem might appear insurmountable, there is nothing that will and desire and the urge to put one's money where the mouth is can't achieve.

The primacy of Test cricket cannot be protected merely by paying lip service; it is incumbent upon every stakeholder involved in this wonderful sport to ensure that the longer version is thriving and vibrant, though no one can apportion any blame to the protagonists if they are not as fascinated by the tugs and pulls, the ebbs and flows, of Test cricket, as several others are.

Australia versus Bangladesh is the classic example of the power of the three-match contest. Just imagine the interest levels that would have accompanied the decider after Goliath fought back to quash David's impunity in winning the first Test. Now, we can only think of what might have been. Unfinished business, unfulfilled promise...

THE GIST

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Gambhir has batted for three-Test series. PTI

SCIENCE

Global space norms find a firm footing in India's new re-entry rules

For many decades, there were few rocket launches and few new satellites in orbit every year, so there were also few re-entries, and most of them simply burned up in the atmosphere with little consequence; but today, low-earth orbit hosts several thousand satellites, with private companies planning for many, many more

Shrawani Shagun

On August 23, India marked its third National Space Day, three years since the Chandrayaan-3 mission's lunar lander 'Vikram' touched down on the moon's south pole region.

Between then and Hyderabad-based Skyroot Aerospace launching India's first privately built rocket to orbit, India has come a long way – even as it is also just beginning to regulate the responsibilities that follow from expanding its orbital footprint.

As part of this endeavour, and days after the success of Vikram-1, the Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACE) released the country's first guidelines on planned re-entry.

A sustainability problem

For many decades, there were few rocket launches and few new satellites in orbit every year, so there were also few re-entries, and most of them simply burned up in the atmosphere with little consequence. But today, low-earth orbit hosts several thousand satellites, with private companies planning for many, many more. Satellite operators are also deliberately bringing satellites down at the end of their operational lives as part of post-mission disposal in great numbers.

A spacecraft returning to the earth has to negotiate many risks, including deviating from its planned path and breaking up into smaller pieces. It may also affect airspace and maritime zones and potentially crash in the territory or jurisdiction of another state.

Here, the idea of sustainability is important. The UN Guidelines for the Long-term Sustainability of Outer Space Activities define 'sustainability' as maintaining space activities while preserving the outer space environment for future generations. In this context, re-entry poses a question: how can an increasingly crowded orbital environment remain usable as more objects are launched, operated, and eventually brought back to the earth?

Therefore, re-entry is a physics problem as well as a governance problem. And the new IN-SPACE guidelines are intended to give Indian operators clarity on how the Indian government expects them to solve these problems.

'Conditions of permission'

The guidelines have three important elements.

(i) **Accountability** – Any Indian entity undertaking a planned re-entry, whether within or outside Indian territory, now requires the IN-SPACE's authorisation. Non-Indian entities seeking to undertake



GSLV Mk-III rocket carries the Crew Module Atmospheric Re-entry Experiment (CARE) on a suborbital flight after lifting off from Sriharikota in 2015. FILE PHOTO

planned re-entry over Indian territory must route the activity through an Indian-incorporated entity, such as a subsidiary, joint venture or partnership, which will be responsible for complying with Indian laws, regulations, and national security requirements.

This has been done because commercialisation creates an accountability gap: i.e. the spacecraft may belong to a private company but the consequences of its return can lie across maritime zones, and jurisdictions. And India has responded by attaching regulatory responsibility to a re-entering entity even before the risk materialises.

Objects designed to survive re-entry or intentionally controlled towards a particular landing or impact area also require separate authorisation. This is what makes a re-entry 'planned'. On the other hand, objects expected to burn up, melt or fragment sufficiently during natural orbital decay do not count as a planned re-entry.

(ii) **Risk must be acceptable** – The guidelines say the expected casualty risk must remain below 1 in 10,000, supported by survivability and ground-casualty assessments.

As a result, operators have to analyse failure scenarios, fragmentation patterns, ballistic coefficients, de-orbit plans, flight-path angles, and danger zones, and share the results. They must also identify components likely to survive re-entry and hazardous systems such as batteries and pressure vessels.

By requiring quantitative studies and attaching a number to the acceptable risk threshold, the guidelines make sustainability measurable and thus trackable.

(iii) **Permissions** – Per the guidelines, IN-SPACE will re-verify the latest re-entry parameters approximately three months before the proposed operation. If planned re-entry is decided upon after launch, the operator must apply at least six months in advance. Operators must also obtain an IN-SPACE advisory note to issue warnings to airborne and marine vessels in the re-entry area at least 45 days before the re-entry begins.

If a re-entry site falls within the territorial control of a non-Indian state, including in its exclusive economic zones, the applicant must also submit the relevant clearance or authorisation from that state.

These checkpoints ensure that the regulator has fixed windows and mechanisms to intervene when the re-entry parameters change after the mission has launched or the risk pattern has changed for some reason.

Soft law to domestic rule

For nearly two decades, the international community has developed principles for sustainable space activities. Notable among them are the Inter-Agency Space Debris Coordination Committee's 'Space Debris Mitigation Guidelines' and the 'Guidelines for the Long-term Sustainability of Outer Space Activities' of

the U.N. Committee for the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space. Article IX of the Outer Space Treaty 1967 also provides an important foundation for environmental responsibility.

However, most of the contemporary sustainability architecture works on guidelines and other similar forms of 'soft law', which operators are not obligated to follow.

The IN-SPACE guidelines solve this problem for India by tying an operator's fragmentation analysis and insurance policies to the national regulator.

The guidelines also address the financial risks that follow from the Space Liability Convention 1972, which places absolute liability on a launching state for damage caused by its space object on the surface of the earth or to aircraft in flight.

The IN-SPACE guidelines, on the other hand, require operators to undertake planned re-entries at their own risk and say they remain liable for third-party damage and claims. They also indemnify the Government of India and its agencies for liability incurred under India's international commitments while satisfying the applicable third-party insurance requirements.

Taken together, the IN-SPACE guidelines translate international principles into obligations that private operators in India must satisfy before the government gives them permission to act. (Shrawani Shagun is a researcher focusing on environmental sustainability and space governance. shrawani.shagun@gmail.com)

THE GIST

A spacecraft returning to the earth has to navigate several risks. It could affect airspace and maritime zones, or even crash within the territory or jurisdiction of another state. This makes sustainability an important consideration

Days after the success of Vikram-1, IN-SPACE released the country's first guidelines for planned re-entry

The current international principles for sustainable space activities are soft laws that need not be followed by the operator

The IN-SPACE guidelines solve this problem for India by tying an operator's fragmentation analysis and insurance policies to the national regulator

BIG SHOT



A crocodile rests on the edge of a domestic compound now almost completely inundated in the rising waters of the Lake Bogoria in Baringo, Kenya. Lake Baringo and other lakes in Kenya's Rift Valley have risen to levels not seen in half a century, with scientists attributing the surge to extreme rainfall. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

Barren-land fallacy

Vasudevan Mukunth

Trees provide many benefits, including helping cool the neighbourhood, keeping soil from getting eroded, drawing carbon from the environment and storing it, and supporting many birds, small animals, and insects. However, these effects are beneficial only when trees are in the right ecosystem; otherwise, they can be harmful.

The barren-land fallacy is the idea that land that does not have tree cover is barren land, thus ecologically deficient, and that it will 'evolve' or should be helped to 'evolve' into a forest. The tree-planting drives that happen in India often perpetuate this fallacy by planting trees in the wrong ecosystems. They often also plant trees that are unsuitable for the local conditions, e.g. eucalyptus trees – which draw a lot of water – in a water-stressed area.

Forests are only one kind of ecosystem. Others include grasslands, savannah, scrubland, wetlands, and deserts, plus many naturally open ecosystems. As University of California professor of history and geography Diana Davis has written, "The assumption that the world's drylands are worthless, deforested, and overgrazed landscapes has led ... to programs and policies that have often systematically damaged dryland environments".

To ecologically restore a place does not always mean planting more trees.



The Sahel region in Mali is a semi-desert landscape. TIMM GUENTHER (CC BY-SA)

Instead, it is to do whatever will protect or restore the ecosystem that would naturally occur there. In the same vein, planting trees or regenerating forests is only valuable where forests have been degraded or cleared and where a forest is the native ecosystem.

For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Daily page'